IIM KOZHIKODE · BMS-01 · SEMESTER III · WORLD AND INDIAN HISTORY (DR. JAYATI BHATTACHARYA)

Mid-term Study Guide Sessions 1–4 and 6–11

One complete resource built from every reading and lecture PPT on the syllabus. It assumes you know nothing yet, explains every concept from scratch, and organises everything in the order the course teaches it.

WHAT IS COVERED

S1 Why Study History (Hobsbawm)
S2 Historical Methods, Sources & Practices (Lange; Backerra)
S3 Global & Regional Histories (Hall)
S4 Indian Schools of Historical Thought (Sreedharan)
S6 India through Foreign Travellers (Tansen Sen; M.S. Khan)
S7 Baghdad to Canton (Bernstein)
S8 Silk Route Connections I (Hansen; J. Bhattacharya)
S9 Silk Route Connections II (Tansen Sen)
S10 Religions in India (Madan; Guy; H.P. Ray)
S11 Indian Ocean as a Connected Space (Chaudhuri; T. Roy)

EXAM AT A GLANCE

Closed book · 50 marks · 2 hours
A 10 MCQs × 0.5 = 5 marks
B Short answers: any 3 of 5 × 10 = 30 marks
C Essay: any 1 of 2–3 × 15 = 15 marks

Session 5 is **not** examined.
Write in paragraphs, not bullets. Name people, dates, scholars and examples.

Compiled from the course outline, the Lecture 16 revision slides, the Session 1–11 PPTs and the prescribed readings uploaded to this repository. Where a reading was not uploaded (Hobsbawm's *On History* ch. 3; Hall ch. 8), the lecture slides are the source.

How to use this guide

Read in this order

1. **Pages 2–6 (this front section):** the exam format, the professor's model answers, the course "story" and the two master timelines. This gives you the skeleton.
2. **Sessions 1–11 in order.** Each session opens with a *Where this fits* box, then teaches the content, then ends with a *Summary* and an *Exam corner*.
3. **The final section** covers cross-session themes, a who's-who, a glossary, practice MCQs with answers, short-answer and essay outlines, and a one-page last-night sheet.

Priority labels

MUST KNOW

Core exam material. It is likely to appear as a short or essay question, so learn the argument and the examples.

SUPPORTING

Concepts, examples and scholars that strengthen an answer or answer an MCQ.

BACKGROUND

Context or detail. Read it once; you don't need to memorise it.

PROF: MAY SKIP

Passages highlighted in the reading as "may leave out" (J. Bhattacharya's article only).

Colour-coded boxes

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS
Links the topic to the course's big argument.

IN PLAIN WORDS
A jargon-free explanation of a difficult idea.

CORE ARGUMENT (MUST KNOW)
The thesis you must be able to reproduce.

EXAMPLES & EVIDENCE
Names, dates and cases that earn marks.

SUMMARY
The session in a few lines, for revision.

EXAM CORNER
Likely questions with answer skeletons.

What the examiner wants (from Lecture 16: Revisions)

PROFESSOR'S GUIDELINES

- Read the question carefully; it guides you to the desired answer.
- Match length to marks. Make a rough sketch of points first.
- Write a proper **introduction** and **conclusion**.
- Write short, clear **paragraphs, not bullet points**.
- Examples of **people, events, dates, scholars, methods and publications** "will enhance your writing".
- There is no fixed word count. Marks depend on **content, language and presentation**.

A RELIABLE ANSWER TEMPLATE (10 MARKS)

1. **Intro (2–3 lines):** define the key term and state your thesis.
2. **Body:** 3–4 paragraphs, each with one idea, the scholar or reading behind it, and a concrete example.
3. **Complication:** one paragraph of critique or limits (examiners reward balance).
4. **Conclusion:** answer the question directly and link it to the course's big theme (connectivity, scale, uses of the past).

Model short answer given in class MUST KNOW

Q. Why is it important to distinguish between religious doctrines and lived religious practices in understanding religion in India? *(The professor's model answer, condensed. Notice the structure: definition → Islam example → Kashmir/Rishi example → Hinduism → Christianity → conclusion.)*

MODEL ANSWER (CONDENSED)

Formal teachings do not by themselves determine how religion is experienced. Traditions provide beliefs, texts, rituals and principles, but these are **interpreted and adapted within particular social and cultural contexts**.

Islam in India: it has universal principles (one God, the Qur'an, prayer, fasting, charity, pilgrimage), yet Indian Muslims lived in a society with established traditions, so Islamic practice acquired distinctive regional and cultural characteristics. They shared Islam's universal foundations while being shaped by geography, language and social circumstances.

Kashmir: Islam spread there not only by transmitting doctrine but by adapting to existing practice. The **Rishi order of Nuruddin** incorporated familiar elements of Kashmiri religious life, such as **vegetarianism and concern for animals**. A tradition can take local forms without losing its broader identity.

Hinduism: the Brahmanical textual tradition differs from local and popular ritual. Brahmanical ideas were incorporated into local traditions and popular religion entered wider Hindu practice, producing great variation and diversity.

Christianity: converts did not abandon their earlier identities. Communities retained pre-conversion beliefs, social attitudes and ritual practices.

Conclusion: studying religion requires attention to how people interpret, negotiate and practise teachings in everyday life. Lived religion shows how caste, region, culture and historical experience shape religious expression.

Model essay plan given in class MUST KNOW

Q. Evaluate the claim that the shift from colonial and nationalist history to Marxist "new history" represented a major advance in historical understanding.

PROFESSOR'S ESSAY GUIDELINE (CONDENSED)

1. **Introduce** the historiographical schools of Indian history briefly and connect them to the question.
2. Colonial and nationalist writing focused on **civilisational judgements, political narratives and identity arguments**. Marxist history redirected attention to **economy, society, class and material life**.
3. **Advance 1, a shift away from elite-centred narrative:** from rulers, dynasties, decline or national greatness to peasants, labour, land systems, production relations and social hierarchy.
4. **Advance 2, explanation:** events are not isolated episodes or moral lessons; causes are sought in material structures and social relations.
5. **Advance 3, correcting nationalist weaknesses:** where nationalists used the past to foster pride, Marxists exposed inequality, conflict and contradiction within Indian society.
6. **Critique:** Marxist history could become rigid when class was the "master explanation". Culture, religion, region and ideas could be undervalued as mere reflections of the economy.
7. **Layered revision:** earlier phases should not be dismissed wholesale. Marxists built on them, and understanding advances by layered revision, not total replacement.
8. **Conclusion:** a major advance (broader evidence, sharper explanation, deeper processes), but one stage in an evolving historiography, not the final form.

The story of the course: how the ten sessions connect

THE BIG PICTURE IN ONE PARAGRAPH

The course first asks **why and how we study history**: the past is socially used (Hobsbawm, S1); historians use methods and criticise sources (Lange, Backerra, S2); history can be studied at local, regional, national and global scales (Hall, S3); and Indian history itself has been written by different "schools", each with its own agenda (S4). It then applies these tools to **India's place in a connected world**: what foreign travellers saw and how reliable they are (S6); how the Indian Ocean linked Baghdad to Canton with India at the centre (S7); how "Silk Roads" were plural, overland and maritime, and how the past is reused today (S8–S9); how religions travelled and changed along these routes (S10); and how the Indian Ocean can be theorised as one connected but uneven space (S11).

Part A · Thinking historically
S1 Uses of the past
S2 Methods & sources
S3 Scale: global vs regional
S4 Schools of Indian history

→

Part B · Seeing India from outside
S6 Chinese pilgrims & Arab scholars (sources and their bias)

→

Part C · Connectivity
S7 Baghdad–Canton sea trade
S8 Silk Roads I (Chang'an; Bengal)
S9 Silk Roads II (maritime Buddhism)

→

Part D · Synthesis
S10 Religions: plural, lived, mobile
S11 Indian Ocean as connected space

Five threads that run through every session (use them in essays)

1 · Sources are never neutral

Every source has an author, purpose and audience. Hobsbawm (selective pasts), Backerra (source criticism), foreign travellers (bias), Mill (misused sources), Chinese pilgrims (Buddhist lens), Shahrastani (secondary sources).

2 · Scale changes the story

City, region, nation, ocean, globe. Hall (multiple globalizations); Vasco da Gama at three scales; Hansen (city) vs Bhattacharya (region); Chaudhuri (unity in the large, disunity in the small).

3 · Connection, not isolation

India as producer, intermediary and cultural conduit: Gujarati and Tamil merchants, monks on merchant ships, Nalanda–Srivijaya links, Malacca. Europe entered an *already connected* world.

4 · Centres and peripheries are made

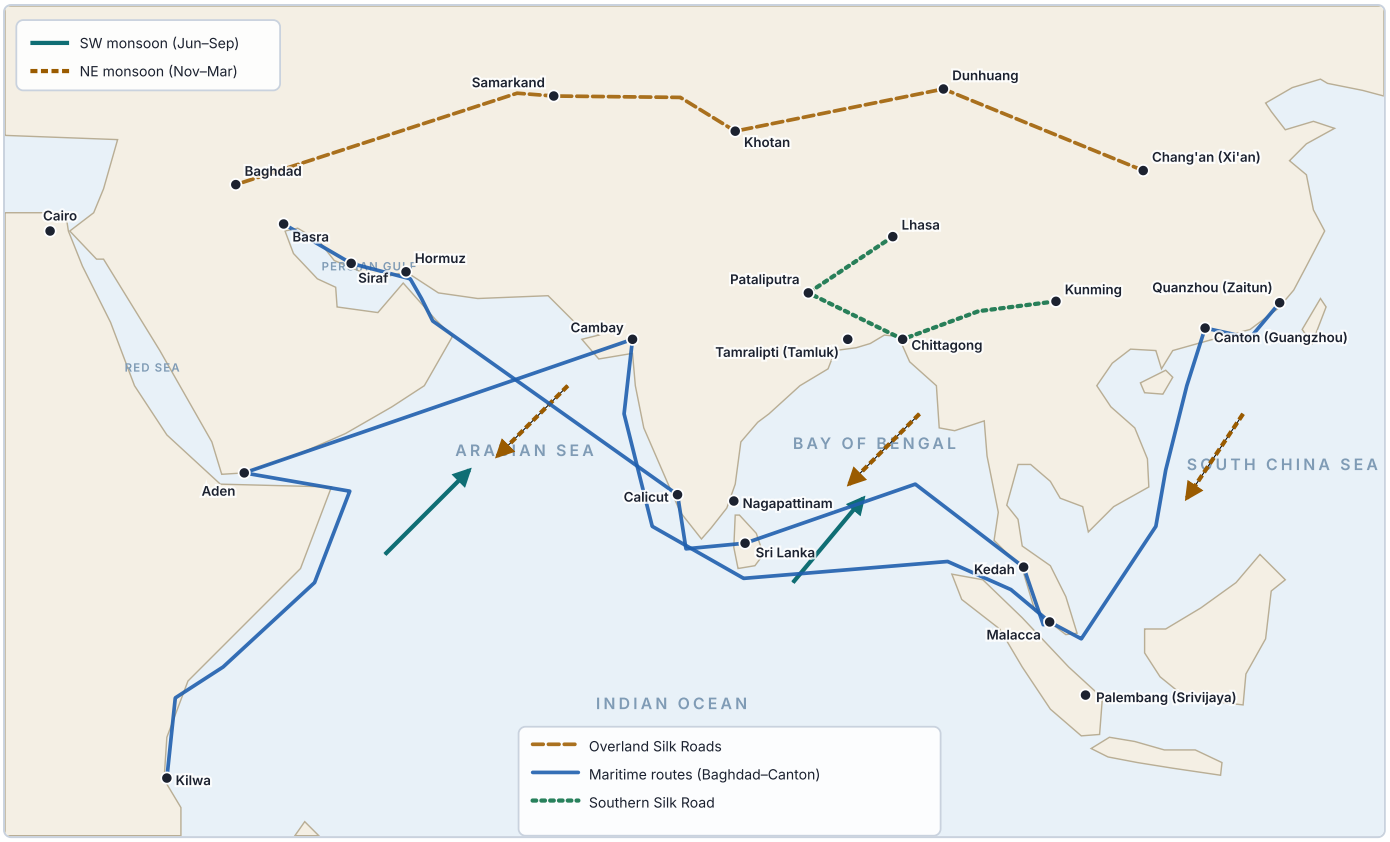
Chang'an's cosmopolitanism depended on "outsiders"; Bengal and Yunnan were labelled peripheral but were central; Southeast Asia was not just a transit zone forever; Sri Lanka was more than "Theravada".

5 · The past is used in the present

Hobsbawm's invented traditions → nationalist historiography → BRI, Act East, BCIM and BIMSTEC invoking the "Silk Road". Are we reviving or inventing connectivity?

6 · Trade and religion move together

Merchants carried monks, relics and texts; monasteries hosted traders; Islam as commercial law; Hindu temples built by Tamil guilds in Takuapa and Quanzhou; conversion followed commerce.



The connected world of this course (schematic). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Master timeline A: the connected history of India and Asia

Dates that appear in the readings. Red dots are the most exam-worthy.

c.2600–1900 BCE — Harappan (Indus) civilisation: urban religion, "great bath" (Madan).

c.1500 BCE — Aryan-speaking peoples enter north-west India (the "generally accepted view", Madan).

≤1200 BCE — Rig Veda composed.

c.600–400 BCE — Early Upanishads; Buddha (c.563–483) and Mahavira (c.599–527).

4th c. BCE — Megasthenes, Greek envoy, describes India.

c.325 BCE — Chandragupta Maurya = "Sandrocottas": the **sheet anchor** of Indian chronology (Jones).

c.270–232 BCE — Ashoka; Buddhism reaches Sri Lanka.

1st c. CE — Buddhism reaches China; Funan emerges; Indo-Roman pepper trade; Kushans link Central Asia and India.

3rd c. CE — Kang Senghui (Sogdian monk) via Jiaozhi to Nanjing; Guangzhou becomes a Buddhist centre.

late 4th c. — Kutei *yupa* inscriptions (Borneo): the earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia.

399–413 — Faxian: overland to India, returns by sea via Sri Lanka and Java.

c.450 — Purnavarman inscription (West Java); Buddhagupta inscription, Kedah (5th c.).

589 / 618 — Sui reunify China; Tang dynasty founded with its capital at Chang'an.

622 — Hijra: the starting point of Chaudhuri's Indian Ocean period.

627–645 — Xuanzang's pilgrimage; he meets Harshavardhana at Kanauj (637/8).

635 — Aluohan brings the Church of the East (Nestorian) to Chang'an.

671–695 — Yijing travels by sea and studies in Srivijaya (7th–13th c. polity).

712 — Arab conquest of Sind.

750 — Abbasids move the caliphate's centre to Baghdad: "no obstacle between us and China".

755–763 — An Lushan rebellion; anti-Sogdian violence in Tang China.

c.810–847 — Pala king Devapala grants villages to Balaputradeva's monastery at Nalanda.

843 / 845 — Tang bans on Manichaeism, then on Buddhism, Zoroastrianism and Christianity.

c.851 — *Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind*: the Basra–Canton route.

877/878 — Huang Chao sacks Canton, killing c.120,000 foreigners.

10th c. — *Book of the Marvels of India* (Buzurg ibn Shahriyar).

1005 — Cudamanivihara at Nagapattinam, built for the Srivijaya king under Chola patronage.

1012–c.1025 — Atisa studies in Suvarnadvipa (Sumatra); goes to Tibet c.1040–42.

1015; 1026/1068 — First Chola mission to China; Chola raids on Srivijaya.

1088 — Barus (Sumatra) Tamil inscription of the Ainnurruvar guild.

973–1048 — Al-Biruni (visited India, learned Sanskrit).

d.1153 — Al-Shahrastani, *Kitab al-Milal wa al-Nihal*, describes Indian religions without visiting India.

1258 — Mongols (Hulagu) sack Baghdad; c.1260–1360 "Pax Mongolica" on the Silk Road.

1281 — Tamil–Chinese Shiva temple inscription at Quanzhou.

c.1292 — Marco Polo dictates his *Travels* to Rustichello.

1325–1354 — Ibn Battuta's travels; Muhammad bin Tughluq rules Delhi (1325–51).

c.1400 — Parameswara founds Malacca.

1405–1433 — Zheng He's seven treasure-fleet voyages.

1498 — Vasco da Gama reaches Calicut, guided by a Gujarati pilot.

1511– — Tomé Pires, *Suma Oriental*; Portuguese take Malacca (1511).

1600 / 1602 — English East India Company / Dutch VOC founded.

c.1640–1690 — English presidency towns: Madras (c.1640), Bombay (c.1660), Calcutta (c.1690).

1707 — Death of Aurangzeb; Mughal decline.

1757 / 1764 Plassey / Buxar. Chaudhuri's period ends with Plassey.

1813 Company's monopoly charter ends.

1877 Richthofen coins "Silk Road".

1905 / 1947 Partitions of Bengal.

1962 Sino-Indian war: borders close old routes.

1990s / 2014 India's Look East policy / Act East policy.

2013 China's Belt and Road Initiative (Xi Jinping).

Master timeline B: who wrote Indian history, and when

1764 / 1783 Robert Orme's first British histories of India; Gladwin's *History of Hindustan*.

1784 William Jones founds the **Asiatic Society of Bengal**, with Warren Hastings as patron.

1786 / 1793 Jones: the Indo-European language family; Sandrocottas = Chandragupta.

1818 James Mill, *The History of British India* (utilitarian condemnation); a textbook at Haileybury 1805–55.

1834 James Prinsep deciphers Ashokan Brahmi.

1841 Elphinstone, *History of Hindu and Muhammadan India*, a sympathetic counter to Mill.

1861–1871 Cunningham and the Archaeological Survey; the first British census (1871, lecture).

1867–77 Elliot & Dowson, *History of India as Told by its own Historians*.

1868 Droysen, *Historik*: heuristic, source analysis, interpretation, presentation.

1889–1923 R.C. Dutt (*Civilization in Ancient India*, 1889; *Economic History*, 1904); V.A. Smith (1904); Jayaswal's *Hindu Polity* (1918); Raychaudhuri (1923).

1949 Braudel, *The Mediterranean*: *longue durée*.

1956–65 D.D. Kosambi: the Marxist "new history" (*Introduction to the Study of Indian History*, 1956).

1960s–80s Cambridge School (Seal, Gallagher, Johnson, Bayly); R.S. Sharma, Thapar, Irfan Habib, Bipan Chandra.

1972 / 1974 Hobsbawm, "Social Function of the Past"; Wallerstein, *The Modern World-System*.

1978 / 1982 Said, *Orientalism*; Ranajit Guha, *Subaltern Studies* vol. 1.

1989–1993 Abu-Lughod; Frank & Gills (5,000-year system); K.N. Chaudhuri (*Asia Before Europe* 1990; JWH 1993).

2012–2024 Hansen *Silk Road* (2012); Lange (2013); Hall (2014); T. Roy (2012); J. Bhattacharya (2021); Backerra (2024).

SESSION 1

Why Study History? Relevance, Impact and Significance

Readings: E.J. Hobsbawm, "The Social Function of the Past: Some Questions", *Past & Present* 55 (1972), pp. 3–17 (OT1) · Hobsbawm, *On History* (1997), ch. 3 "What Can History Tell Us About Contemporary Society?" (R1, covered in the PPT)

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

This is the foundation of the course. Before studying *what* happened in India and Asia, you need to understand **why** people care about the past and **how** they use it. Hobsbawm shows that every society uses its past: to stay the same, to justify change, to claim legitimacy, to build identity. Later sessions apply this directly: nationalist historians "using" ancient India (S4), modern states using the "Silk Road" to justify BRI and Act East (S8–S9), and selective memories of religion (S10). **Exam tip:** Hobsbawm is the easiest scholar to cite in an essay about the uses of history, nationalism or the present-day politics of the past.

1.1 Who is Hobsbawm and why does he matter? SUPPORTING

- **Eric J. Hobsbawm** (Birkbeck College, London) was one of the most influential historians of the twentieth century.
- He is associated with **Marxist historiography**, and is one of the sharpest thinkers about the broader uses of history in modern societies.
- He wrote about **class, nationalism, capitalism, revolution, empire and modernity**.
- His key insight for us: **interest in the past is organised into meaning**. He helps us see how facts, memories, traditions and narratives are *socially mobilised*.
- The 1972 essay began as a paper at the 1970 *Past and Present* conference on "The Sense of the Past and History". It deliberately raises **questions** rather than giving final answers ("It is easier to formulate questions than answers").

1.2 The core argument (1972) MUST KNOW

CORE ARGUMENT

"The past is a permanent dimension of the human consciousness, an inevitable component of the institutions, values and other patterns of human society."

- Everyone is conscious of the past (defined as the period *before* what an individual directly remembers) simply because we live with people older than ourselves.
- Every society has a past. Even the most "innovatory colonies" are populated by people from societies with long histories.
- To belong to any community is to position yourself in relation to its past, **even if only by rejecting it**.
- So the real question is not *whether* societies have a past but **how they use it**: as a source of authority, a moral guide, a political weapon, a marker of identity, or a framework for understanding change.
- The historian's job is **to analyse the nature of this "sense of the past" in society and to trace its changes and transformations**. The past is not just inherited; it is **socially organised and functionally used**.

> *"We swim in the past as fish do in water, and cannot escape from it. But our modes of living and moving in this medium require analysis and discussion."*
>
> Hobsbawm, concluding lines (1972)

1.3 The three ways a society relates to its past MUST KNOW

This is the heart of the essay and a favourite exam topic: **distinguish the past as pattern, as model, and as process**.

1 · Past as PATTERN
Traditional societies. Each generation *copies* the previous one, almost automatically. "This is how things have always been done."

→

2 · Past as MODEL
When change accelerates beyond a point, the past can no longer be reproduced automatically, so it is *consciously invoked, selected and adapted* : "we ought to return to the ways of our forefathers".

→

3 · Past as PROCESS
Modern societies accept constant change ("progress"). The past legitimises the present as a *process of becoming* : history as development or evolution.

(a) The past as PATTERN: traditional societies

- For most of history, societies treated the past as the **pattern for the present**. Ideally each generation copies its predecessor and sees itself as *falling short* when it fails to.
- Inherited ways (customs, ancestral authority, sacred texts, old law) are treated as **norms**. History here is **not a story of development** but a **reservoir of precedent and legitimacy**.
- Examples of the past as a stabilising norm: family structures, village customs, religious law, inherited land rights. In illiterate societies, "law equals custom"; old documents gain spiritual authority. A community may base its claim to common lands on old possession, or even on colonial-era court decisions, which are valued as records of a past that is a *charter for the present*.

> **IN PLAIN WORDS: "TRADITIONAL SOCIETIES ARE NOT STATIC" (A KEY CORRECTION)**
>
> Hobsbawm says the idea that traditional society is static and unchanging is **"a myth of vulgar social science"**. Change does happen, but it is absorbed in ways that do not openly challenge tradition. Change can be: **gradual**; **concealed**; **renamed** (new wine poured into old bottles, e.g. nomads "dealing in" lorries as an extension of dealing in camels); or **absorbed into inherited forms** by "stretching" the framework, through myth or ritualised history.
> **How innovation happens without breaking tradition:** (1) the official "past" is always a *selection* from everything remembered, so it has **interstices** (gaps) where innovation can occur unnoticed; (2) technology is often the most flexible area: tradition-bound peasants accepted horses or new weapons without any sense of breaking with the past; (3) radical innovation can be legitimised only by disguising it as a **return** to a forgotten past, or by an **anti-historical higher principle** such as a religious revelation or prophecy.
> **Tradition is strong not because it blocks all change, but because it can absorb change without seeming to surrender its authority.**

- This kind of traditionalism implies a **slow rate of change**. Where change is too fast it survives only through isolation (e.g. the **Amish** in the USA), or absorbs single drastic steps at great psycho-social cost (e.g. the **forced conversion of Mexican Indians to Catholicism** after the Spanish conquest).
- "What has always been done" for Bulgarian peasants in 1850 was very different from earlier centuries, yet they still felt traditional.
- Dominance of the past is compatible with **cyclical** views and with **regression/catastrophe**. What it is **incompatible with is the idea of continuous progress**.

(b) When the past stops being a pattern: the past as MODEL

- When social change accelerates beyond a certain point, the past "must cease to be the pattern of the present, and can at best become the **model** for it".
- **Crucial difference:** a *pattern* is reproduced almost automatically; a *model* is **consciously invoked, selected, interpreted and adapted**.
- The past now becomes a **"mask for innovation"**: calls to restore it actually produce something new.

- **Key insight:** the moment a society starts **loudly calling for restoration is often the moment when continuity has already broken down**. The past moves from *lived tradition* to a *conscious reference point*.

(c) Restoration and invention MUST KNOW

Hobsbawm is sceptical of the language of "restoration" because it is **rarely literal**. It always involves **selection, reconstruction or reinvention**.

> **EXAMPLE: ZAPATA AND MORELOS (MEXICO)**
>
> The peasant movement of Morelos under **Zapata** tried to restore society to what it had been forty years earlier, before the era of Porfirio Díaz. It **failed to restore the past literally**: (1) it involved reconstructing what could not be accurately remembered (e.g. precise boundaries of disputed common lands) and imagining "what ought to have been"; (2) the hated innovation was not "a bullet lodged in the flesh" that could be surgically removed but part of a wider social change; (3) the effort mobilised forces with far greater effects. The peasants became a revolutionary power and the attempt to turn the clock back **became a social revolution** that helped produce "a historically unprecedented new Mexico". (Hobsbawm draws on John Womack's biography of Zapata, 1969.)

Type	Meaning	Examples from Hobsbawm
Effective restoration	Tries to **re-establish actual practices, institutions or structures**.	Calls to restore old morality or "old-time religion" (ideally everyone attends church); 19th-c. British radical hopes of returning to small peasant proprietorship.
Symbolic restoration	Recovers **emotional, political or cultural meaning** rather than the actual social world. Often what people want back, such as "greatness" or "freedom", is too vast and vague for literal restoration.	Rebuilding the bombed fabric of **Warsaw** after WWII; pulling down the **Stalin monument in Prague**; **Churchill's** insistence on literally restoring the **Parliament** building (partly practical, partly "magic": restoring a part to restore the whole).

Interpretation is therefore needed to assess **innovations that claim the authority of antiquity**.

(d) The past as artefact or fabrication MUST KNOW

- If the past invoked is **remote enough**, it becomes little more than a language for expressing present aspirations. It may turn into an **artefact** or, "in less flattering terms, a **fabrication**".
- Such a past is **weakly connected to historical reality** but politically useful, because it can be **selectively organised into a story that legitimises the present**.
- **Traditions may be recent, even constructed, yet powerful** because they claim continuity with something older. **Invented pasts can have very real effects.**

EXAMPLES OF REMOTE OR FABRICATED PASTS

- The **"Free Anglo-Saxons before the Norman Yoke"**, and **"Merrie England"** before the Reformation (used by English radicals, 17th–19th c., mainly as explanatory devices).
- The **"Charlemagne" metaphor**, used since Napoleon I for schemes of European unity, though nobody wants to recreate 8th–9th-century Europe.
- The name **"Ghana"** transfers the history of one part of Africa to another, geographically remote and historically different.
- The **Zionist** claim to return to the pre-diaspora past in Israel was in practice the *negation* of 2,000 years of actual Jewish history.
- **Nationalist movements** are the clearest case: in Renan's words, nations "get their history wrong". Their objectives are unprecedented, yet they define them historically, especially **territorial claims** and **deliberate archaism** (Welsh neo-druids, Hebrew revived as a spoken secular language, the Nazi *Ordensburgen*). These are not revivals but **"innovations using or purporting to use elements of a historic past, real or imaginary"**. "History is the most easily worked raw material" for manufacturing nations.
- **Contrast:** attempts in genuinely traditional societies to restore remote regimes are meant **literally**, e.g. Peruvian peasant risings (to the 1920s) to restore the **Inca Empire**, or Chinese movements to restore the **Ming**. For Peruvian peasants the Incas were "yesterday"; to apply chronology to them "is to introduce anachronism".

(e) Innovation, progress and modernity: the past as PROCESS MUST KNOW

- Systematic rejection of the past happens only when innovation is seen as **inescapable and desirable**, i.e. as **"progress"**.
- In modern culture, words like **"new"** and **"revolutionary"** (as in advertising) have become synonyms for "better".
- People accept **technological innovation** (control over nature: science, technology) far more easily than **social or moral innovation** (e.g. changes in sexual and family relations). "Has there ever been a serious example of Luddism directed against bicycles or transistor radios?" Even popular religion accepted cheap printed holy images, yet violently resisted changes to holy texts. Where useful technology *is* rejected, it is because of fear of the **social disruption** it entails.
- So **modernity is not one simple embrace of the new**; it produces enthusiasm in some areas and anxiety in others.
- Once innovation becomes normal, the past cannot function simply as a stable precedent. **Paradoxically, the past remains the most useful tool for coping with constant change, in a new form: as process.** History becomes a story of **development, transformation, evolution and becoming**. Examples: **Bagehot's *Physics and Politics*** (1872); modern ideas of **"modernization"**.
- What legitimises the present is no longer the past as **reference points** (e.g. **Magna Carta**) or as **duration** (e.g. the age of parliamentary institutions), but **the past as a process of becoming the present**. "Faced with the overriding reality of change, **even conservative thought becomes historicist**."
- **The paradox:** "the more change dominates social life, the more important history becomes as an analytical tool." Even innovation-proud societies remain deeply historical.

IN PLAIN WORDS: THE PROBLEM OF THE FUTURE

Innovators who want to design a future unlike the past still look for examples, such as socialists citing **"primitive communism"** as an analytical prop: "a concrete precedent even for the unprecedented". **Historicism** (extrapolating past trends) is the most popular way to predict, but a contradiction arises. Marx was convinced capitalism would be replaced by socialism yet said almost nothing about what socialist society would be like, because history can show *tendencies* but not their precise outcome. Utopias need **stability**, while history is change. So "**History ceases to be of use at the very moment when we need it most**." We fall back on the past as a **repository of precedent** chosen for present problems. Examples: what happened to the poor displaced by 19th-century **railway building** can illuminate the effects of 20th-century **urban motorways**; **"student power" in medieval universities** bears on reforming modern universities. This dipping into the past does not replace proper social models.

(f) Genealogy, identity and legitimacy MUST KNOW

- **Genealogy** means not just family trees but groups' efforts to **locate themselves in a lineage**.
- It provides **continuity, emotional depth, legitimacy, prestige**, and often **compensation for insecurity**.
- New nations, new elites, revolutionary movements and rising social groups search for **heroic predecessors**. They want ancestors, even symbolic ones.
- Examples: **modern revolutionaries** claiming **Spartacus, Thomas More and Winstanley** as ancestors, though Marxist theory says these are irrelevant (Roman slave revolts could not produce communism); school history syllabuses teaching children about **Boadicea, King Alfred or Joan of Arc**; **bourgeois parvenus** seeking aristocratic pedigrees; social movements annexing past greatness in proportion to how much they feel they lack it; 20th-c. businessmen hunting elk like aristocrats; the Stalin-era claims that Russians invented everything.
- Discussion point: *Why do modern groups that claim to be creating something new still need to link themselves to older examples?* Think of how political parties, social movements and nation-states constantly build lineages.

(g) Chronology and historical thinking MUST KNOW

- For modern historians **chronology is essential**: sequence, dating, duration, and the avoidance of **anachronism**. Modern historical consciousness is bound to chronology because it assumes history is about **directional change**. Anachronism is an "alarm signal" for historians, which is why *Macbeth* in modern dress shocks today but did not in Jacobean times.
- But not all uses of the past work like this. In **traditional** uses (pattern, model, moral storehouse) the **moral, symbolic or exemplary value** of a story matters more than its date. Examples: Romans and Moors fighting together in **Spanish Easter processions**; whether **Horatius** came before **Mucius Scaevola** matters only to pedants; the value of the **Maccabees, Masada and Bar Kokhba** to modern Israelis has nothing to do with their dates. (Moses **Finley**'s contrast: Homer's Odysseus vs Samuel Butler's middle-aged Odysseus returning to an ageing wife.)
- When real time is introduced into such a past (e.g. analysing **Homer and the Bible** with modern scholarship), it becomes something else, which is socially disturbing and a symptom of transformation.
- Yet chronology (genealogies, chronicles, precedents) matters for legal, bureaucratic, economic and ritual purposes. The **lawyer's search for precedent** is present-oriented; the **historian** cares about the *difference* of circumstances.

THREE THINGS TO KEEP SEPARATE (FROM THE PPT)

History	Memory	Myth
Disciplined, **temporal reconstruction** (dates, sequence, evidence).	**Social remembrance**: what a group chooses to remember.	A **meaning-bearing narrative**: exemplary, moral, symbolic.

1.4 *On History* (1997), ch. 3: what can history tell us about the present?

MUST KNOW

THE LINK BETWEEN THE TWO TEXTS

The 1972 essay studies the **social function of historical consciousness** (how societies *live with* the past). Chapter 3 of *On History* studies the **analytical function of historical explanation** (how historians *think with* the past). The movement is from the **social uses of the past** to the **explanatory uses of history**. The present itself cannot be understood without historical depth.

- History helps us understand contemporary society by **placing it in sequence**, **showing its formation**, and **identifying long-term processes** that are invisible if we look only at the present.
- So history can help us: **contextualise present institutions**; **distinguish continuity from rupture**; **identify what is actually new**; and **expose false assumptions about novelty**.
- History is an **instrument of demystification**. It does not predict the future, but it helps us understand how the present was made.

What history CAN do	What history CANNOT do
Show the **roots of present institutions**.	Provide **mechanical lessons**.
Uncover the **historical construction of nations, identities and traditions**.	Tell us exactly **what will happen next**.
Reveal that many supposed novelties are part of **longer developments**.	Serve as a **substitute for political judgement**.
Distinguish **genuine rupture from recycled rhetoric**.	Deliver a **ready-made programme for action**.

Why this balance matters: Hobsbawm gives history a serious **public role** without turning it into **prophecy or moral preaching**.

HOBSBAWM'S CONTRIBUTION IN ONE SENTENCE (PPT)

History is not only about the past; it is about the **ongoing relationship between past and present**. **Societies use the past to justify themselves, and historians use the past to explain how those societies came to be what they are.** That is why history remains indispensable to public life and intellectual inquiry.

Discussion questions from the lecture (practise these)

1. Why do societies appeal to the past **most loudly in moments of crisis or change**? (Because continuity has already broken; the past becomes a model or mask for innovation.)
2. Is **nationalism possible without selective history**? (Renan: nations get their history wrong; territorial claims; invented traditions.)
3. Does modern society really **break from the past**, or does it simply **reorganise the past** in new ways? (Past as process; even conservative thought becomes historicist; genealogies persist.)

Connections: nationalist historians (S4) built a glorious past "as compensation for a humiliating present" (Thapar), which is Hobsbawm's genealogy and compensation. BRI and Act East invoking the Silk Road (S8–S9) are **symbolic restorations**, "politically using the past". Vivekananda's and the Arya Samaj's versions of Hinduism (S10) reorganised the past for nationalist purposes.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 1

Every society lives with its past (a "permanent dimension of human consciousness"); the question is how it **uses** it. Traditional societies use the past as a **pattern** but are not static: change is absorbed, concealed or renamed. When change accelerates, the past becomes a **model**, consciously selected; calls for **restoration** (effective or symbolic) signal that continuity has broken, and restoration always reinvents (Zapata). Remote pasts become **artefacts or fabrications** (Norman Yoke, Charlemagne, Ghana, nationalism), invented yet powerful. Modern societies, accepting **progress**, use the past as **process**, and even conservatives become historicist. **Genealogy** gives legitimacy; **chronology** separates history from memory and myth. *On History* adds that history explains how the present was made (demystification) but cannot predict or prescribe.

EXAM CORNER

Likely short questions (10 marks):

1. "The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness." Explain Hobsbawm's argument.
2. Distinguish between the past as *pattern*, *model* and *process*, with examples.
3. Why is Hobsbawm sceptical of the language of restoration? Distinguish effective and symbolic restoration.
4. What can history tell us about contemporary society, and what can it not do?

Answer skeleton for Q2: Intro: Hobsbawm (1972) says societies relate to their past in changing ways. ¶ Pattern: traditional societies reproduce inherited norms (customs, sacred law, land rights); not static, since change is absorbed in interstices or disguised (nomads and lorries; Mexican conversion). ¶ Model: when change accelerates the past is consciously invoked; calls for restoration show continuity has broken; Zapata's Morelos became a revolution. ¶ Process: modernity values novelty ("new" = better); the past legitimises the present as development (Bagehot, modernisation theory); even conservatives become historicist. ¶ Conclusion: the more change, the more history matters as an analytical tool; link to nationalism and invented traditions.

Possible MCQ facts: journal = *Past & Present*, 1972; "myth of vulgar social science" = static traditional society; Warsaw rebuilding = symbolic restoration; Zapata = Morelos, Mexico; "History ceases to be of use at the very moment when we need it most"; Bagehot's *Physics and Politics* (1872).

SESSION 2

Historical Methods, Sources and Practices

Readings: Matthew Lange, *Comparative-Historical Methods* (Sage, 2013), ch. 1, pp. 1–21 (R2) · Charlotte Backerra, "Source criticism for cultural history", *Rethinking History* 28:2 (2024), pp. 194–216 (OT2)

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 1 asked *why* the past matters. Session 2 asks **how historians actually do history**. The lecture pairs two readings that answer two basic questions: **Lange** asks *how do historians explain the past?* (through comparison, causation and long-term analysis), and **Backerra** asks *how do historians know whether evidence is trustworthy?* (through source criticism). Every later session applies these tools: judging Xuanzang or al-Shahrastani as sources (S6), Hansen using tombs and pawn tickets (S8), Sen combining archaeology and texts (S9).

2.1 What are historical methods? MUST KNOW

- **Historical methods** are **systematic ways of investigating the past**. Research is **analytical, not merely descriptive**: historians explain *why* events happened (this connects with Lange's point that historical methods seek **causal explanations** rather than simple narratives).
- They include: asking research questions → finding evidence → evaluating sources → comparing societies → explaining change → presenting historical arguments.
- **Source vs evidence:** a *source* is any surviving trace of the past (a letter, coin, tomb, photo). It becomes *evidence* only when the historian uses it, critically evaluated, to answer a **specific question**. Backerra: almost anything surviving can become a source if it helps answer a research question.

The four stages of the historical method (lecture table) MUST KNOW

Stage	Purpose	Key question	Failure mode (what goes wrong)
1. Heuristics	Collection of evidence	"What survives, and where is it?"	Missing extant evidence; mistaking derivative copies for originals
2. Criticism	Evaluating authenticity and reliability	"Is it genuine? Is its author credible?"	Misattribution, fraud, naively accepting biased testimony
3. Hermeneutics	Interpreting meaning	"What did the author mean, in context?"	**Anachronism**; projecting modern categories backwards
4. Synthesis	Reconstruction and narrative	"How do the parts fit into a coherent account?"	**Whig (teleological) narrative**; decontextualised pastiche

Whig history = writing the past as a steady march of progress towards the present (judging the past by how it led to "us"). **Teleology** = assuming events were heading towards a predetermined end.

Types of sources MUST KNOW

Type	Definition	Examples	Character
Primary	Created **during the time** under study	Diaries, letters, court proceedings, legislative debates, newspapers, photographs (also inscriptions, coins, travel accounts)	Contemporaneous, uninterpreted
Secondary	**Analyses, assesses or interprets** a historical event	Scholarly articles, monographs, biographies	Synthesising, retrospective

Tertiary	**Synthesises and summarises** primary and secondary sources	Encyclopaedias, textbooks, bibliographies	Reference, distanced

Five contending schools of historiography (lecture table) MUST KNOW

School	Periodisation	Focal evidence	Key method	Canonical critique
German Historicist (**Ranke**)	Event-driven	Archival primary sources	Source-critical reading of state papers	E.H. **Carr**: "naive objectivism"
Annales (**Bloch, Febvre, Braudel**)	**Longue durée** (long-term structures)	Geography, demography, agronomy	Multidisciplinary; "regressive method" (reading backwards from the present)	Apolitical; "reluctance to study contemporary history"
Marxist (**Marx, Engels, E.P. Thompson**)	Epochal (modes of production)	Class conflict, labour archives	Historical materialism	Deterministic, teleological
Subaltern / Postcolonial (**Guha, Spivak**)	Anti-imperial	Peasant and subaltern testimony	Recovery of marginalised voices	Risk of essentialism
Cliometrics / Digital (**Fogel, North**)	Quantitative periods	Statistical series, big data	Econometrics, data mining	Reduces meaning to numbers

Practice: oral history and archival research SUPPORTING

Practice	Authoritative body	Stages	Ethical anchor
Oral history	Oral History Association (OHA)	Preparation → interviewing → preservation → access	**Informed consent** on record
Archival research	American Historical Association (AHA)	Pre-trip planning → on-site navigation → post-trip citation	**Provenance + chain of custody**

Shared commitments and tensions across the field SUPPORTING

Dimension	Shared commitment	How schools diverge
Evidence	Read primary sources where possible	Ranke: archives are paramount; Thucydides: eyewitness; Cliometrics: statistics
Distance	Avoid anachronism	Butterfield: the contingent past over the progressive present; Subaltern: actors as colleagues; Annales: *mentalité* rather than event
Disclosure	Acknowledge bias	Carr: disclose selection; Hayden White: disclose "emplotment"; Thompson: disclose the framing of class

- **Objectivity vs disclosure:** Ranke treated the historian as a transparent recorder; White argued that transparency is itself rhetorical. Modern practice opts for **explicit disclosure**: state the question, the source set and the framing.
- **Event vs structure:** Annales elevated structure; narrativists elevated events. Digital and cliometric methods can recover both only by separating **data** from the **model**, otherwise quantification becomes Whiggish teleology.
- **Recovery vs representation:** subaltern studies (recover excluded voices) plus postmodern scepticism (every representation is partial) create strong ethical requirements: return narratives to participants, record consent, allow restricted access.

2.2 Lange: comparative-historical methods MUST KNOW

LANGE'S CORE ARGUMENT

Comparative-historical analysis (CHA) has produced some of the most influential social science (**Adam Smith, Tocqueville, Marx, Max Weber, Barrington Moore, Charles Tilly, Theda Skocpol**). Between 1986 and 2010, CHA books won **one-quarter** of the American Sociological Association's best-book awards, although few sociologists use it. Yet there was **no textbook** on what the method actually is. Lange fills this gap and argues that CHA is distinctive because it **combines diverse methods** (a template for methodological pluralism) and **balances the particular and the general** (ideographic and nomothetic explanation).

CHA's big topic is **social change**, the pivotal social issue of the past half-millennium: **state building, nationalism, capitalist development and industrialisation, technological development, warfare and revolutions, social movements, democratisation, imperialism, secularisation and globalisation**. It is prominent in sociology and political science, and more marginal in history, economics and anthropology. (The older name was "comparative-historical sociology"; **Mahoney & Rueschemeyer (2003)** renamed it comparative-historical *analysis*.)

The four defining elements of comparative-historical analysis (Lange's Venn diagram)

1 · Within-case methods (the "historical")

Analyse processes **over time** inside one case. Main types:

- **Causal narrative**: a "detective-style" account of processes and their causes.
- **Process tracing**: a focused narrative examining the **mechanisms** linking two phenomena.
- **Pattern matching**: uses within-case evidence to **test theories**.

Works that use within-case methods without analysing temporal processes are *not* CHA.

2 · Comparative methods (the "comparative")

Compare **multiple cases** to explore similarities and differences and highlight **causal determinants**. Types: **narrative, Millian, Boolean, statistical** comparisons. CHA mostly uses **small-N comparisons** that attend to context and mechanisms.

3 · Epistemology: social-scientific

Accepts that real **causal insight is possible**. **Postmodern** views that deny social-scientific knowledge (because discourses bias all analysis) are "anti-methodological", so they fall outside CHA.

4 · Unit of analysis: meso/macro

"Big structures, large processes, huge comparisons" (**Tilly 1984**): states, classes, economies, religions, social movements. Individuals matter (Weber; Kalyvas and Petersen on violence) but always in relation to **structures and institutions**.

WHAT IS NOT COMPARATIVE-HISTORICAL ANALYSIS (AND WHY)

- **Edward Said, *Orientalism* (1978)** and other postmodern works: they compare and narrate, but they deny social-scientific insight.
- **Acemoglu, Johnson & Robinson** (2001, 2002) on colonial legacies: social-scientific and macro, but they **omit within-case analysis** (purely statistical).
- **Tilly, *The Contentious French*** (1986): within-case analysis of France, but **no explicit inter-case comparison**.

These are excellent works; they just lack one defining element. The boundaries are "very blurred".

Methodology vocabulary MUST KNOW

Methodology

A body of practices, procedures and rules used to gain insight into the world. **Michael Mann (1981)**: there is really one methodology in eight steps: formulate a problem → conceptualise variables → make hypotheses → establish a sample → operationalise concepts →

gather data → analyse data to test hypotheses → conclude. Only the *techniques* of analysis differ.

Method
A technique for analysing data (and, by extension, the matching strategy for gathering it).

Insight
Evidence contributing to an understanding of a case or set of cases; CHA cares most about **causal insight**.

Nomothetic explanation
From Greek *nomos*, "law": general explanations that apply to many or all cases; associated with **positivism** and the natural sciences, and often (wrongly) seen as "more scientific".

Ideographic explanation
Explains the causes of a **particular case**, stressing its uniqueness. Tilly: an ideographic explanation is not "a bungled attempt at generalization".

Positivism
The scientific method is the best way to gain knowledge; at its extreme, it holds that social laws can be discovered.

Verstehen
German, "understanding" (Max Weber): social scientists should aim to **understand** meaning rather than find laws (interpretivism).

Epistemology
The branch of philosophy dealing with the possibility and scope of knowledge.

Lange compares the four main social-science methods MUST KNOW

Method	What it does	Strengths	Weaknesses
Statistical (nomothetic, comparative)	Analyses **natural variation** across many cases (e.g. lower per-capita GDP linked to civil war)	Tests several theories at once; estimates effects; generalisable; formalised and replicable	Assumptions often broken; model choice changes results; **correlation ≠ causation**; weak on mechanisms; needs data and many cases
Experimental (nomothetic, comparative)	Manipulates subjects with a **treatment** (e.g. telling subjects a toddler is a boy or girl; the self-esteem and horn-honking experiment)	The most powerful causal insight; controls other factors; reveals mechanisms	Impractical for big, long processes (revolutions, capitalism); ethical limits. "Natural experiments" approximate it with fewer controls.
Ethnographic (ideographic, within-case)	Participant observation and interviews; the main method of anthropology	Rich insight into culture, motives, values, ritual; handles complexity	Can't study the past directly; case-specific; needs willing participants who may change their behaviour when observed (e.g. Lipset et al., *Union Democracy*)
Historical (= historiography; ideographic, within-case)	Finds, validates and narrates data about a particular time and place (e.g. Truman's decision to drop the atomic bomb; family structure in 19th-c. rural England)	Insight into complex past phenomena	Case-bound, so ill-suited to generalisation; **cannot generate its own data** and depends on surviving sources
Comparative-historical	**Combines comparative + within-case methods**; mostly **small-N** comparison; draws data largely from **secondary sources**	Largest toolkit; triangulation; spans the **ideographic–nomothetic divide**	Criticised by historians for sacrificing "good history" for generalisation, and by positivists for privileging internal over external validity

CHA rarely uses statistics (its logic of variables differs from that of causal processes, and historical data and case numbers are small) and never laboratory experiments (it studies concrete real-world events, such as "what caused the American civil rights movement?", that cannot be replicated). It borrows data from ethnography and history but differs in its goal: **causal explanation** rather than description.

TWO FAMOUS EXAMPLES LANGE USES

- **Reinhard Bendix, *Kings or People* (1978)**, a **difference-oriented (ideographic)** strategy. He compares England, France, Germany, Japan, Russia and China on how **popular sovereignty** replaced hereditary monarchy. Conclusion: each path was **distinctive**, with no single route to modernity.
- **Theda Skocpol, *States and Social Revolutions* (1979)**, a **balance** of the nomothetic and ideographic. She shows that **state breakdown + peasant mobilisation capacity** cause social revolution, but limits the claim to agrarian bureaucracies that were not colonies, in a particular period.

IN PLAIN WORDS: WHY COMBINING METHODS MATTERS

Comparison (looking across cases) pushes you towards **general** explanations; within-case narrative (looking deep into one case) pushes you towards the **particular**. Using both stops you from over-generalising ("all revolutions are caused by X") and from treating every case as utterly unique. That is why CHA sits in the "middle" of the ideographic–nomothetic continuum, and why it is criticised from both sides.

2.3 Backerra: source criticism for cultural history MUST KNOW

BACKERRA'S CORE ARGUMENT

Source criticism has been the historian's basic method since the 19th century, and textbooks suggest it has barely changed in 150 years. But **cultural historians** today ask **different questions**, use **different materials**, and so reach **different interpretations**, often **without reflecting** on how they are modifying the method. The **formal analysis** of a source stays largely the same; what changes is the **heuristic** (questions and sources) and the **interpretation**. The final step, **presentation**, remains "largely unreflected" and needs rethinking. Cultural history is avant-garde in theory but works with an established, partly adapted methodology: a tension between theory and method.

History of the method

Humanism — **"Ad fontes"** ("back to the sources") becomes an imperative.

early 1800s — The **Tübingen School** of biblical criticism develops critical reading of the Bible. **Monumenta Germaniae Historica** (1819) edits German sources. **Niebuhr** is an early user of source criticism.

1830s — **Leopold von Ranke** makes source-reading courses a standard part of studying history, using Tübingen methods.

1868 — **Johann Gustav Droysen**, *Historik* (an 84-page outline of his Jena lectures): **four steps: heuristic, source analysis, interpretation, presentation**. The steps are intertwined ("a continuous back and forth"). Translated into French (1882) and English (E.B. Andrews, 1893).

1889 — **Ernst Bernheim**'s 500–800-page textbook spreads the method to generations of German students (Erslev in Denmark follows him).

1970s–80s — Droysen is rediscovered (Gadamer, **Jörn Rüsen**, **Hayden White**). The method is still taught in Germany, Austria, Denmark, Estonia and Finland, but rarely in anglophone countries.

Today — **Digital humanities**: online databases, digitised editions, text-mining, automatic handwriting transcription (**Transkribus**).

Droysen's four steps, as taught today MUST KNOW

1 · Heuristic
Develop a **guiding question**; check that it is relevant; search for suitable sources (textual and material). Question and sources shape each other.

→

2 · Source analysis
External: is it **genuine** (paper, ink, handwriting) and **valid** (relevant)?
Internal: by whom, for whom, when, why, what, how?

→

3 · Interpretation
Droysen's hermeneutic approach: understand thoughts, intentions and the meaning of events for contemporaries.

→

4 · Presentation
Results must reach an audience, otherwise they stay "unripe and undisclosed". Often neglected.

Droysen's four kinds of interpretation

1. **Pragmatic**: cause and effect.
2. **Of conditions**: space, time, resources (geography, chronology, materials).
3. **Biographical / psychological**: action as the result of character.
4. **Of ideas**: events express the concepts or ideologies of an age.

White compares these with psychological, causal, teleological and ethical interpretation. The Annales school and economic history need **analytical** (statistical) rather than hermeneutic interpretation.

Forms of presentation

- **Investigative**: follows the guiding question and shows the historian's decisions.
- **Narrative**: "tell a story" (the 19th-c. norm; White's *Metahistory*).
- **Didactic**: "learn from history"; history as the teacher of humanity.
- **Discursive**: the most common academic form; engages in controversies.

Droysen (via White): historians determine what is **plausible**, not absolute truth, so representation matters.

Common student misconceptions (Backerra): that source analysis is a universal "recipe" (perhaps true); that heuristic–analysis–interpretation is the *only* way to assess sources (perhaps not); and that this is all there is to Droysen. In practice historians work "instinctively", shaped by criticism and by reading others.

Backerra's case study: early modern diplomatic correspondence MUST KNOW

Traditional (political) historians used diplomatic letters mainly to establish **"who said what to whom, when and where"**. For **cultural historians** that is only the starting point. They ask about **actors and their roles**, patronage and family networks (Hillard von Thiessen's "diplomacy of the type *ancien*"), symbols, ceremony, space, emotions, language and knowledge. These interests come from the **linguistic, performative, spatial and knowledge "turns"**.

EXAMPLES THAT SHOW HOW CULTURAL HISTORY "READS" A SOURCE DIFFERENTLY

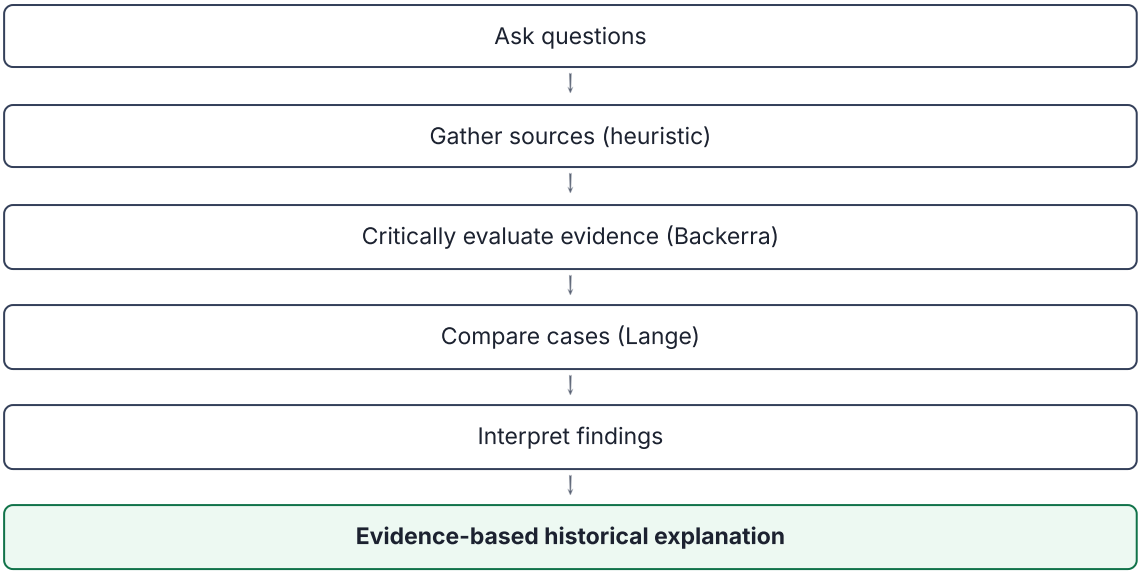
- **Layout reveals hierarchy:** blank **margins grew larger the higher the rank** of the addressee; letters were folded and sealed (**"letterlocking"**); style, language and calligraphy reflected rank. (The lecture's example: a diplomatic letter reveals negotiations, but also social hierarchy through handwriting, language and layout.)
- **Labels:** "open" reports could be shown to others; "secret" or "very secret" ones held critical information, sometimes encrypted; "private" meant *limited readership* (king and ministers), not personal. A letter could be both secret and private.
- **Ceremony was not trivial:** ceremonial questions made up about **half the instructions** for diplomats (Emperor Charles VI, 1728). The imperial envoy to London was told to insist that the Spanish and French ambassadors pay the **first formal visit**, to show imperial precedence.
- **Newspapers, tokens and society letters reveal networks:** Count **Philipp Kinsky** (imperial envoy, then ambassador in London) never mentions his social network in official letters, but newspapers show him fencing at **Figg's** club and hosting a ball at Somerset House; a **Vauxhall Gardens token** marked "His Excellency" dates to 1733 or later (after he became ambassador).
- **Language asserts status:** Charles VI wrote to George II in **Italian** (emperor to king), and the reply came in **French**, but in **German** when George wrote as Elector of Brunswick-Lüneburg, a vassal of the emperor. Credentials were in **Latin**, but because Vienna downgraded "maiestas" to "serenitas", the British envoy carried a **French** set to secure "majesté".
- **Space and religion:** British envoys **Waldegrave** and **Robinson** lived in the **Freihaus** outside Vienna's walls, owned by the Starhemberg family. This shows help from senior officials, and it placed them outside Catholic confessional restrictions so they could provide Protestant worship.
- **Even weather means something:** Waldegrave's 1728 complaint "I never knew what Cold was, till I felt it here" coincided with frozen negotiations, so it likely expresses his sense of diplomatic failure.
- **Emotions are performances:** displays of emotion are read as **constructed performances** reflecting rank, origin and the observer's background (history of emotions). Thomas Otte calls personality the "missing dimension".

Cultural history expands sources: traditional history focused on government archives, official documents and political correspondence. Cultural history also studies **rituals, symbols, emotions, material culture, literature, newspapers, personal letters and everyday life**. It asks not only **"What happened?"** but also **"What did this event mean?"**. Peter Burke: cultural history is less a separate field than **a way of writing history from a particular point of view**, and the frontier with social history is hard to locate.

On presentation: British historiography tends towards **chronological** chapters; German, French and Spanish towards **analytical categories**. French and German cultural history distrusted "master narratives", but fictional-yet-fact-based narration appears (Ginzburg, *The Cheese and the Worms*; Schama, *Dead Certainties*). Backerra asks historians to **state their own point of view** ("I"/"we") instead of hiding behind neutral language.

2.4 Putting Lange and Backerra together MUST KNOW

Lange	Backerra
Explains historical **change**	Explains how **evidence is evaluated**
Focuses on **causation**	Focuses on **source criticism**
Uses **comparison**	Uses **interpretation**
Builds **theories**	Builds **reliable evidence**
Asks: "What does this evidence **explain**?"	Asks: "Can we **trust** this evidence?"



The complete workflow of historical scholarship (lecture). "History is both an art of interpretation and a science of evidence."

SUMMARY OF SESSION 2

Historical methods are systematic and analytical: **heuristics → criticism → hermeneutics → synthesis**, each with typical failures (missing evidence, fraud, anachronism, Whig teleology). Sources are primary, secondary or tertiary. Five schools (Rankean, Annales, Marxist, Subaltern, Cliometric) differ in their evidence and method. **Lange** defines comparative-historical analysis by four elements (within-case methods, comparative methods, social-scientific epistemology, macro units) and shows that it bridges **ideographic and nomothetic** explanation (Bendix vs Skocpol). **Backerra** traces source criticism from Ranke and Droysen (**heuristic, analysis, interpretation, presentation**) and, through early modern diplomatic letters, shows how cultural historians read layout, ceremony, language, space and emotion to ask "what did it mean?", while presentation remains unreflected.

EXAM CORNER

1. What are the four defining elements of comparative-historical analysis? How does it balance ideographic and nomothetic explanation? (Use Bendix and Skocpol.)
2. Explain Droysen's four steps of source criticism. How does cultural history change their application? (Use the diplomatic-letter examples: margins, ceremony, Kinsky, language, Freihaus.)
3. "Lange shows how historians explain; Backerra shows how they know." Discuss.
4. Distinguish primary, secondary and tertiary sources, and explain why sources must be criticised before use.

MCQ facts: Droysen's *Historik* 1868 (Jena); Ranke 1830s; Tübingen School = biblical criticism; Bernheim 1889 textbook; Transkribus = handwriting recognition; "ad fontes"; Mann's eight steps; Tilly "big structures, large processes, huge comparisons"; Said's *Orientalism* excluded from CHA as postmodern.

SESSION
3

Global and Regional Histories: Scale, Perspective and Context

Reading: Thomas D. Hall (ed.), *Comparing Globalizations: Historical and World-Systems Approaches* (Springer, 2018), chs. 1 & 8 (R3). Uploaded: Hall's introduction "Toward Comparative Globalizations" (*Journal of Globalization Studies* 5:1, 2014). Ch. 8 (Daniel Little, on "place") is covered by the lecture.

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 2 gave you methods; Session 3 gives you **scale**. The same event looks different seen from a village, a region, a nation or the whole globe. The lecture's one-line conclusion: **"Global history asks how places are connected. Regional history asks how places are constituted. Historical understanding is strongest when we ask both questions together."** This framework is reused constantly: India as both internally diverse and globally connected (S7), Hansen's city vs Bhattacharya's region (S8), and Chaudhuri's "unity and disunity" of the Indian Ocean (S11).

3.1 Why study history at multiple levels? MUST KNOW

The problem

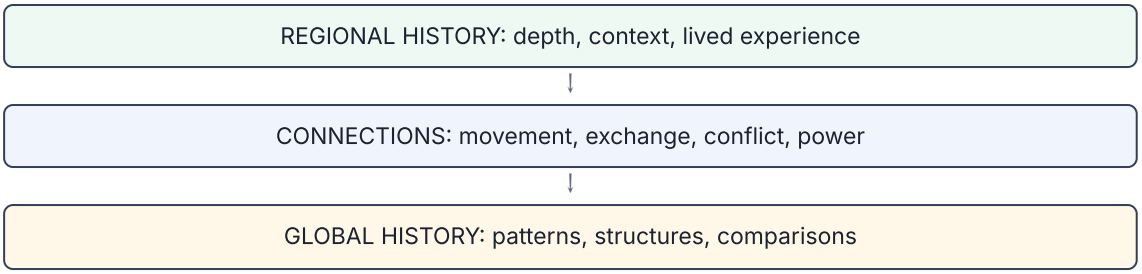
- Historical events do **not** occur at only one level.
- **Local experiences are shaped by wider systems.**
- **Large systems are built from regional interactions.**
- **National history alone is often too narrow.**

The principle

- Historical processes unfold at multiple levels.
- **Scale shapes the questions we ask**, and different scales produce different explanations.
- No single scale is always sufficient.
- **History is not naturally contained within the nation-state.**

3.2 Global history vs regional history MUST KNOW

	Global history	Regional history
Studies	**Connections across borders**; entanglements among distant places	A **specific historical space**, which may be sub-national, cross-border or macro-regional
Focus	**Mobility, exchange, circulation**; broad processes and large-scale change (without ignoring diversity)	**Local dynamics and internal diversity**
Contribution	Challenges **nation-centred, isolated national narratives**; e.g. Wallerstein's world-systems theory	**Recovers voices and processes hidden in larger narratives**; **tests and refines** larger claims
Key question	How are places **linked**?	How did a place **work internally**?
Danger	Can become **too abstract**	Can become **too isolated**
Explains	**Interconnection**: patterns, structures, comparisons	**Specificity**: depth, context, lived experience



The lecture's diagram: regional depth feeds into connections, which build up into global patterns. Together they produce stronger explanation.

3.3 Wallerstein and world-systems analysis (WSA) MUST KNOW

IN PLAIN WORDS: WHAT IS A "WORLD-SYSTEM"?

Immanuel Wallerstein (*The Modern World-System*, vol. I, 1974) argued that the modern world economy since the 16th century is one system divided by an international division of labour into a **core** (capital-intensive, high-skill production), a **semi-periphery** and a **periphery** (labour-intensive, low-skill suppliers of raw materials). The key phrase: **"A world-system is not the system of the world, but a system that *is* a world"**, and it can be (and usually has been) **smaller than the whole globe**. A world-system is **the largest unit of social evolution**: empires, states, non-state societies and families all exist *inside* it, with a **recursive relationship** in which the parts shape the whole and the whole constrains the parts.

(In S8, J. Bhattacharya notes that Wallerstein placed South Asia in the "semi-periphery". David Washbrook rejected this, pointing to strong states, finance and a dynamic bourgeoisie, and Bayly and Ludden called Wallerstein Eurocentric.)

3.4 Hall, ch. 1, "Comparing Globalizations": the argument MUST KNOW

HALL'S CORE CLAIMS

1. **Reject the idea of one single globalization; there are MULTIPLE globalizations.**
2. **Globalizing processes have long historical depth.** They are ancient, becoming "truly global" only in the last century or so. Contemporary globalization has new aspects, but these did not appear *de novo*: "how can one tell what is new if one does not already know what is old?" If processes are **cyclical**, you need a long view to tell what is new from what is the same process intensified.
3. **Different world-systems emerged at different times** (many world-systems since at least the Neolithic, c. 12,000 years ago).
4. **Comparison is more useful than one linear story.** What counts as an appropriate comparison depends on the **purpose** of comparing, not on the objects themselves.

The great debate: one system or many? MUST KNOW

Andre Gunder Frank (with Barry Gills, 1993)	Christopher Chase-Dunn & Thomas Hall (1997)
ONE expanding world system for 5,000 years (written without a hyphen: "world system")	**MANY world-systems** of various kinds since at least the Neolithic (with a hyphen: "world-systems")

Hall jokes that this debate "may appear to be nit-picking about whether or not world-system has a hyphen" and has caused "no end of headaches for copy editors", but the hyphen marks **an important theoretical distinction**. Others extended WSA into the past: **Janet Abu-Lughod**, *Before European Hegemony: The World System A.D. 1250–1350* (1989), traced Europe-to-China interconnections in the 13th–14th centuries.

Hall's lessons about comparison SUPPORTING

- **Apples and oranges:** it is fine to compare apples and oranges if you are discussing *fruit*; add baseballs if you are discussing *spherical objects*. The purpose decides what is comparable.
- **Context matters:** narrow comparisons give detail and nuance but need larger contexts. The cartoon of the young stock-market whiz who asks "you mean they can go down?" shows how narrow experience restricts analysis. Progress in the social sciences comes from discovering the **larger contexts**, which can reveal that supposed constants are actually slow-changing **variables**.
- **Move between levels:** some local processes cannot be understood from very broad contexts. Know when to treat something as constant and when as a variable. Very slow changes (e.g. **climate change**) can become invisible in short spans of noisy data.
- **Emergent change and inflection points:** moments when a boundary is crossed and a whole set of phenomena changes, e.g. the **"emergence of the state"** (like a machine's *purpose*, which physics and chemistry cannot explain). Because "pristine" states arose several times, there may be systematic processes. If you study only recent decades (as **Sklair** does), you cannot even frame questions about the rise of states or the modern nation-state.
- **Julian Go** compares the **19th-century British** and **20th-century American** empires using **"world-system time"** (equivalent phases of hegemonic cycles), showing that the "American Empire" is hardly exceptional.

The volume's other contributors (who argues what) BACKGROUND

Author	Contribution
Nick **Kardulias**	Archaeology and ancient globalization (with Justin Jennings, *Globalizations and the Ancient World*, 2011); "negotiated peripherality".
Christopher **Chase-Dunn**	How world-systems evolve since before the Neolithic, and possible futures.
Korotayev & Grinin	Global integration over five or more millennia (they edited the *Journal of Globalization Studies*).
Julian **Go**	British vs US empires using world-system time.
Glen **Kuecker**	Possible **collapse** of the current world-system as it hits resource limits; **peripheral peoples** may be best placed to survive.
Daniel **Little** (ch. 8)	What "place" means in world history, and how nation and region relate to it.
Sing **Chew**	The first **Southeast Asian world-system** and its role in the growing Afroeurasian system.
Patrick **Manning**	The neglected "Afro" in Afroeurasia: sub-Saharan Africa's role ("we all ultimately came out of Africa").

THREE IMPLICIT DEBATES IN THE VOLUME

1. **The unification of Afroeurasia** (Abu-Lughod, against Wallerstein's view that the European world-system was barely connected to Asia and Africa). Jared **Diamond** (*Guns, Germs, and Steel*, 1997): Eurasia's **east–west axis** eased the spread of plants and animals. Turchin, Adams and Hall (2006) found this holds empirically; the Andes are a north–south exception that follows similar climatic logic via altitude.
2. Stephen **Sanderson**: parallel sequences of social evolution in the Old and New Worlds over similar time-spans.
3. **Turchin & Hall (2003)**, building on Teggart's *Rome and China* (1939): synchronised cycles show why **low volumes of luxury trade (silk, gems) can have large effects** at both ends of a network. Luxury goods can matter as much as the bulk goods Wallerstein emphasised, and this highlights the role of **Central Asian pastoral nomads**.

WSA is a hallmark of **multi- and inter-disciplinary** work (anthropology, archaeology, geography, philosophy, political science, sociology, world history). It often studies systems **"from the bottom up", from the periphery to the centre** (frontiers, indigenous peoples; Hall & Fenelon argue indigenous movements were the *original* social movements).

3.5 Hall, ch. 8: nation, region and globe MUST KNOW

- Historical **"place"** can be understood at three levels: **nation, region, globe**. Each scale reveals different patterns.
- **Historians must move across scales.**
- **Nation-state boundaries can be misleading for earlier periods.** "India", "China" or "Bangladesh" did not exist in their modern form in the past.
- This is **especially useful for Indian history**.

3.6 Why India is central to this discussion MUST KNOW

India as a test case

- India has always contained **multiple regions**.
- It has long-standing ties to **Asia, Africa and the Indian Ocean**.
- Its history **cannot be reduced to one national narrative**.
- It shows both **internal diversity and global connectedness**.
- It is ideal for testing **nation–region–globe** frameworks.

The Indian Ocean: where regional meets global

- A **coherent macro-region** with its own historical logic.
- Also part of wider **Afro-Eurasian and global networks**.
- Connected **East Africa, Arabia, India and Southeast Asia**.
- **Trade, migration, religion and empire** moved through it.
- The best example of regional and global history meeting (developed in S7 and S11).

Case study: Vasco da Gama at three scales MUST KNOW

Scale	How the 1498 arrival at Calicut looks
National frame	A moment in **Indian history**: the beginning of European presence, later colonial rule.
Regional frame	Entry of a new player into the **Indian Ocean world**, which already had Gujarati, Arab, Mapilla and Chetti merchants (he was guided to Calicut by a **Gujarati pilot**, S11).
Global frame	A shift in wider **Eurasian and maritime systems**: the Cape route as an alternative to the Red Sea, Gulf and Venetian routes.

THE LESSON

The Portuguese arrival **changed existing networks**, but it **did not create connectivity from nothing**. Europe entered an already connected world. This is the central claim of S7 and S11.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 3

History unfolds at many scales, and the scale chosen changes the questions and the answers. **Global history** studies connections, mobility and entanglement and challenges nation-centred narratives, but risks abstraction. **Regional history** studies how a place works internally, recovering hidden voices and testing big claims, but risks isolation; together they are stronger. **Wallerstein**'s world-system is "a system that is a world", not necessarily the whole globe. **Hall** argues for **multiple globalizations** with deep histories, many world-systems (Chase-Dunn & Hall vs Frank's single 5,000-year system), and comparison defined by purpose. Ch. 8 frames place as **nation, region, globe**; nation-state borders mislead for earlier periods, which matters especially for India. The Indian Ocean is where regional and global meet; **Vasco da Gama** read at three scales shows that Europe changed existing networks but did not create connectivity.

EXAM CORNER

1. Why should global and regional histories be read together? Illustrate with India or the Indian Ocean.
2. What does Hall mean by "multiple globalizations"? How does his view differ from Frank's?
3. Analyse Vasco da Gama's arrival at national, regional and global scales.
4. "A world-system is not the system of the world." Explain.

Answer skeleton for Q1: Define both (connections vs constitution). ¶ Strengths and limits of each (abstract vs isolated). ¶ Hall: multiple globalizations, many world-systems, comparison by purpose; ch. 8's nation–region–globe, and nation-state borders misleading for the past. ¶ India: multiple regions plus ties to Africa, Arabia and Southeast Asia; the Indian Ocean as macro-region and global arena; Vasco da Gama at three scales. ¶ Conclusion: "Good history moves across scales, not within one alone."

SESSION 4

Indian Schools of Historical Thought

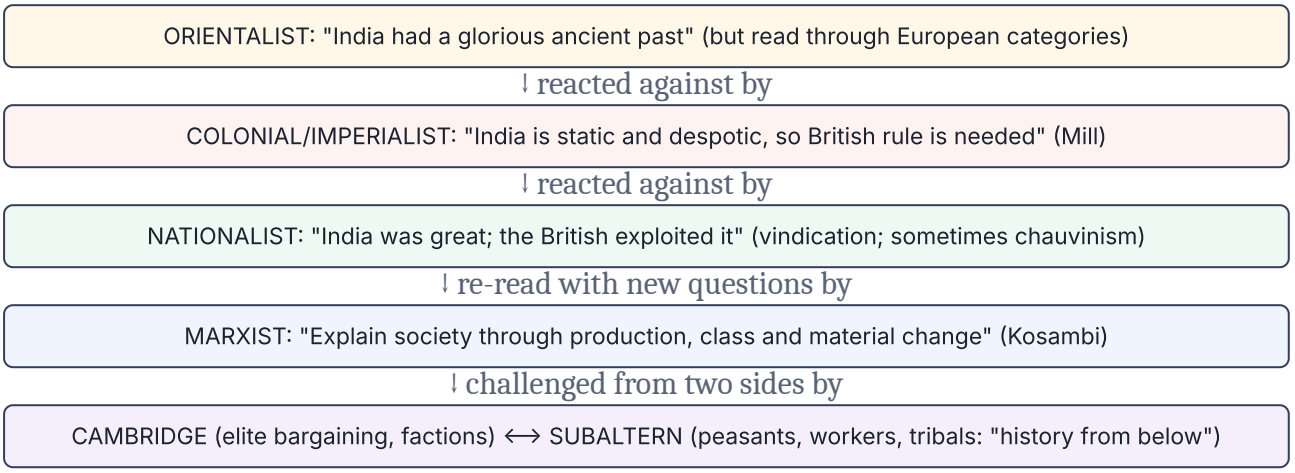
Reading: E. Sreedharan, *A Textbook of Historiography, 500 BC to AD 2000* (Orient BlackSwan, 2004), chs. 14, 15 & 16 (RB1): Indology and colonial historiography; nationalist historiography and modern Indian historians; the Marxist phase and Subaltern Studies. The lecture adds Edward Said's *Orientalism* and the Cambridge School.

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

This session applies Session 1 (uses of the past) and Session 2 (methods) to **India itself**: who wrote India's history, with what sources, and for what purpose? It is a **high-probability essay topic**; the professor's own sample essay asks whether Marxist "new history" was an advance over colonial and nationalist history. Learn the **sequence of schools**, each school's **central concern**, **key figures and works**, and **strengths and weaknesses**.

The sequence at a glance (learn this table first) MUST KNOW

School / phase	Central concern (lecture)	Key figures
Orientalist / Indological (late 18th–19th c.)	Recovery of ancient India through texts, language, archaeology and inscriptions	William Jones, Colebrooke, Wilkins, Max Müller, Prinsep, Cunningham
Colonial / Imperialist (19th–early 20th c.)	Justification of British rule through narratives of Indian backwardness	James Mill, Elliot & Dowson, Maine, Lyall, Hunter, Vincent Smith, Moreland
Nationalist (late 19th c.–1960s)	Defence of Indian civilisation and national identity	R.C. Dutt, Bhandarkar, Jayaswal, R.K. Mookerji, Raychaudhuri, Jadunath Sarkar, R.C. Majumdar, Nilakanta Sastri, Panikkar
Marxist (post-1947)	Social and economic structures, class, production, material life	D.D. Kosambi, R.S. Sharma, Romila Thapar, Irfan Habib, Bipan Chandra, Sumit Sarkar
Cambridge School (1960s–80s)	Elite politics, patronage, local interests, political networks	Anil Seal, John Gallagher, Gordon Johnson, C.A. Bayly
Subaltern Studies (1980s–)	Popular agency, protest, marginalised voices: history from below	Ranajit Guha, Gayatri Spivak, Shahid Amin, Dipesh Chakrabarty, Gyan Pandey, David Arnold



4.1 The problem: ancient India "without history"? MUST KNOW

- **Medieval India** had Indo-Muslim chronicles, so the British had fair knowledge of the 700–800 years before them. **Ancient India** seemed harder to reconstruct: British scholars claimed there were few **"genuine" historical records**,

so ancient history had to be **recovered from indirect sources** (literature, inscriptions, coins, monuments, sculpture).

- Sreedharan says the typical Hindu view kept mundane history outside "useful knowledge": there was a vague, exaggerated sense of antiquity but no "genuine historical consciousness as we understand the term". Example (cited by R.C. Majumdar): **Mrtyunjay Sharma**, chief pundit of the Supreme Court and teacher at **Fort William College** (founded 1800), published a Bengali history in 1808 with kings ruling for lakhs of years and 119 unknown kings on the throne of Delhi.
- **Robert Orme** (historiographer to the Company, 1769–1801) began British historiography on India with *Military Transactions of the British Nation in Indostan* (1764) and *Historical Fragments of the Mughal Empire…*, dismissing Hindu gods as "a heap of the greatest absurdities". **Francis Gladwin**, *History of Hindustan* (1783), covered Jahangir to Aurangzeb. **William Robertson** (1792) collected Greek and Roman references (Herodotus, Megasthenes, Pliny, Arrian). Ancient India remained *terra incognita*, "a land of marvel and mystery".

Why this matters for the exam: the course stresses that history is "built from fragments". This is the methodological challenge that Indology tried to solve.

4.2 Orientalism and Indology: the recovery of ancient India MUST KNOW

Indology = the scientific or systematic study of Indian history, languages, literature, religions and culture (with little emphasis on politics). Missionaries, especially the **Jesuits**, began earlier, but their religious motive outweighed the historical.

Influences behind the Orientalists

- **European Enlightenment** (David Kopf): differences between peoples come from *custom and culture*, not from unchanging nature, leading to **cultural relativism**, tolerance and appreciation (Voltaire thought India and China invented the arts before Europe).
- **Romanticism**: fascination with ancient, distant and mysterious civilisations.
- A new **scientific, critical spirit** in handling sources (after the Scientific Revolution).
- **Comparative scholarship**.
- **Colonial administrative needs**: officials had to know Indian languages, law and culture; linguistic skill was key to promotion.

Early British Indological efforts (lecture table)

Robert Orme	Early British historical writing on India
Francis Gladwin	Mughal India; *Institutes of the Emperor Akbar* (abridged *Ain-i-Akbari*)
Nathaniel Halhed	*Gentoo Laws* (1776, aged 23); Bengali grammar (1778)
Charles Wilkins	Sanskrit; first direct English translation of the **Bhagavad Gita** (1784); *Hitopadesa* (1787)
Jonathan Duncan	Encouraged Hindu learning (served 1772–1811)
Warren Hastings	Governor-General and **patron**: learned Persian, loved the Gita, fought for the Orientalists in Council

Indology emerged from a mixture of curiosity, administrative necessity, patronage and imperial governance. Hastings believed British administration required knowledge of Indian law, language and culture.

William Jones (1746–1794) and the Asiatic Society of Bengal MUST KNOW

- A Welsh **philologist**, linguist and Orientalist (Hebrew, Greek, Latin, Arabic, Persian); appointed **judge of the Supreme Court at Calcutta** in 1783.
- **January 1784**: founded the **Asiatic Society of Bengal**, supported by Hastings and consciously modelled on the **Royal Society** of London. It **institutionalised Indological research**, encouraged translations, supported source collection, and modelled organised scholarly inquiry. Indology became **systematic, collaborative and institutional**. (Its journal and the *Bibliotheca Indica* series published critical editions.)
- Translations: **Shakuntala** (1789, epoch-making: five editions in 20 years, a German translation in 1791 that moved **Herder and Goethe** and the whole Romantic movement), **Gita Govinda**, and the **Manusmriti** (published posthumously as *The Institutes of Hindu Law*). He studied Sanskrit under **Pundit Ramlochan**.

- Of his **eleven annual discourses** to the Society, eight were on history and one on science.

Jones's discovery	What it was	Historical importance
Indo-European languages (discourse of **1786**)	Sanskrit is "cousin" to Old Persian, Greek, Latin and modern European languages, which all derive from a lost mother tongue (e.g. Sanskrit *duhitr*, English *daughter*, German *Tochter*, Greek *thygater*; Kosambi's example)	Almost created **comparative philology, comparative mythology and ethnology**; showed the value of linguistics for history
The "Aryan race" (an audacious leap)	From a common *language* Jones jumped to a common **race** ("Aryans"), with Central Asia as the cradle	Made north Indians kin to Persians and Europeans, but later misused (see "seamy side")
Sandrocottas = Chandragupta (10th discourse, **28 Feb 1793**)	Greek sources on Alexander mention "Sandrocottas", king of the Prasii with capital **"Palibothra"**. Jones identified Palibothra = **Pataliputra** and Sandrocottas = **Chandragupta Maurya**, who made a treaty with **Seleukos Nikator**	Gave the **first firm date (325 BC)**, from which other dates could be counted backwards and forwards: **"the sheet anchor of Indian history/chronology"**. It also revealed the first great Indian empire.

After Jones: two lines of development MUST KNOW

(1) Critical study of ancient texts

- **H.T. Colebrooke**: a mathematician who first mocked the "Sanskrit-mad" Orientalists' work as "a repository of nonsense", then became Sanskrit-mad himself. Jones's successor (1794); professor of Sanskrit at Fort William College (1800, under Wellesley); *Essay on the Vedas* (1803). He pictured the Vedic age as a **golden age** with no sati, caste, idolatry or polytheism, and the early Indians as robust, beef-eating, egalitarian, with tribal republics (yet he thought the Vedas would hardly reward a translator).
- **Anquetil Duperron** (French) translated **Dara Shukoh's Persian Upanishads** (1801–02), which reached **Schelling and Schopenhauer** (who called it the profoundest philosophy he had read).
- **Eugène Burnouf** linked Rig Vedic language with the **Zend Avesta**; his *Essai sur le Pali* (1826) first made **Buddhism** known in the West as a system of thought. **Bopp, Grimm, Humboldt** established Aryan language relations.
- **Max Müller** (1823–1900, German at Oxford): edited the **Rig Veda** with Sayana's commentary (1845–79), *History of Sanskrit Literature* (1859), and ***Sacred Books of the East*** (1879–1904; 50 non-Christian scriptures in English); comparative religion.
- **Rhys Davids**, the **Pali Text Society**, Fausbøll and Jacobi: Buddhist and Jain texts.

Lecture point: ancient history was rebuilt from religious, literary, linguistic and philosophical texts, which raised **methodological challenges**: texts had to be dated, interpreted, compared and used carefully.

(2) Epigraphy, numismatics and archaeology

- **Epigraphy** = the study of inscriptions; **numismatics** = the study of coins.
- Context: Champollion read the hieroglyphs (1822); Rawlinson, cuneiform (1851); Schliemann and Evans dug up Troy and Minoa.
- **Charles Wilkins** used Pala inscriptions (1781) and read Gupta Brahmi at Gaya (1785), revealing the **Maukharis**.
- **James Prinsep** (1799–1840), assay-master of the **Calcutta Mint**, studied facsimiles every morning for seven years and in **1834 deciphered the Old Brahmi of Ashoka's inscriptions**. This turned the legendary Buddhist emperor into the **historical Ashoka** and opened the history of Buddhism to investigation. ("The decipherment of a script can open an entire historical world.") *Indian Antiquities* (1858).
- **Alexander Cunningham** (1814–1893), a Bengal Army engineer inspired by Prinsep and the **pioneer of Indian archaeology**, associated with the **Archaeological Survey of India** (director 1870): **Sarnath** (1837), **Sanchi** (1850), **Taxila** (1870–85). Archaeology includes *everything*, even ploughs and irrigation; finds are "fossil fragments of the great skeleton of lost Indian history". He published the **first Harappan seal**, but was not interested in settlement sites.
- Colin Mackenzie collected 8,000+ south Indian inscriptions. Later **Harappa and Mohenjo-daro** upset the belief that Indian civilisation began with the Vedic Aryans. In the 19th century, **three-quarters** of ancient and medieval Indian history was read from inscriptions.

Significance of the Orientalist recovery MUST KNOW

ACHIEVEMENTS

- Introduced **modern historical methods** into Indian history.
- Developed **source criticism, philology, epigraphy, archaeology and numismatics**.
- Established **chronological anchors** (325 BC).
- Revealed Indian literature and philosophy to the world. A.A. MacDonell: "Since the Renaissance there has been no event of such world-wide significance… as the discovery of Sanskrit literature."
- **Restored India to a major place in world civilisation**, a "Renaissance in the East". Irony: as India passed under British rule, British Orientalists showed it as a creative civilisation with 3,000 years of continuity: "no mean spiritual triumph for a people so physically crushed".

THE "SEAMY SIDE" (SREEDHARAN)

- The **language-race link** was false, and the **Aryan race theory** is now discarded. Yet **White Aryan superiority** became a basic assumption of imperialism and a justification for British rule.
- **Aryan invasion theory:** a superior conquering race subdued "inferior" Dravidians and Austrics, segregated them through caste, and founded Indian civilisation. This explained upper-caste superiority and an **Aryan–Dravidian racial divide** ("motivated fancy").
- Everything of value in India was credited to **European origins**, "unhistorical".
- **Romantic exaggeration** (Jones): Sanskrit "more perfect than the Greek"; Plato and Pythagoras borrowed from India; India invented the decimal scale, grammar and chess; even Newtonian theory was in the Vedas. These claims were balm to a conquered people but **bred chauvinism**, and extreme nationalist historians later "read into the sources things that were not there".

Reading Orientalism through Edward Said (lecture) MUST KNOW

Edward Said, *Orientalism* (1978): European scholarship on "the East" was not only academic inquiry but part of a wider relationship of **power, representation and colonial authority**. "The Orient" was not simply *discovered* by European scholars; it was **constructed** through European systems of knowledge.

"Orientalism" means…	Explanation
An academic field	The study of Asian and Middle Eastern languages, cultures, texts, religions and histories
A style of thought	Dividing the world into "Occident" and "Orient"
A discourse of power	Knowledge that helped Europe **define, govern and dominate** the East

Orientalist activity	Colonial function
Translating Hindu law texts	Helped colonial courts administer "native law"
Studying Sanskrit and Persian	Helped officials communicate and govern
Classifying castes, religions, customs	Made society "legible" to the colonial state
Reconstructing ancient chronology	Placed India in a European framework
Archaeological surveys	Mapped and catalogued India's past under colonial authority

THE BALANCED VERDICT (USE THIS IN ESSAYS)

British scholars studied Indian texts partly out of **genuine curiosity**, but that knowledge also helped officials **classify** Indian society, and classification made administration easier. The scholar, translator, judge, collector and administrator were often the **same person** (Jones was a judge). So Sreedharan's chapter can be read through Said: the Orientalists **genuinely contributed** to recovering ancient India through philology, translation, epigraphy, archaeology and chronology, but this visibility was produced **within colonial power**. The India they recovered was also an India **classified, translated, textualised and represented through European categories**. **The result was double-edged.**

4.3 British imperialist (colonial) historiography MUST KNOW

After **Plassey (1757)**, three schools competed over how to govern India:

School	Who	View of India and policy
Conservative / Orientalist	Warren Hastings, Wilkins, Jones, Colebrooke; later Elphinstone, Munro, Malcolm, H.H. Wilson	High opinion of early Hindu civilisation; change slowly, with respect for old institutions
Evangelical	John Shore, **Charles Grant** (*Observations on the State of Society among the Asiatic Subjects…*), missionaries	"Hideous state of Indian society": cure by **Christianity and Western education**
Utilitarian	Jeremy **Bentham**, **James Mill**	Test everything by **utility**; remake Indian society through **laws, education and a despotic government**

James Mill, *The History of British India* (1818) MUST KNOW

- Begun 1806, published 1818. Mill was a Benthamite utilitarian and East India Company official in London who **never visited India**. Motive: to apply utilitarian doctrine to the governance of India, with Indian decadence supplying the argument for reform.
- **Method failures:** he reached his conclusions *before* writing; held the Orientalists and their primary-source work in contempt; relied on **travellers' reports** and hostile, partial witnesses (Orme; Buchanan; Tennant, "a most superficial observer"; Tytler, who knew India only through criminal courts; Abbé Dubois, a missionary); cited hostile testimony and ignored favourable testimony, including the 1813 parliamentary evidence. C.H. Philips: he "attached the greatest weight to the writers who are least entitled to confidence". *(A perfect example of what Backerra's source criticism is meant to prevent.)*
- **Judgements** (Book Two, 500 pages): Hindu laws could only exist "under… one of the rudest and weakest states of the human mind"; Europe even in feudal times was superior; **"the Hindu, like the Eunuch, excels in the qualities of a slave"**; "human nature in India gained… by passing from a Hindu to a Muhammadan government". British rule was better than either.
- **Periodisation** into **Hindu, Muslim and British** periods, still with us today.
- **Influence:** editions in 1818, 1820, 1826, 1840 and 1848 (H.H. Wilson's annotated edition). Macaulay called it "the greatest historical work… since Gibbon"; it shaped his *Minute on Indian Education*. It was the **textbook at Haileybury College (1805–1855)**, where civil servants were trained, so administrators came to India with "illusions of the permanence of British rule" and "imperial dogmatism".
- **Critics: H.H. Wilson**, the leading Orientalist, said the comparisons ignored time and circumstance (were Britons in Caesar's day more civilised than Hindus then?), and that the book **destroyed sympathy between ruler and ruled**, **created aversion** to Indians, and encouraged **British monopoly of all posts of power and honour**, helping lead towards 1857. **R.C. Majumdar**: "so much prodigious labour has been misdirected to produce a historical work which by any canon of criticism does not deserve the name."

Mountstuart Elphinstone, *History of Hindu and Mohammadan India* (1841) SUPPORTING

- A scholar-administrator (governor of Bombay, retired 1827) and a critic of Mill. A **Romanticist**: human nature differs by region, period and people, so the historian should **understand rather than judge** (unlike Mill's Enlightenment-utilitarian universalism). His criticism of Mill was implicit and cautious.
- Used **native sources** and personal observation (William Erskine's chronicles); rejected the four *yugas*; started with the Rig Veda (dated 14th c. BC); fixed Chandragupta and counted backwards and forwards. His **chronological framework is still broadly accepted**.
- Weak on political history, but **"laid the foundations of the cultural history of India"**: society, religion, arts, trade, the north–south distinction, and even Indian maritime activity and colonisation of Java and Bali. Used at Haileybury from 1841 and hailed as the **"Tacitus of India"**. Yet even he wrote that "want of veracity" was the Hindus' most prominent vice.
- His followers: **Grant Duff**, *History of the Marathas* (1825, from the Peshwa papers, printed at his own expense); **Erskine**, translation of the *Babur-nama*; **James Tod**, *Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan* (1812–23), rich in legend and romance.

The Mill tradition persists; late-19th-century imperial ideas SUPPORTING

- **Henry Elliot & John Dowson**, *The History of India as Told by its own Historians* (8 vols, 1867–77): translated Persian chronicles. Elliot's preface poured scorn on Muslim rule, as Mill had on Hindu, so that "our native subjects" would appreciate "the mildness and equity of our rule". All later histories of Muslim rule relied on it.
- Ideas of the age: **race superiority** (Lord Rosebery: "What is empire but the predominance of race"); **Social Darwinism** and "survival of the fittest"; **Kipling's "White Man's Burden"** (1899: "half-devil and half-child"); the **"civilising mission"**; Seeley's *Expansion of England* (1883); Curzon. J.S. Mill justified despotism in India: a despot responsible to a free people 12,000 miles away is better than one responsible to none.

The administrator-historians (c.1870–1940) MUST KNOW

E.T. Stokes divides them into **"popular"** historians (who explain the British empire by **individual character**) and **"philosophic"** historians (who explain it by **impersonal forces**, using Sanskrit studies). Both reached the same conclusion: **British rule must continue**.

Historian	Key works	Argument
Macaulay; Malleson; Hunter's *Rulers of India* (28 vols)	*Essay on Clive*, *Warren Hastings*	**Popular**: biography of heroic Englishmen; superior British character. Malleson: Indians brave but "incapable of combination".
James Fitzjames **Stephens**	*Liberty, Equality, Fraternity* (1873)	Utilitarian and Social Darwinist: the strongest rule; Britain is to India what **Rome** was to the Mediterranean; rule by law and force indefinitely.
Henry **Maine**	*Ancient Law* (1861); Rede lectures (1875)	The Indian village community is a surviving **Aryan** institution; India is the "infancy of the human mind prolonged", arrested at an early stage; Britain transmits progress.
J. Talboys **Wheeler**	*History of India* (5 vols)	Brahman tyranny killed public spirit and nationality; the Mughal system was "a monstrous system of oppression"; India was saved only by European rule.
Alfred **Lyall**	*Asiatic Studies*; *Rise and Expansion of the British Dominion* (1894)	The conquest was quick because India **lacked any permanent organisation** (nationalities, aristocracies); a "loose conglomeration of tribes, races and castes"; refuted Seeley's "accidental" conquest (it was part of European expansion); favoured some decentralisation (Ripon) but never giving up control.
W.W. **Hunter**	*Annals of Rural Bengal* (1868); *Indian Mussalman* (1876); *Imperial Gazetteer*	A pioneer of economic history: "The silent millions who bear our yoke have found no annalist." Caste originated in Aryan–aboriginal racial distinction; British rule was the "epic of the British nation" (1600–1750 endurance) and would break barriers to create a united nation, under paternal authority.

Vincent **Smith** (1848–1920)	*Early History of India* (1904); *Oxford History of India* (1919)	Standard college textbooks. Sympathetic to ancient culture (Gupta age like Elizabethan England) but **imperialist in politics**: **66 of 478 pages on Alexander** to show "the inherent weakness of… Asiatic armies"; only "autocracy" and "despotism" in India; chaos after Harsha shows India needs the "benevolent despotism" holding it "in its iron grasp".
E.B. **Havell**	*History of Aryan Rule in India* (1918)	A dissenting voice: Aryans gave India panchayat democracy, so India deserves self-government. "No greater spiritual injury can be done to a people than to teach them to despise the achievement of their forefathers."
W.H. **Moreland** (1868–1938)	*India at the Death of Akbar* (1920); *From Akbar to Aurangzeb* (1931); *Agrarian System of Moslem India* (1929)	Primacy of the **economic factor** (agriculture and land revenue); continuity of the revenue system; the British as agents of a money economy. Mughal rule was a *damnosa hereditas* (a legacy of loss). Polemics against Congress (revenue below 10%, "what Manu thought reasonable"). A "true historian" with a narrowed vision.

OVERVIEW: THE ASSUMPTIONS OF IMPERIALIST HISTORIOGRAPHY MUST KNOW

1. **A static, unchanging Indian society** (Mill), which influenced **Hegel** (India outside world history). Christian Lassen recast Mill's three periods as Hegelian thesis (Hindu), antithesis (Muslim), synthesis (Christian).
2. **Oriental despotism**: unchanging, politically indifferent villages with no private property in land, and despots on top. **Marx** turned this into the **Asiatic Mode of Production** (self-sufficient villages, no private landed property). Maine, Durkheim and Weber accepted it.
3. **Purpose:** if India never changed, the British could present themselves as the **catalyst of change**, the *raison d'être* of their rule. Even Max Müller's "our Aryan brother" became a reason to explain why Indian Aryans failed (blamed on **caste**).
4. **Dominance of the political element**: British prejudice, moralising, value-laden judgements, focus on the British period, and an English readership. Example: **Morley** told **Gokhale** that a fur coat needed in Canada was not needed in the Deccan (denying India the self-government given to Canada and Australia).

4.4 Indian nationalist historiography: history as cultural vindication MUST KNOW

CONTEXT

After a phase of imitating Western ways, educated Indians wanted to make India "more Indian and less English", to **revitalise** rather than replace their culture (as Ram Mohun Roy wanted). This "renaissance" needed a **historical consciousness**. **Bankim Chandra Chatterjee**: "There is no Hindu history. Who will praise our noble qualities if we do not praise them ourselves? … The Hindus have no such glorious qualities simply because there is no written evidence." In the first half of the 20th century, **nationalism supplied the ideology for historical investigation**.

What nationalists were reacting against SUPPORTING

- Mill's condemnation; Elphinstone on Hindu "want of veracity" and his surprise that the Arabs did not overrun India; Smith on European military superiority and India's "endemic chaos".
- R.C. Majumdar lists the belittling: Elphinstone assumed that India's foreign trade was carried by Greeks and Arabs despite the *Periplus*; the **lowest possible dates** for the Vedas and epics; claims that Indians **borrowed everything** (the epics from Homer, drama, mathematics and astronomy from the Greeks, the Krishna cult from Christ).
- **Joseph Needham**: the trigonometric **sine** was used in India from the Gupta period, not by the Greeks, yet Tannery assumed it must be Greek simply because Indians could not have invented it.
- Selective focus on weaknesses: Hindu **sati** condemned while European witch-hunting was forgotten; **caste** condemned while slavery and serfdom were passed over.

Definition (R.C. Majumdar): nationalist historians are Indians who examine or re-examine "points of national interest… which have been misunderstood or misconceived or wrongly represented". This is "not necessarily in conflict with a scientific and critical study"; a nationalist historian is not necessarily "a propagandist or a charlatan".

What nationalist historians did (the lecture's key figures in bold) MUST KNOW

Domain	What was argued
Religion & society	An extreme school (Rajnarain Bose, Bankim, Sasadhar Tarkachudamani) defended Hinduism in all its forms. **Dayananda Saraswati** defended it rationally: only Vedic religion is true, and idolatry, caste and sati are later accretions. Caste was explained as division of labour; Vedic women were said to have had high status.
Material culture	**R.C. Dutt**, *Civilization in Ancient India* (1889, 3 vols), which Majumdar calls the **first nationalist history "in the best sense"**: moderate and scientific (Rig Veda c.1200 BC). Extremists went further: **Tilak** dated the Rig Veda to **4000 BC** from astronomy; A.C. Das to geological epochs; there were claims of firearms and aeroplanes in the epics. **R.K. Mookerji**, *History of Indian Shipping* (1912), answered Elphinstone. Some claimed India was the Aryan homeland.
Politics	Against "India is not a nation": **R.K. Mookerji**, *The Fundamental Unity of India* (1914). Against Oriental despotism: **K.P. Jayaswal**, *Hindu Polity* (1918), which claimed republics, limited monarchy, a sovereign *samiti*, a *sabha*, *paura-janapada*, quorum, referendum, even an "address from the throne" and "voting of grants".
Military	Easy conquest explained away: Plassey (1757) blamed on treachery but **Buxar** (1764) forgotten; Sikh defeats blamed on bribery, but Chilianwala credited to Sikh skill.
Hostility to the British	**Dadabhai Naoroji** and R.C. Dutt were moderate. **B.D. Basu** was well documented but scathing. Titles like *Clive, the Forger*; Siraj ud-Daulah and Mir Kasim made patriots; the Black Hole called a myth.
Reinterpretation	**V.D. Savarkar** renamed 1857 the **"Indian War of Independence"**; S.B. Chaudhuri stressed civil rebellions. Some historians reinterpreted medieval history to show Hindu–Muslim brotherhood (Tarachand, *Influence of Islam on Indian Culture*) to counter communalism.

WEAKNESSES

- **Methodological lapses**: making history serve present issues. Basham on Jayaswal: he used sources "in the manner of a **barrister** trying to win a favourable judgement", stressing supporting passages and ignoring contrary evidence.
- **Chauvinism**: "from patriotism to chauvinism is but a step". **Romila Thapar**: "unashamed glorification of the ancient Indian past… **a compensation for the humiliating present**." Examples: the Indian origin of Aryans, Vedic culture older than Harappa, spiritual India vs materialist West, political unity from the earliest times.
- **Self-contradiction**: military power vs non-violence; democracy vs imperial glory; spiritual vs worldly; high status of women vs their seclusion.
- **Communalism**: Hindu accounts of Rajput, Maratha and Sikh struggles against Muslims provoked Muslim counter-histories. "Communalism… had its roots in the writing of history, too."

STRENGTHS

- The **greatest stimulant** of historical studies in India: national feeling drove scholars into the sources (monuments, epigraphs, coins, literature).
- Thapar: by writing against imperialism they **took a fresh look at sources**; history moved from the antiquarian's collection of facts to **narration and interpretation**; debates led into social and economic history.
- The growth of **regional and local history** (Bengal, Maharashtra; Nilakanta Sastri's south India) corrected generalisations based on the Ganges heartland.
- The birth of **economic history**: William Digby, *Prosperous British India*; **Naoroji's "drain theory"**; **R.C. Dutt's *Economic History of India* (1904)** located India's malady in the **agrarian problem**, which became the economic platform of the national movement.
- **Cultural history** (Tagore's idea; Panikkar: "we had each to 'discover India for ourselves'… a spiritual adventure").

Modern Indian historians: who's who SUPPORTING

Mostly nationalist in character until the 1960s: political, dynastic and cultural. Preliminary editing was done by Bhagawanlal Indraji, Bhau Daji and Rajendralal Mitra. The lecture names **R.C. Majumdar, K.P. Jayaswal, R.G. Bhandarkar and H.C. Raychaudhuri**; learn these first.

Historian	Key works	What to remember
R.G. Bhandarkar (1837–1923)	*Early History of the Deccan* (1884); *A Peep into the Early History of India* (1900)	The **earliest indigenous modern historian**; rigorous source criticism ("critical, comparative and historical method"); a historian should be an impartial judge seeking "dry truth", not an advocate; criticised V.A. Smith; Rankean; not anti-British; Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, Poona.
R.C. Dutt (1848–1909)	*Literature of Bengal* (1877); *Civilization in Ancient India*; *Economic History of India* (1904)	An ICS officer; literature as a source for social history; drain theory and agrarian focus; "cease to act under mandates from Manchester"; protection; criticised Home Charges.
K.P. Jayaswal (1881–1937)	*Hindu Polity* (1918); *History of India c. AD 150–350*	An Oxford-trained lawyer; republics and limited monarchy; made heroes of the Bharasiva-Nagas against the Saka-Kushans; "patriotism outran historical probity" (questioned by Ghoshal and Altekar), but his account of republics remained a framework.
Radha Kumud Mookerji (1880–1963)	*Indian Shipping* (1912); *Fundamental Unity of India* (1914); *Local Self-Government in Ancient India*; *The Gupta Empire*; *Hindu Civilization*	Patriotic but careful; the most exhaustive writer on ancient India.
H.C. Raychaudhuri (1892–1957)	*Political History of Ancient India* (1923)	A sober chronology from Parikshit (9th c. BC) to the Guptas, letting **Indian chronology start from the 9th century BC**; compared to Niebuhr; replaced Smith as the standard textbook; Basham detects a Hindu nationalist undertone.
G.S. Sardesai (1865–1957)	*Marathi Riyasat* (8 vols); *Peshwa Daftar* (45 vols, with Jadunath Sarkar); *New History of the Marathas*	Thorough but not critical; purely political.
Jadunath Sarkar (1870–1958)	*History of Aurangzeb* (1912–24); *Shivaji and his Times* (1919); *Fall of the Mughal Empire* (1932–50)	The greatest Indian historian of his time ("like Ranke and Mommsen"): multilingual original sources, site visits, merciless textual criticism. "I would not mind… whether truth is… a blow to the glory of my country." His *Shivaji* upset Poona nationalists.
S. Krishnaswami Aiyangar (1871–1953)	*Some Contributions of South India to Indian Culture*; *History of Tirupati*	South Indian chronology (Sangam literature in the early centuries CE; Pallavas not foreigners); Chola maritime relations with the Sailendras; edited the *Journal of Indian History*; don't distort history even for noble aims.
Shafaat Ahmad Khan	*East India Trade in the 17th Century*	Ranke–Acton line: the historian as judge; history must include the feelings of the ruled.
Surendranath Sen (1890–1962)	*Administrative System of the Marathas*; *Military System*; *India through Chinese Eyes*; *Eighteen Fifty-Seven* (1957)	The Marathas were not mere plunderers; on 1857, a "national war" only in Oudh and Shahabad, not a mere military rising; objective.
K.M. Panikkar (1895–1963)	*India and the Indian Ocean* (1945); *Survey of Indian History* (1947); *Asia and Western Dominance* (1953)	The geographical and geopolitical angle: "India never lost its independence till it lost command of the sea" (16th c.); the "Vasco da Gama epoch" (1498–1945); Aryo-Dravidian synthesis; accused of Hindu bias.
K.A. Nilakanta Sastri (1892–1975)	*The Cholas*; *A History of South India* (1955); *History of Srivijaya*; *Foreign Notices of South India*	Brought the **south** into national perspective (Thapar), with an emphasis on chronology and politics; Southeast Asian links.

R.C. Majumdar (1888–1980)	*Corporate Life in Ancient India* (1918); *Ancient Indian Colonies in the Far East*; editor of *History and Culture of the Indian People* (11 vols)	Rankean "show what really happened"; called Southeast Asian states "Hindu colonies" (in the cultural sense); 1857 was not a national war but "the dying process of an obsolete aristocracy"; saw deep Hindu–Muslim animosity under the Sultanate. "History, divorced from truth, does not help a nation."

BACKGROUND: MODERN MUSLIM HISTORIOGRAPHY ON MEDIEVAL INDIA (PETER HARDY) BACKGROUND

No Muslim historian wrote on medieval Muslim India until the 1920s because: Syed Ahmad Khan's priority was religious reform; after 1857 Muslims needed to conciliate the British; the Aligarh school was non-communal and did not want to stir memories; and Aligarh's syllabus favoured European history.

Muhammad Habib (*Mahmud of Ghaznin*): Mahmud plundered for glory and gold, not Islam; a Marxist-flavoured "urban revolution" and "rural revolution" under the Turks (too good to be true). **K.M. Ashraf** (*Life and Conditions of the People of Hindustan*, 1935): no fundamental revolution, classes as haves and have-nots, Hindu–Muslim cultural fusion. **Nazim**, **I.H. Qureshi**, **Faruki** (an apology for Aurangzeb against Sarkar) and **Jaffar** show "an unresolved tension between Islam and Indian nationalism" and an "Islamic apologetic". Hardy: in Habib, "Islam has absorbed Marxism".

4.5 The Marxist phase: the "new history" MUST KNOW

WHAT MADE IT NEW

Influential after independence. Not all its practitioners were Marxists, but they adopted a **materialist interpretation** (dialectical materialism) and treated history as a **social science**, studying the relation between **social and economic organisation** and historical events. Crucially, it called **"not so much for new evidence as for a re-reading of the sources with a different set of questions in mind."** Focus: **class relations, modes of production, agrarian structures, surplus extraction, caste and economy, state formation.** Key figures: **D.D. Kosambi, R.S. Sharma, Irfan Habib, Romila Thapar, Bipan Chandra** ("Marxist-nationalist") and **Sumit Sarkar**.

D.D. Kosambi (1907–1966): the patriarch

- Works: *An Introduction to the Study of Indian History* (1956) and *The Culture and Civilization of Ancient India in Historical Outline* (1965) "revolutionised Indian historiography"; also *Myth and Reality*, *Exasperating Essays*. No writer since Mill and Smith had so deeply influenced Indian history.
- **Definition of history:** "the presentation, **in chronological order**, of successive developments in the **means and relations of production**." Reliable records and chronology for ancient India are lacking, but we can know how people lived. "Man makes himself" (Gordon Childe) by making tools; social organisation cannot be more advanced than the means of production. This is the only definition that allows treatment of **prehistory**.
- **Comparative and interdisciplinary method**: India is full of "living survivals of the dead past". He used archaeology, field work on microliths and routes, ethnography (tribal clusters, red-painted village deities as relics of blood sacrifice, joint burials), philology (Hittite *khatti* = Sanskrit *kshatriya*), and statistics (weighing **punch-marked coins**).
- **From tribe to caste**: plough agriculture, introduced through Brahmanical settlement, broke tribes and clans, and caste became the new form of organisation; clan totems became caste names; local cults were Sanskritised.
- **Myths** reflect social change (Pururavas and Urvasi: sacred marriage, the transition from matriliny to patriliny).
- **Indus**: thought the Harappans had no plough and that Aryans destroyed the dams (Indra freeing the waters from Vrtra). **Thapar corrects him**: the plough was known even pre-Harappan, and the Vedic word for the plough is non-Aryan.
- **Aryans**: rejected an Aryan *race* but accepted Aryan-speaking conquerors (iron, horse); Indian tradition was an **amalgam** of Aryan and non-Aryan from the start.

- **Buddhism and Jainism**: economic causes (technology, detribalisation, urbanism, new classes of *grihapatis* (landowning peasants) and *shreshtis* (rich traders) who wanted peace and a universal ethic). **Ahimsa** had an economic basis: Vedic sacrifice consumed cattle needed for plough agriculture. Mercantile patronage rooted these faiths more deeply than royal patronage did.
- Thapar's assessment: not a mechanical Marxist. He rejected the **Asiatic Mode of Production** wholesale and qualified feudalism.

R.S. Sharma, Romila Thapar, Irfan Habib, Bipan Chandra

Historian	Key works and arguments
R.S. Sharma	***Sudras in Ancient India*** (1958): iron for large-scale cultivation turned egalitarian Vedic society into a class society by the 6th c. BC; the varna system procured labour; a "vaisya-sudra formation". ***Indian Feudalism*** (1966): land grants to temples, Brahmanas and officials, serfdom, decline of towns, trade and money from the Guptas to the 12th c. ***Urban Decay in India*** (1987): archaeological evidence of urban decline after the 3rd c. AD, linked to falling long-distance trade (end of the Han, Kushan, Parthian and Satavahana empires). *Material Culture and Social Formations* (1983): PGW and NBP pottery, iron, paddy, coins, towns, states.
Romila Thapar	***Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas*** (1963): **Dhamma as political and social necessity**, a binding ethic for a diverse empire, not just moral idealism; the empire fell because it was over-centralised and lacked the idea of the state above the king. *History of India* vol. 1 (1966). *Ancient Indian Social History* (1978): Buddhism as social protest; social mobility. **1969 Indian History Congress address**: no massive Aryan invasion (small groups with iron and horses spread the language); caste was not light versus dark skin (use social anthropology); later Vedic texts were not purely Aryan. ***From Lineage to State*** (1984): state formation in the Ganga valley, from lineage society to state (iron, plough, grihapatis, shreshtis, towns, coins, tax, standing army). *Interpreting Early India* (1992): refuted the **Aryan race theory** and **Oriental despotism** (private property in the Dharmashastras and Arthashastra, urban centres from Harappa onwards, coins and credit).
Irfan Habib	*Interpreting Indian History*: **interpretation makes the historian**; medieval India was its own social formation (tax = rent, a centralised despotic state, not feudal). ***The Agrarian System of Mughal India***: the main contradiction was between the **state and the peasantry**; the revenue drive drove peasants to revolt, and the empire was "its own grave-digger"; economic tyranny, not religion, explains opposition to Aurangzeb. *Caste and Money*; *Problems of Marxist Historiography* (against rigid universal stages); *An Atlas of the Mughal Empire*; *Cambridge Economic History of India* vol. 1 (Mughal population c.1600: 140–150 million, 85% rural).
Bipan Chandra	*The Rise and Growth of Economic Nationalism* (ideas matter as agents, but the leaders championed capitalist growth); *Nationalism and Colonialism*; *India's Struggle for Independence 1857–1947*, which **attacks the Cambridge School** (nationalism *was* a people's movement) and notes that Marxists like Palme Dutt miss its "open-ended, all-class character"; *Communalism in Modern India* (a by-product of colonialism with a middle-class base; virulent after 1937).

ASSESSMENT: WHY MARXIST HISTORY WAS AN ADVANCE

- **Broadened the scope** from state to society, from soldiers and statesmen to **the people**; dynastic history went out of fashion and politics became a backdrop.
- **Interdisciplinary and primary sources**: linguistics, sociology, anthropology, statistics; **archaeology** (PGW, NBP) seen as bias-free physical evidence (Sharma's *Urban Decay* is almost wholly archaeological).
- Strong on **origins**: state formation in the Ganga valley (Kosambi, Sharma, Thapar) was "a triumph of materialist historiography".
- **Explanation and interpretation** instead of narrative; processes over events.
- **Critique of Western clichés**: the Asiatic Mode of Production, Oriental despotism, the Aryan race, static society; evidence of urbanism and social mobility.

SREEDHARAN'S CRITICISMS

- **Different conclusions from the same theory**: Kosambi's no-plough Harappa is unlikely; **Sharma** says Buddhism accepted slave-keeping and money-lending while **Thapar** says Buddhism disapproved of slavery.
- **The economics of ahimsa** lacks quantitative evidence: how many cattle were really sacrificed? The Suttanipata itself says "brahmins of old did *not* kill cattle", so why a taboo, and why would Brahmanists obey it?
- **Jargon**: Bipan Chandra's and Habib's "contradictions" are "exercises in obscurity" (Thapar is exempted).
- Interpretation must not leave the **factual basis**.
- (Lecture model answer: class can become a rigid **"master explanation"**, undervaluing culture, religion, region and ideas.)

4.6 The Cambridge School: politics, patronage and local interests MUST KNOW

- Associated with **Anil Seal, John Gallagher, Gordon Johnson and Christopher Bayly**.
- **Challenged nationalist interpretations** of the freedom movement.
- Emphasised **local politics, patron–client networks, elite competition, provincial interests, factionalism**, and **collaboration and negotiation with colonial power**.
- Saw Indian nationalism **less as a unified idealist movement** and more as a product of **political mobilisation and elite bargaining** (Sreedharan's chapter 15 calls this the view that nationalism was the "response of the Indian bourgeois elite to the stimulus provided by British ideas, institutions, opportunities and resources").

EVALUATION

It **usefully highlighted local politics and networks**, but critics argue it **underestimated ideology, mass politics, anti-colonial commitment and popular nationalism**. Bipan Chandra and the Marxists attacked it, and Subaltern Studies (Guha) attacked it as **elitist**.

4.7 Subaltern Studies: a historiography of protest ("history from below")

MUST KNOW

RANAJIT GUHA'S ARGUMENT (SUBALTERN STUDIES VOL. 1, 1982)

The historiography of Indian nationalism suffered from **two kinds of elitism**, both treating nationalism as an **elite achievement**: (1) **colonial/imperialist** (and Cambridge) history, in which nationalism is the response of Indian elites to British stimuli; and (2) **Indian nationalist** history, in which Indian elites led the people from subjection to freedom. Neither recognises the **contribution made by the people on their own**, so neither can explain popular upsurges like the **anti-Rowlatt agitation of 1919** or **Quit India (1942)**. Parallel to elite politics there was an autonomous **domain of people's politics**, whose principal actors were the **subaltern classes**.

- **"Subaltern"** is a term from **Antonio Gramsci** meaning "of inferior rank", whether of class, caste, age, gender or office. Associated especially with **Ranajit Guha and Gayatri Spivak**; a collective of the 1980s.
- Focus: **peasants, workers, tribals/adivasis, lower castes, women, marginalised communities**; **popular initiative, insurgency, consciousness, autonomous politics**; subaltern consciousness (religion, superstition, views of the elite). Guha: the peasant **never stumbled into rebellion**; he rebelled **consciously** when petitions failed.
- Marxian in tone, but it upset conventional Marxist historiography as well. It **radically widened the subject of history**, giving agency to people earlier seen as "crowds, mobs, or followers".

Contributor (SS vol.)	Study
David Arnold (1, 3)	Hillmen's rebellions in the Gudem and Rampa tracts of Andhra (1839–1924); peasant experience of the Madras famine (1876–78)
Gyan Pandey (1)	Peasant revolts in Awadh (1919–22)
Stephen Henningham (2)	Quit India in Bihar and eastern UP as a **"dual revolt"**: elite nationalist plus subaltern rebellion
Arvind Das (2)	Bihar land reforms (zamindari abolition, bhoodan) were responses to **peasant pressure** (Kisan Sabha, Telangana), not elite gifts
Dipesh Chakrabarty (2, 3)	Calcutta jute-mill workers; elitism even in left unions ("babu–coolie" relations)
Shahid Amin (3)	How **Gandhi's charisma** was registered in peasant belief in miracles
David Hardiman (3)	The Devi movement among south Gujarat tribals
Sumit Sarkar (3)	Swadeshi stayed upper-caste bhadralok; in Non-Cooperation/Khilafat, popular initiative alarmed the leaders
Ramachandra Guha (4)	Forest protest in British Kumaun (1893–1921): the roots of Chipko
Tanika Sarkar (4)	Jitu Santhal's movement in Malda (1924–32), whose leadership the elites credited to "outside agitators"
Gautam Bhadra (4)	"Four Rebels of 1857" (Shah Mal, Devi Singh, Gonoo, Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah): Gramsci's "multiple elements of conscious leadership"

ASSESSMENT (SREEDHARAN)

Weaknesses: a loose, negative **elite/subaltern dichotomy**; no theme beyond popular militancy; **fragmented** topics with no sustained narrative ("sub-history"); risk of essentialism (lecture). **Strengths:** it recovers neglected records, **reopens questions** thought settled, and **restores individuals and groups** considered too low for history. These "sagas of struggle" can be woven into mainstream history to enrich it.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 4

Ancient India seemed to lack "genuine" records, so it was **recovered** by Orientalists from texts, language, inscriptions, coins and sites: Jones and the **Asiatic Society (1784)**, the Indo-European languages, **Sandrocottas = Chandragupta (325 BC, the "sheet anchor")**, Prinsep's **Brahmi (1834)**, Cunningham's archaeology. Its achievements were real but it had a **seamy side** (the Aryan race theory, exaggeration), and through **Said** it was knowledge produced within colonial power: **double-edged**. **Colonial historiography** (Mill 1818, Elliot & Dowson, Maine, Lyall, Hunter, Smith, Moreland) built clichés of a **static society and Oriental despotism** to justify rule. **Nationalists** (Dutt, Bhandarkar, Jayaswal, Mookerji, Raychaudhuri, Sarkar, Majumdar) vindicated Indian civilisation, sometimes with chauvinism, but founded economic, regional and cultural history. **Marxists** (Kosambi, Sharma, Thapar, Habib, Bipan Chandra) re-read the sources for production, class and state formation. The **Cambridge School** stressed elite bargaining; **Subaltern Studies** (Guha) recovered history from below.

EXAM CORNER

1. **(Sample essay)** Evaluate the claim that the shift from colonial and nationalist history to Marxist "new history" was a major advance (see the model plan on p. 3).
2. How was ancient Indian history "recovered"? Assess the strengths and weaknesses of the Orientalist recovery (use Said).
3. Why did James Mill's *History of British India* become so influential, and why is it criticised as bad history?
4. Compare the Cambridge School and Subaltern Studies on Indian nationalism.
5. Assess the strengths and weaknesses of nationalist historiography.

MCQ facts: Asiatic Society 1784 (Jones, patron Hastings); first direct Sanskrit→English translation = Wilkins's Gita (1784); Jones's Shakuntala 1789; "sheet anchor" = Chandragupta–Sandrocottas, 325 BC; Prinsep (Calcutta Mint) deciphered Brahmi in 1834; Cunningham = ASI; Mill 1818, Haileybury 1805–55; Elphinstone = "Tacitus of India" (1841); "the silent millions… found no annalist" = Hunter; *Hindu Polity* = Jayaswal; Kosambi's definition = means and relations of production; "subaltern" from Gramsci; Guha 1982.

SESSION 6

India through the Eyes of Foreign Travellers: Travel Writing as a Historical Source

Readings: Tansen Sen, "The Travel Records of Chinese Pilgrims Faxian, Xuanzang, and Yijing: Sources for Cross-Cultural Encounters between Ancient China and Ancient India", *Education About Asia* 11:3 (2006), pp. 24–33 (OT3) · M.S. Khan, "A Twelfth Century Arab Account of Indian Religions and Sects", *Arabica* 30:2 (1983), pp. 199–208 (OT4)

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 4 showed that ancient India seemed to lack "genuine" historical records. **So how can historians reconstruct periods with no Indian records?** One answer is **foreign travellers**. This session applies Session 2's **source criticism** to two traditions: **Chinese Buddhist pilgrims** (eyewitnesses with a religious purpose) and an **Arab scholar** (al-Shahrastani, who never came to India). The core lesson: **travel writing is both evidence and interpretation**. It also opens Part C of the course: travellers reveal **a history of connections, not isolation**.

6.1 Why study foreign travellers? MUST KNOW

Possible sources for India's past: **archaeology** (physical remains), **inscriptions** (official records in stone or metal), **coins** (rulers, dates, trade), **literary texts** (religious and courtly works), and **foreign travellers** (outsider accounts of everyday life).

Foreigners often noticed **everyday details** (diet, dress, city life) that local writers **took for granted** and rarely recorded, because they were observing an **unfamiliar society**.

Learning objectives (lecture)

1. Explain what travel writings are as historical sources.
2. Identify different **motivations** behind foreign travel (pilgrimage, trade, faith, curiosity).
3. Compare **Chinese and Arab** accounts.
4. Evaluate their **strengths and limitations** (eyewitness insight vs bias, language gaps, selective focus).
5. Appreciate how foreign accounts help reconstruct Indian history where indigenous records are scarce.

What is travel writing? MUST KNOW

A description of a society by someone who travelled outside their homeland, **blending firsthand experience with the traveller's own outlook**. It records geography, economy, cities, religion, customs, trade, political institutions, food and everyday life. It combines four layers:

1 · Observation — What the traveller directly witnessed
+
2 · Memory — Recalled later, often years afterward
+
3 · Interpretation — Filtered through their own worldview
+
4 · Personal opinion — Judgements about people and rulers

Method: how to read a travel account MUST KNOW

Travel narratives are not objective mirrors of reality. Historians ask:

Question	Why it matters
Why was the traveller visiting?	Purpose shapes what they noticed and recorded.
Who was the intended audience?	A report for a court differs from private notes (Xuanzang wrote for Emperor Taizong).
What languages did they know?	This limits what they could read, ask or verify (al-Biruni knew Sanskrit; al-Shahrastani did not).

What sources did they use?	Direct observation, hearsay, or earlier written accounts.
What did they ignore?	Absences are as telling as inclusions (al-Shahrastani omits Jainism and the Vedas).
What cultural assumptions shaped them?	Their beliefs coloured their judgements (al-Shahrastani's Islamic idea of "prophecy").

ADVANTAGES

- **Eyewitness observations**: direct testimony often unavailable in Indian sources.
- **Information unavailable elsewhere**: details locals had no reason to record.
- **Cross-cultural comparisons**: India compared with places they knew.
- **Independent perspective**: distance from local politics can mean less bias.

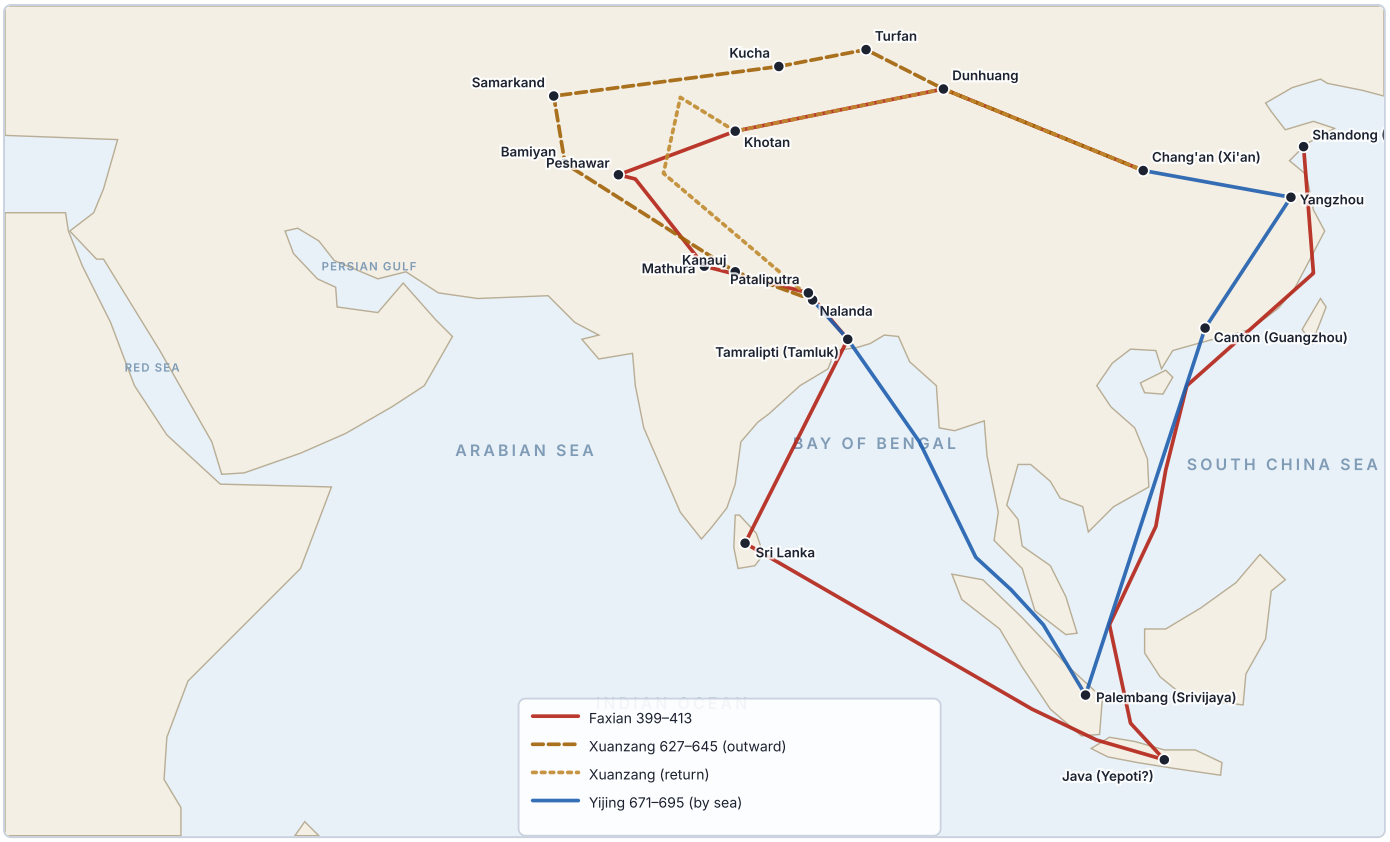
LIMITATIONS

- **Language barriers** and **dependence on interpreters**: meaning lost or distorted.
- **Religious bias**: faith shaped how customs were judged.
- **Limited geographical experience**: most saw only a fraction of the subcontinent.
- **Exaggeration**: marvels and dangers overstated.
- **Selective observation**: they noticed what struck them, not what was typical.

Foreign travellers to India: a timeline MUST KNOW

Traveller	Century	From	Purpose / nature
Megasthenes	4th c. BCE	Greece	Envoy (Seleukos) to Chandragupta's court; *Indica*
Faxian	5th c. CE (399–413)	China	Buddhist pilgrim, seeking Vinaya texts
Xuanzang	7th c. (627–645)	China	Pilgrim, scholar, quasi-diplomat
Yijing	7th c. (671–695)	China	Pilgrim by sea; monastic discipline
Al-Biruni	11th c. (973–1048)	Central Asia	Scholar who visited India and learned Sanskrit (*Kitab al-Hind*)
Al-Shahrastani	12th c. (1086–1153)	Persia	Scholar of comparative religion who **never visited** India

Lecture question: "Did all these travellers come for the same reason?" No: **diplomacy, pilgrimage, scholarship, curiosity**, and for later travellers (S7) **trade and law**.



Routes of the three Chinese pilgrims (approximate). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

6.2 The Chinese pilgrims (Tansen Sen) MUST KNOW

SEN'S FRAMING ARGUMENT

The spread of Buddhism from India to China from the **1st century CE** triggered cross-cultural exchanges with a profound impact on Asian and world history, involving missionaries, traders, artisans and medical professionals across Central and Southeast Asia. Chinese pilgrims introduced **new texts and doctrines**, carried **ritual paraphernalia**, and wrote detailed accounts. These records created a **unique Chinese perception of India**, for some a **sacred, even Utopian realm**, for others a land of **"civilized" and sophisticated people**. Since Chinese discourse usually described foreigners as uncivilised barbarians, this **elevated India's status**. The pilgrims' journeys became **channels for wider cultural exchange**, far beyond the transmission of religious texts alone.

Why these records are valuable (Sen): (1) meticulous accounts of **Buddhist doctrines, rituals and monastic institutions** in South, Central and Southeast Asia; (2) vital information on **social and political conditions** in South Asia and the kingdoms on the routes; (3) insight into **cross-cultural perceptions and interactions**; and (4) evidence of the hardships of **long-distance travel**, commercial exchange, and the **pilgrim–merchant relationship**.

Why Chinese pilgrims came (lecture): primary motivation **Buddhism**, to **collect scriptures**, **visit sacred places** linked to the Buddha's life, **study Sanskrit**, **learn from Indian monks**, and **carry texts back** for translation projects in Chinese monasteries.

Faxian (337?–422?) MUST KNOW

- One of the first and perhaps the **oldest** Chinese monks to travel to India: he left **Chang'an in 399, aged over 60**, and returned 14 years later, aged about 77.
- Route: across the **Taklamakan desert** → Central Asia → India's pilgrimage sites → **Sri Lanka** → a perilous **sea voyage back** via Southeast Asia.
- **Purpose** (stated in the opening of *A Record of the Buddhist Kingdoms*): to obtain **Vinaya texts** (monastic rules). Texts like the *Lotus Sutra* had been translated by the 3rd–4th centuries, but Vinaya texts, essential for running monasteries, were scarce. (Vinaya + Sutras + Abhidharma = the **Tripitaka**, the "three baskets".)
- In Central Asia: in **Loulan**, people dressed like Chinese but followed Indian customs, and monks read Indian books; in **Khotan**, every family had a small stupa before its door and monasteries hosted travelling monks.
- Highlights **Buddhist practices and legends**: at **Taxila**, the Buddha (in a previous life) gave his body to a starving tigress; conception at **Kapilavastu**, birth at **Lumbini**, nirvana at **Kushinagara**.
- **Relic veneration**: the Buddha's **alms-bowl at Peshawar**, the **tooth relic** ceremony in Sri Lanka led by the king. These records spread similar ceremonies to China and created **demand for relics**.
- **Monks and merchants were mutually beneficial**: monks hitchhiked on merchant caravans and ships; traders profited from new demand for ritual goods; monasteries gave traders **lodging and health care**, and traders gave **donations**.
- In 408/409 he sailed on a **merchant ship from Tamralipti** (eastern India) to Sri Lanka, stayed about two years, then sailed home through Southeast Asia: proof of **maritime channels** linking India and China, and that sea travel was **perilous and navigation rudimentary**.
- *A Record of the Buddhist Kingdoms* was the **first eyewitness account in Chinese** of Buddhist practice and pilgrimage sites in Central and South Asia. It was written in the **third person**, apparently by someone to whom he recounted it (translated by James Legge).
- **Borderland complex** (Antonino Forte): Chinese clergy felt melancholy at living in the "borderland", far from the Buddha's land. His companion **Daozheng** stayed in India: "I wish that I not be reborn in the borderland."
- **Impact on Chinese views of India:** Li Daoyuan (d. 527), commenting on the *Shui jing*, wrote, using Faxian, that south of Mathura is **Middle India (Madhyadesha)**, whose people are rich and "**dress and eat like people in China**", which was high praise in Chinese terms. (Wordplay: both used *Zhongguo*, "Middle Kingdom", for Middle India and for China.) This view of India as civilised lasted until about the 10th century.

Lecture summary: Faxian's main interests were Buddhist monasteries, Vinaya texts, pilgrimage centres and maritime travel. His historical contributions: one of the earliest outside accounts of **early Gupta India**; Buddhist institutions; **trade routes** linking India, Central Asia and China; Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.

Xuanzang (600?–664): "the greatest Chinese traveller to India" MUST KNOW

- A leading **Indophile** who promoted Buddhism and the image of India as a holy land, and lobbied his patrons, Tang emperors **Taizong** (r. 626–49) and **Gaozong** (r. 649–83), for **diplomatic exchange**.
- His book, ***The Records of the Western Regions Visited During the Great Tang Dynasty***, was written for his **royal patrons** as much as for the clergy, so he appears as both a **pious pilgrim and a diplomat for Tang China**. (His biography by Huili and Yancong was completed in 664.)
- Context: by **627** Buddhism was rooted in China; almost all basic texts had been translated; Chinese schools (e.g. **Tiantai**) were emerging; China transmitted Buddhism to Korea and Japan.
- **Motives:** visit sacred sites; dissatisfaction with Chinese translations: "When words are wrong, the meaning is lost, and when a phrase is mistaken, the doctrine becomes distorted." He wanted original texts and Indian teachers.
- **Success:** brought back **657 texts** and is one of the **three best translators** in ancient China. Emperor Taizong built the **Big (Great) Wild Goose Pagoda** in Chang'an to house them.
- He left **without official authorisation**, which may explain why he sought audiences with foreign rulers (protection, or to impress Taizong). This gives rare insight into the politics of Central and South Asian courts.
- Noted Indic influence in Central Asia: **Agni, Kucha and Khotan** used modified Indic scripts.
- **Fascicle two**, a general survey of India: the correct Chinese name for India should be **"Yindu"** (still used); geography, climate, measurement, concepts of time, urban life and architecture, **caste**, Brahmin education, Buddhist teaching, law and economy, social norms, eating habits, natural and manufactured products.
- **Fascicle five**: **Kanauj**, capital of **Harshavardhana**, reached in **637/638**. Harsha's empire stretched from north-west Bengal to the river Beas and had restored peace and prosperity to north India for the first time since the Guptas. Harsha had heard of a "compassionate" ruler in China; Xuanzang praised Taizong (reduced taxes, mild punishments). This meeting led to **diplomatic relations between Kanauj and the Tang court**, acknowledged by Tang official scribes. His motive may have been that the pilgrimage sites and **Nalanda** lay in Harsha's empire.
- **Borderland dialogue at Nalanda:** monks asked why he would return to China, "a borderland where… the Dharma [is] despised; the Buddhas are never born in that country". He replied that the Dharma must be spread, and that China was civilised, with laws and cultured people. This is **rare evidence of Indian perceptions of China**.
- His meticulous notes on **Bamiyan and Nalanda** help modern archaeologists. His reports of **urban decay** in the Ganges basin (Kushinagara, Vaishali) were used by **R.S. Sharma** (*Indian Feudalism*) for early medieval decline.

Lecture summary: he observed cities, universities (Nalanda), politics, society, economy, and religion (Buddhist, Hindu and Jain side by side). Historians value him because he is **among the richest sources for 7th-century India**; his observation was detailed, systematic and wide-ranging; and his account is often **cross-checked against and confirmed by archaeology and inscriptions**.

Yijing (635–713) MUST KNOW

- Travelled **mainly by sea**, 671–695; studied in **Srivijaya** (Sumatra) on the way. Less studied than Faxian and Xuanzang.
- Two works, completed and sent home **from Srivijaya**: ***A Record of Buddhism as Practised in India Sent Home from the Southern Seas*** (how doctrine and monastic rules were practised in India), and ***Memoirs of Eminent Monks who Visited India…*** (biographies of **56 Chinese monks** who went to India in the 7th century, some overland via Central Asia and Tibet, others by sea, some never returning).
- He wanted to **correct "errors" in Chinese practice**. He described **40 practices** in Indian monasteries (from cleansing after meals to ordination rules) and compared them with China. He allowed **compromise**: Indians eat with the right hand and never use chopsticks, but since the Vinaya neither allows nor forbids chopsticks, the Chinese may keep them, "for if we obstinately reject their use, people may laugh or complain".

- Example biography: **Xuanzhao** went via Tibet and Nepal; Emperor Gaozong sent him back to India for **longevity drugs and physicians**; he died before returning.
- His aim: "If you read this Record of mine, you may, **without moving one step, travel in all the five countries of India**", and to "build a **second Rajagriha** in the Divine Land of China". All the pilgrims tried to **recreate an Indic world in China**, so followers could make pilgrimage without the journey and **dispel the borderland complex**.

Lecture: Yijing focused on monastic discipline, Buddhist education, daily religious life and translation. His contribution: he shows **India within a larger Asian Buddhist world**, connecting it to Southeast Asian Buddhist centres.

> **WHAT CHINESE PILGRIMS TEACH HISTORIANS (LECTURE)**
>
> Their writings reveal **Buddhist networks** (links between monasteries across Asia), **universities** (Nalanda), **urban life**, **trade routes** (shared by monks and merchants), **diplomacy** (contacts between courts), and **cultural interaction**. **Key message: religion became a vehicle connecting Asia**, moving monks, texts and ideas along the same routes as merchants and goods.

6.3 Arab scholars and al-Shahrastani (M.S. Khan) MUST KNOW

Why were Arab scholars interested in India? SUPPORTING

Trade (sea and land routes); the **expansion of Islam** into South Asia; **scientific curiosity** (Indian mathematics, astronomy and philosophy fed the **translation movement in Baghdad**); and **comparative religion**. Comparative religion has been "rightly acclaimed as one of the great contributions of Muslim civilization" (Franz Rosenthal), because of Muslims' attachment to their own faith, their early direct contact with other world religions, and their interest in philosophy. Religious debates were held at Baghdad.

early Islam	Tradition holds that **Malik bin Dinar**, a companion of the Prophet, reached South India (the earliest Islam–Hinduism contact). Muslims met Buddhists in **Samarqand** (conquered 711) and Central Asia.
712	Conquest of **Sind and Punjab** brings close Hindu–Muslim relations.
771	A Hindu scientist, probably from Sind, visits the court of Abbasid Caliph **al-Mansur** in Baghdad.
786–803	The **Barmakids** (viziers of Indian, originally Buddhist, origin): **Yahya bin Khalid** sends an envoy to India to collect information on its religions. The report survives in Ibn al-Nadim's ***Kitab al-Fihrist*** ("Madhahib al-Hind").
10th–11th c.	Al-Maqdisi, Iranshahri, Gardizi and al-Marwazi (in Persian), **al-Biruni** (critical, from Sanskrit sources), Qadi Sa'id al-Andalusi (*Tabaqat al-Umam*, Toledo, 1068).
12th c.	**Al-Shahrastani** (1086–1153), *Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal*, chapter "Ara' ahl al-Hind" (Views of the people of India).

What al-Shahrastani wrote SUPPORTING

- Indians are divided into **Brahmins, Naturalists and Dualists**; the majority are **"Sabeans"**. All fall into five groups: **Brahmins, followers of spiritual beings, proponents of heavenly bodies, idol-worshippers, and philosophers**.
- **Brahmins** are named after a man called "Brahma" (an error); they **deny prophecy** (four arguments, which Shahrastani rebuts with his own case from the Qur'an). Sub-sects: followers of the **Buddha**, proponents of **meditation** (experts in astrology; "meditation… kills [a man] instantly"), adherents of **metempsychosis** (transmigration).
- **Spiritual beings** (divine messengers in human form without a written book): sects Basawiya (Vasudeviya), Bahuwadiya (Mahadeviya), Kabaliya (Kapalika), Bahaduniya. **Planet worshippers**: sun and moon worshippers.
- **Idol worshippers**, five sects: **Mahakala** worshippers (the great idol at **Ujjain**), tree worshippers (Vrksa-bhaktas), Dakini followers, water worshippers, fire worshippers (**Agnihotra**).
- **Philosophers**: supposedly followers of "Qalanus", a student of Pythagoras who settled in India (a garbled version of Kalanos, the Indian sage who accompanied Alexander); God is **pure Light**; ends with an Alexander story in which Indian sages are superior.

Khan's evaluation: how reliable is al-Shahrastani? MUST KNOW

STRENGTHS / MERITS

- **Preserves medieval knowledge** that might otherwise be lost.
- **Systematic classification** of Indian religions into clear categories.
- **Comparative religion**: places Indian belief alongside other traditions.
- **Faithful, objective reporting** of what his sources said; he **does not denigrate** Indian religions or attack the Upanishads or Gita.
- Unique information on **Buddhism** not found in other Arabic sources: reward and punishment, the eternity of the world, five virtues (comparable to the **Four Noble Truths**), lists of ten virtues and ten vices (an expanded **Eightfold Path**); "Shakamin" = Sakyamuni; Bodhisattvas.
- Correctly understood why Brahmins "reject prophethood": **avatara** (God himself descends; no book needed) differs from the Semitic **prophet** (a human who brings God's book).

WEAKNESSES / DEMERITS

- **Never visited India**; **no Sanskrit or Pali**; his account is "mainly **literary**", based on **secondary Arabic compilations** (paraphrased from Ibn al-Nadim, al-Maqdisi and especially **Gardizi**, who used **Jayhani**). **He did not use al-Biruni.**
- **Inherited errors**: Brahma as a man's name; **Buddhism treated as a branch of Hinduism** (as medieval Europe called Islam a Christian heresy); no knowledge of Mahayana/Hinayana.
- **Omissions**: nothing on the **Vedas** or **Jainism**; describes sects rather than religions; his material reflects roughly the 8th century.
- **Factual errors**: chronology (Buddha "5,000 years" before the Hijra, actually about 1,182); astronomy (Saturn rather than **Jupiter** as the largest planet); meditation mixed with black magic; the false Pythagoras link.
- **Islamic categories imposed**: he defends prophecy with the Qur'an and criticises idol worship as treating idols as divine, unaware of symbolic worship (**pratikopasana**), which al-Biruni understood.

Khan's fair conclusion: it would be "futile to expect scientific accuracy from an author of the twelfth century". He should be judged by the Arabic information available in the mid-12th century. The chapter mixes fact and fiction, and except for al-Biruni, Arab authors had little or no access to original Indian sources.

Al-Biruni vs al-Shahrastani (lecture table) MUST KNOW

Al-Biruni (973–1048)	Al-Shahrastani (1086–1153)
Visited India	Never visited
Learned Sanskrit	Did not know Sanskrit
Used original texts (Mahabharata, Gita, Samkhya, Patanjali; translated the Yoga Sutras into Arabic)	Used Arabic compilations
Critical scholarship	Compilation
Primary evidence	**Secondary evidence**

"Which source would historians trust more? Why?" Al-Biruni, because he has direct observation, language competence, original texts and a critical method. But al-Shahrastani is still valuable as evidence of **how knowledge about India circulated in the Islamic world through literary traditions**. A source can be poor for "what India was like" yet excellent for "what 12th-century Muslims believed about India", which is Backerra's point that the question decides the value of a source.

6.4 Comparing the two traditions MUST KNOW

	Chinese pilgrims	Arab scholars (al-Shahrastani)
Motive	Pilgrimage	Intellectual inquiry
Framework	Buddhism	Comparative religion (Islamic categories)
Evidence	First-hand observation	Often literary sources
Focus	Monasteries, relics, Vinaya	Religious classifications
Genre	Travel narrative	Encyclopaedic writing

READING FOREIGN ACCOUNTS CRITICALLY

Ask: **Who is speaking? Why did they travel? What did they observe (vs hear)? What could they not understand? What evidence supports their claims? Can archaeology confirm them?** The key concept is **corroboration**: check one account against others before trusting it, especially against **inscriptions** (official, dated, less shaped by outside bias), **archaeology** (independent physical evidence), **indigenous literature** (the Indian perspective missing from outsiders), and **coins** (independent evidence of rulers and trade).

LARGER HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE (LECTURE)

Foreign travellers show that **India was deeply connected with Asia**, not an isolated civilisation; that **knowledge travelled alongside merchants**; that **Buddhism linked India and China**; that **Islamic scholarship connected India with West Asia**; and that **ideas moved across political boundaries**. Travel writing reveals **the history of connections, not isolation**.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 6

Where Indian records are scarce, foreign accounts fill gaps, but travel writing combines observation, memory, interpretation and opinion, so it is **evidence and interpretation at once**. The three Chinese pilgrims (**Faxian**, Vinaya, 399–413, returning by sea; **Xuanzang**, 657 texts, Harsha and Kanauj, diplomacy, Nalanda; **Yijing**, by sea via Srivijaya, 40 monastic practices, 56 monks) give first-hand, Buddhist-coloured evidence, show monk–merchant symbiosis and the "borderland complex", and raised India's image in China. **Al-Shahrastani** (12th c.) classified Indian religions systematically but from secondary Arabic sources, without Sanskrit, with errors and Islamic categories; **al-Biruni** is the critical, primary counterpoint. Historians must **corroborate** with inscriptions, archaeology, coins and Indian texts. Together these sources reveal **connections, not isolation**.

EXAM CORNER

1. "Travel writing is both evidence and interpretation." Discuss with reference to the Chinese pilgrims.
2. Compare Xuanzang and al-Shahrastani as sources for Indian history. Which would you trust more and why?
3. How did the Chinese pilgrims contribute to cross-cultural exchange between India and China? (Texts, relics, perception of India, diplomacy, monk–merchant networks.)
4. What are the strengths and limitations of foreign travel accounts, and how should historians use them?

MCQ facts: Faxian left Chang'an 399 for Vinaya texts; Xuanzang left 627, met Harsha at Kanauj, 657 texts, "Yindu", Great Wild Goose Pagoda; Yijing 671–695, wrote from Srivijaya, 56 monks; al-Shahrastani's book = *Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal*; he never visited India; Ibn al-Nadim's *Fihrist* preserves the Barmakid envoy's report; the Mahakala idol was at Ujjain.

SESSION 7

Commercial and Cultural Exchanges in the Medieval Indian Ocean World: Baghdad to Canton

Reading: William Bernstein, *A Splendid Exchange: How Trade Shaped the World* (2008), ch. 4, "The Baghdad–Canton Express: Asia on Five Dirhem a Day", pp. 77–109 (R5). Key sources discussed: Marco Polo · *Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind* · *The Book of the Marvels of India* · Ibn Battuta · Tomé Pires.

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 6 showed travellers revealing connections. Session 7 shows the **system** behind those connections: the Indian Ocean as **"one of the clearest examples of premodern globalization"**, with **India at the centre**. This is the first big application of Session 3's argument: **Europe entered an already connected world; it did not create global interconnection**. Expect questions on **why India was central**, **Islam as a framework of exchange**, **trade diasporas**, **monsoons**, and **Malacca/Gujarat**.

7.1 The big argument MUST KNOW

CORE ARGUMENT (LECTURE, BASED ON BERNSTEIN)

- The Indian Ocean was a major arena of **premodern globalisation**: a dense system of interregional exchange linking many societies over long distances. **This is not modern capitalism**, but a dense, interregional system.
- Trade moved **goods, people, beliefs and institutions**: merchants, sailors, pilgrims, diplomats, technologies and stories travelled together.
- Exchange depended on **ports, monsoons, merchant networks and law**.
- **India occupied a strategic middle position**: geographically central, commercially productive and culturally influential, both a **destination** and a **relay zone** between western and eastern Asia.
- It was a **patterned, durable system**, not occasional or accidental, linking **East Africa, the Middle East, India, Southeast Asia and China** (from the Red Sea to the South China coast), supporting **high-value and bulk trade** (spices and silk are remembered, but textiles, grain, horses, metals and timber mattered as much), and functioning **before European naval control**. This challenges Eurocentric narratives.

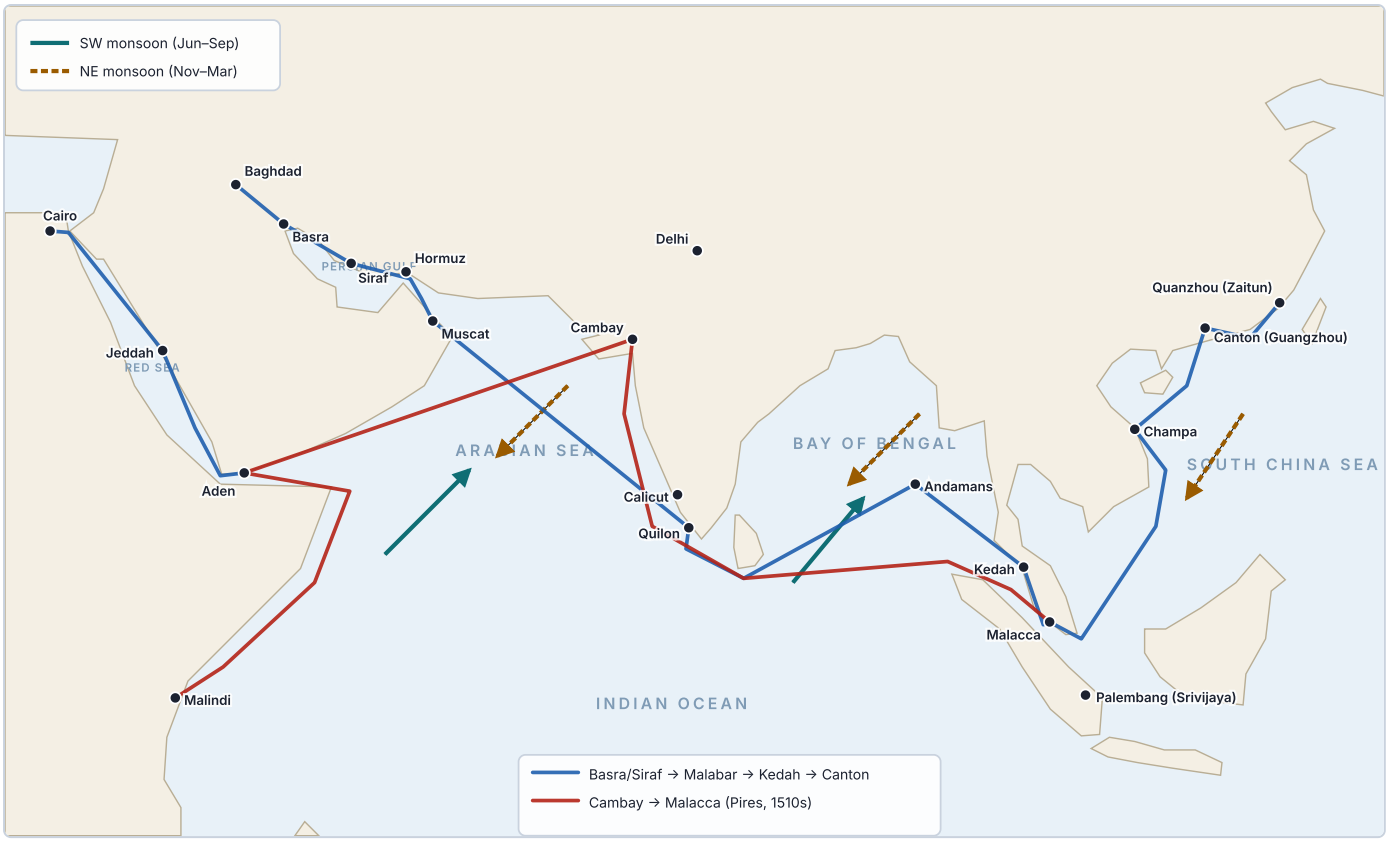
What moved across the system

- **Goods**: silk, spices, porcelain, cotton textiles, horses, ivory, incense, gold; each region supplied what others lacked.
- **People**: merchants, sailors, pilgrims, judges, envoys, carrying information and expertise.
- **Ideas**: religion, law, stories, customs, technologies, especially **Islam**.
- **Institutions**: taxation, port regulation, contracts and credit, which made **trust at a distance** possible.

Key idea: trade rested on both **material and cultural foundations**; goods alone cannot explain how the system worked.

Monsoons and maritime rhythm

- **Seasonal winds structured routes**: ships could cross safely only at specific times.
- **Sailing calendars** set when merchants left and returned.
- **Most merchants travelled in segments, not whole routes**. Bernstein's example: a **Gujarati** merchant sails the **summer (SW) monsoon** to Malacca with cotton cloth and indigo, swaps for silk, spices and porcelain, and returns on the **winter (NE) monsoon**; or goes west to **Aden** (horses, incense) or **Malindi** (gold, slaves). Goods on the whole Baghdad–Canton route travelled in **at least three different ships**.
- **Nature actively shaped exchange**: the Indian Ocean world was **ecological as much as commercial**.



The Baghdad–Canton sea route (Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind, 9th c.) and the later Cambay–Malacca axis (Pires). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Danger, distance and uncertainty SUPPORTING

- Before the Chinese invented the **magnetic compass** (c. 12th century), sailors used the **stars**; fog and overcast skies were as deadly as storms. Latitude could be measured, but **longitude only from the 18th century**.
- Shipwreck, piracy, storms and delay were constant; a voyage that looked short could take **over a year**.
- **Long-distance trade was profitable precisely because it was risky**: scarcity and danger raised the value of whatever survived.
- Travel narratives reflect both **fear and fascination**. **Exaggeration is not just a flaw; it is evidence of how travellers experienced distance and difference** (a source-criticism point, linked to S2 and S6).

> *"The Great Ocean spreads out over a boundless expanse. There is no knowing east from west; only by observing the sun, moon, and stars was it possible to go forward… The merchants were full of terror, not knowing where they were going."*
> Faxian (5th c.), quoted by Bernstein

7.2 Reading the sources: every account is a socially located point of view

MUST KNOW

Source	Who / when	Value and bias
Marco Polo, *Travels*	Venetian merchant, dictated c.1292 in a Genoese prison to **Rustichello of Pisa**; family in Constantinople; father and uncle (Niccolò, Maffeo) reached Kublai Khan c.1265	A famous European perspective; remarkably accurate (even on places told to him second-hand: Burma, Java, the Spice Islands), but **poor in technical economic detail** (no pepper prices or monsoon patterns), perhaps because Rustichello knew readers wanted marvels (sati, assassins, burning oil).

Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind ("An Account of China and India")	Mid-9th c. (c.851), Arab merchants, especially one **Sulayman**; continued by the geographer **Abu Zayd** (916). Lecture: "written over two different centuries by a merchant and geographer"	An early **Islamic** account of the **Baghdad–India–China** route; starts the "China travelogue" tradition.
The Book of the Marvels of India (*Kitab 'Aja'ib al-Hind*)	10th c., attributed to **Buzurg ibn Shahriyar of Ramhormuz**, a Persian ship captain and merchant; 123 stories	**Mixes maritime reality with fantasy** (man-eating giants, islands of women) but reveals shipwreck risk, slavery and Islam's commercial bonds.
Ibn Battuta	14th c. Moroccan **qadi** (Muslim judge), 1325–1354	A **Muslim legal and courtly view**; little interest in trade details or non-Muslims.
Tomé Pires, *Suma Oriental*	Portuguese apothecary, in India and Malacca from 1511	A **16th-century observer at the moment of Portuguese arrival**: precise, numerate, admiring of Asian trade.
Others in Bernstein	**Chau Ju-Kua** (Zhao Rugua), inspector of maritime trade at Zaitun, *Chu-fan-chi* (early 13th c.), a "reverse Marco Polo"; **Benjamin of Tudela** (12th-c. Spanish rabbi: Baghdad as "the place of meeting of philosophers"); **al-Idrisi** for Roger II of Sicily (Aden's trade); **Sinbad** in the *Thousand and One Nights*; **Ma Huan** (Zheng He's Muslim interpreter)	Each shows what its author cared about.

Lecture point: these limitations reveal what different actors cared about: **profit, piety, danger, power, curiosity or prestige**.

7.3 The story in phases (Bernstein's narrative) SUPPORTING

Phase 1: Tang China and the early caliphate, direct trade (7th–9th c.)

- As the Pax Romana and Han enabled indirect Rome–China trade, the **early Islamic and Tang empires** stimulated **more direct** exchange. Chinese sources say Islam reached **Canton c.620**, before the Prophet's death.
- The Chinese distinguished **"Po-ssi" (Persians)**, the more numerous seafarers, from **"Ta-shih" (Arabs)**, and from **"Fu-lin" (Byzantium)**. By **758** Muslims in Canton were numerous enough to sack the city. After the Arabs defeated the Sasanians at **Ctesiphon (636)**, Arab and Persian ships sailed directly to China.
- **Trade diasporas**: Po-ssi communities along the Chinese coast, followed by Jews; **Nestorian Christians** (tolerated by Islam as "people of the book") came overland.
- **750: the Abbasids** moved the centre of Islam from landlocked Damascus to riverine **Baghdad**: "This is the Tigris; there is **no obstacle between us and China**."
- **The *Akhbar* route:** load at **Basra and Siraf** → one month from Oman to the **Malabar coast** (tax of 10–30 dinars per ship) → a month across the Bay of Bengal, provisioning at the **Andamans** → **Kedah** (Malaysia) → through the Strait of Malacca or a **portage** across the peninsula → Indochina (20 days) → **Canton** (a month). About four months' sailing in theory, **over a year** in practice.
- **Exchange at Canton:** China wanted **copper, ivory, incense, turtle shells**; Muslims bought **gold, pearls, silk and brocade**. A **government monopoly** held goods for six months, took a **30% import duty**, and bought what it wanted at the highest price. The *Akhbar* admired China's literacy, poll tax and **old-age pensions**, disliked pork and toilet paper, and described **tea** ("al-sakh"), the West's first encounter with it.
- ***Marvels of India***: a captain who made **seven China voyages** safely was astonishing; the Jewish merchant **Ishaq**'s ship carried a million dinars of musk. In the longest story, traders shipwrecked in East Africa are treated kindly by a king, then **enslave him** and sell him in Oman. Years later he has escaped, converted to Islam in Baghdad and converted his kingdom, and he receives the same merchant kindly: **"Musulmans shall know that they may come to us like brothers, since we are Musulmans too."** This shows the slave trade **and** Islam's power to bind a commercial system.

- **Collapse:** as the Tang declined, foreign traders became scapegoats; in **878 Huang Chao** sacked Canton and killed about **120,000 Muslims, Jews and Christians**, and even destroyed mulberry groves. Trade shifted north to **Quanzhou (Zaitun)**. China appointed **inspectors of maritime trade** (Chau Ju-Kua: "none surpasses the realm of the Arabs").
- **"Sinbad's Way"** (Mediterranean → Syrian desert → Tigris/Euphrates → Persian Gulf → Indian Ocean) was the **preferred route** over the Red Sea (pirates, shoals, adverse winds) and the overland Silk Road (inefficiency, danger, politics). Sinbad was really the **scion of a Baghdad trading family**, not a sailor; few crew earned salaries, and most traded on their own account. China's silk, sandalwood, spices and porcelain went west for horses, ivory, incense, cottons, gold and copper; **rice served as ballast**.

Phase 2: the Mongol window and Ibn Battuta (13th–14th c.)

- **Hulagu sacked Baghdad in 1258**; the Mamluks stopped the Mongols at **Ain Jalut (1260)**. For about a century (c.1260–1360) a chain of Mongol states kept the **Silk Road open**, which the Polos and Ibn Battuta exploited.
- **Ibn Battuta** (b. Tangier 1304), a **qadi** who made the hajj in **1325** and travelled about **74,000 miles** over three decades, selling his expertise in *sharia*.
- **Delhi under Muhammad bin Tughluq (1325–51)**: famous for hare-brained schemes (moving the capital to the Deccan, agricultural regimentation, an army against the Mongols); his passion was Islamic law, so he recruited foreign scholars with lavish rewards. **Credit and patronage**: newcomers had to give expensive gifts to win favour, financed by loans from merchants of China and India, repaid from the sultan's larger counter-gift. Battuta became **qadi of Delhi** but ran up a **55,000-dinar debt**; association with a dissident Sufi brought nine days under guard. He was then made **ambassador to China**.
- Sailed from **Cambay** to **Calicut** (pepper country, huge Chinese junks); his ships were wrecked or lost. In **Samudera** (Sumatra, 1345), the first Islamic-ruled place in Southeast Asia, he witnessed the beginning of the conversion that made **Indonesia** the largest Muslim nation. In China he disliked "paganism" and **paper money** but admired Zaitun's six boroughs (one for Muslims) and the safety of travel.
- **Polo vs Battuta**: Polo was Christian, **curious** and dependent on the Mongol khans; Battuta was Muslim, **uncurious** about non-Muslims, and successful in Delhi. Battuta's lack of interest shows **Muslim dominance of Asian trade**: he could travel 74,000 miles **entirely within Dar al-Islam**.
- **A shared commercial code:** a Muslim importer in Cairo or Tangier and his supplier in Cambay or Malacca obeyed the same religious, ethical and commercial rules. Customs rates were typically **2.5% for Muslims, 5% for protected *dhimmi* (Christians, Jews), 10% for others** (Hindus, animists). The **hajj** united the trading world, and pilgrims paid their way with spices and textiles, making **Jeddah** a great market. The Indian Ocean was **"no Muslim lake"** (Calicut had a Hindu **zamorin**), yet 14th-century Indian Ocean trade was "essentially one and the same with Dar-al-Islam".

Phase 3: Chinese ships and Zheng He's treasure fleets (1405–1433)

- **Song China** created a permanent navy (1132) and built huge ships with iron nails, watertight compartments, stern rudders and the compass. Indian Ocean **dhows** were sewn with coconut fibre (Marco Polo preferred the Silk Road to sailing on one from Hormuz). Why dhows persisted: **tradition**, **little iron** on India's west coast, and being more **"beachworthy"** (flexible on reefs and shallows).
- **Zheng He** (born Ma, a Muslim boy captured in 1382 and made a eunuch) commanded **seven voyages, 1405–1433**, of about 300 ships and 30,000 men to Malacca, Sumatra, Java, India, Hormuz, the Red Sea and East Africa, following the monsoon. Their purposes were **diplomatic, military and symbolic**, not opening markets. He **stabilised the Strait of Malacca** (killing 5,000 pirates, making Malacca a "country" protected from Siam). His interpreter **Ma Huan** recorded the voyages. A prized cargo was **giraffes**, taken for the mythical *qilin*.
- **The end:** after Zhu Di's death (1424), the **Confucian bureaucracy defeated the eunuchs**; voyages stopped after 1433. By 1500, building ships with more than two masts was a capital offence; in 1525 oceangoing ships were banned, so Japanese *wako* pirates flourished. Bernstein: Confucian contempt for merchants and centralised politics could **switch off** contact, whereas the **decentralised** Indian Ocean world produced "Darwinian" competition among trading states.

- Modern China uses Zheng He to illustrate its **"peaceful"** foreign policy, but the voyages kidnapped and killed those who refused homage, an example of the **political use of the past** (S1). Gavin Menzies' claim (*1421*) that Zheng He reached America is not taken seriously. Da Gama missed the fleets by about 65 years.

Phase 4: Tomé Pires and Malacca on the eve of the Portuguese MUST KNOW

- **Tomé Pires**, an apothecary, left Lisbon in 1511, worked in India, was sent to Malacca, then became the first European ambassador to China (died in captivity). His *Suma Oriental* was rediscovered in the 1930s in the "Paris Codex". It gives "a last look at the indigenous world of Asian commerce".
- **Main axis: Cambay (Gujarat) ↔ Malacca.** Cambay "with her right arm reaches out towards Aden, and with the other towards Malacca". Cambay's long-distance trade was dominated by **Hindu trading castes**. Pires praised the Gujaratis: "these people have the cream of the trade… They are men who understand merchandise… **Those of our people who want to be clerks and factors ought to go there and learn**." That a chauvinistic Portuguese said this "spoke volumes" about Asian sophistication.
- **Malacca** was founded c.1400 by **Parameswara**, a prince of Palembang from the line of **Srivijaya**, who fled the Javanese Majapahit (*malaqa* = "hidden fugitive"). It was medieval Asia's Singapore. Pires counted **84 languages** (Cairo, Aden, Gujaratis, Malabars, Klings, Bengal, Pegu, Siam, Chinese, Moluccas…). **Four harbourmasters** handled different regions. Cloth (30 types) came from India; spices, sandalwood, tin, silk and porcelain went west.
- **Why Malacca succeeded (institutions, not just location): low duties** (at most 6% for westerners, 3% if settled with a wife, none for "easterners", plus 1–2% "presents", **no export duty**); an honest legal structure (the **bendara** as mayor and chief justice; the **tumungam** as customs judge); a **transparent auction** with well-known rules, a "medieval eBay". **"The law and the prices of merchandise in Malacca are well known."**
- **Islam and trade:** Parameswara converted to Islam to marry the daughter of the king of **Pase** (protection against Majapahit); by 1400 most merchants in the strait were Muslim. Bernstein: Islam's backbone is **law covering commerce**, so embracing it "did wonders for one's credit rating". **Southeast Asia was converted not by conquerors but by cloth and spice merchants from Cambay and Calicut who married local women**; their children were raised Muslim. Malacca fell to the Portuguese in 1511 under the "dissolute" Mahmud Shah.

7.4 Why India becomes central (lecture, Part Two) MUST KNOW

Geography alone is not enough to explain India's role. India was geographically between the Gulf and China, **economically vital as producer and intermediary**, home to major ports and merchant communities, and a **key transmitter** of religion and commercial culture.

1 · Intermediary

Bridged the western and eastern circuits; ships from the Gulf or Red Sea reached India before going east; sub-networks converged at Indian ports; cargo was sorted, taxed, repackaged and redirected. India was **market and transit zone**. **Centrality can come from connecting regions, not just producing goods.**

2 · Gujarat & Cambay

One of the most sophisticated commercial regions; Cambay a hub to the Gulf, Red Sea, East Africa and Southeast Asia; Gujarati merchants admired even by Pires; cloth, indigo and western Indian trade fuelled larger circuits. **A local commercial culture competing on a global stage.**

3 · Textiles

"If spices were glamorous, **cloth was indispensable**." Cotton was among India's most important exports; it linked producers to Asian consumers (not just elites) and was exchanged for spices, silk and porcelain. India was central **structurally, not just symbolically**.

4 · Malabar & pepper

Malabar was a crucial spice zone; **Calicut** was built around pepper; **Chinese demand** was huge (Polo: pepper at Zaitun was 100 times what went to Alexandria). Asian markets were powerful in their own right: **decentring Europe**.

5 · Ibn Battuta's India

The Delhi Sultanate drew scholars and officials from across Islam: India as a hub for **talent and ambition**; Tughluq's volatility; **credit, patronage and office** intertwined; India integrated into a wider **Muslim ecumene**. Exchange took many forms: Battuta came as a **jurist**, not a merchant.

6 · From Delhi to the coast

Inland power and maritime trade were **connected but distinct**; Cambay and Calicut linked hinterland and ocean; coastal prosperity rested on **security, predictable taxation and port efficiency**; **both Muslim and Hindu rulers** sustained trade. Look at **institutions and incentives, not fixed civilisational labels**.

INDIA AS A CULTURAL CONDUIT

Muslim traders from India **carried Islam eastward**; **commercial networks preceded political conversion**; **intermarriage** created lasting communities; change moved through **everyday commerce, not conquest**. "Religious and cultural change often happens through **households and trade**, not just armies."

MALACCA: IMPORTANT LARGELY *BECAUSE* OF INDIA

Malacca linked India to China and the Spice Islands; Indians (especially **Gujarati and Malabari** traders) were among its most important merchants; cloth moved east, spices, silk and porcelain west; low duties and good governance encouraged return. This is "one of the clearest demonstrations of **India's centrality to the entire system**".

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR GLOBAL HISTORY (CONCLUSION)

- **Premodern globalisation was real and complex**, long before European dominance.
- **Europe entered an already connected world**: a later participant, not the creator.
- **India was central** geographically, economically, institutionally and culturally all at once.
- Oceanic exchange shaped later imperial systems, which **built upon, disrupted and partly appropriated** existing structures.
- The Indian Ocean was a major arena of **"peaceful" global exchange** (note the quotation marks: violence, slavery and piracy existed). Its operation depended on winds, ports, merchants, institutions and shared norms. **Commercial exchange was also cultural exchange**: "to study the history of trade is to study the making of connected worlds."

SUMMARY OF SESSION 7

The medieval Indian Ocean was a durable, patterned system of premodern globalisation from East Africa to China, organised by **monsoons** (segmented voyages), **ports**, **trade diasporas** (Persian, Arab, Jewish, Indian, Chinese), and **institutions** (taxes, contracts, credit). **Islam** worked as commercial infrastructure (shared law, hajj, customs rates), easing trade for everyone. The sources (*Akhbar*, *Marvels*, Polo, Battuta, Pires) each reflect their authors' concerns. The story runs from Tang–Abbasid direct trade (Canton, 878 massacre), through the Mongol window (Battuta in Tughluq's Delhi), Zheng He's voyages (1405–33) and their end, to **Malacca's** institutional success and fall (1511). **India was central** as intermediary, producer (textiles, pepper), market and cultural conduit, with Gujarat/Cambay and Malabar/Calicut as hubs. **Europe entered an already connected world.**

EXAM CORNER

1. "The Indian Ocean was one of the clearest examples of premodern globalization." Discuss.
2. Why did India become central to the Indian Ocean trading system before 1500? (Geography is not enough: intermediary, textiles, pepper, Gujarat, institutions, conduit.)
3. How did Islam function as a framework of exchange in the Indian Ocean? (Shared law, hajj, customs rates, credit; Malacca and Parameswara; conversion by merchants; "not only Muslims traded".)
4. What made Malacca a successful port, according to Tomé Pires and Bernstein?
5. Assess the value and limits of travel and merchant accounts (Polo, *Akhbar*, *Marvels*, Battuta, Pires) as sources for Indian Ocean trade.

MCQ facts: *Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind* c.851 (Sulayman); *Marvels of India* by Buzurg ibn Shahriyar of Ramhormuz (10th c.); Huang Chao 878 Canton massacre; Abbasids 750; Hulagu 1258; Ibn Battuta = qadi from Tangier; Tughluq 1325–51; Zheng He 1405–1433 (7 voyages); Pires's *Suma Oriental*, 84 languages at Malacca; Malacca founded c.1400 by Parameswara; Calicut ruled by the Hindu zamorin; customs 2.5/5/10%.

SESSION 8

India and the Silk Route Connections I: Overland Networks of Travel and Exchange ("Silk Roads and Connectivities: Comparing Two Lenses")

Readings: Valerie Hansen, *The Silk Road: A New History* (OUP, 2012), ch. 5, "The Cosmopolitan Terminus of the Silk Road: Historic Chang'an, Modern-day Xi'an" (R6) · Jayati Bhattacharya, "Old Routes, New Dreams: Reminiscences of the Southern Silk Road and Bengal–China Connectivities", *JESHO* 64 (2021), pp. 302–341 (OT5). Note: the article says "you may leave out the highlighted portion".

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 7 was about the sea; Session 8 turns to the **"Silk Road"**, and asks what that term really means. The lecture's central claim: **"There is no single Silk Road narrative; there are multiple histories of connectivity."** Two readings are compared as **two lenses**: **Hansen** sees the Silk Road through a **city** (Chang'an); **Bhattacharya** sees it through a **region** (Bengal and the northern Bay of Bengal). This is Session 3's lesson on **scale** in action, plus Session 1's lesson on the **political use of the past** (BRI, Act East).

8.1 What is the Silk Road? MUST KNOW

- **The popular view:** a single overland route linking China to the West, mainly for silk and luxury goods.
- **The Britannica definition (lecture):** starting at **Xi'an**, a 4,000-mile (6,400 km) caravan track followed the Great Wall north-west, bypassed the **Taklamakan** desert, climbed the **Pamirs**, crossed Afghanistan to the Levant, and then crossed the Mediterranean by ship. **Few persons travelled the entire route; goods were handled in a staggered progression by middlemen.**
- The term **"Silk Road"** (*Seidenstrasse*) was coined by the German geographer **Ferdinand von Richthofen in 1877**, who drew it as a single line on a map while looking for a railway route from Germany to China (Hansen, plate 2).
- **What the readings show: multiple routes, not one road**, carrying people, religions, ideas, commodities, states and ecologies. **The lens a historian chooses shapes which Silk Road becomes visible.**

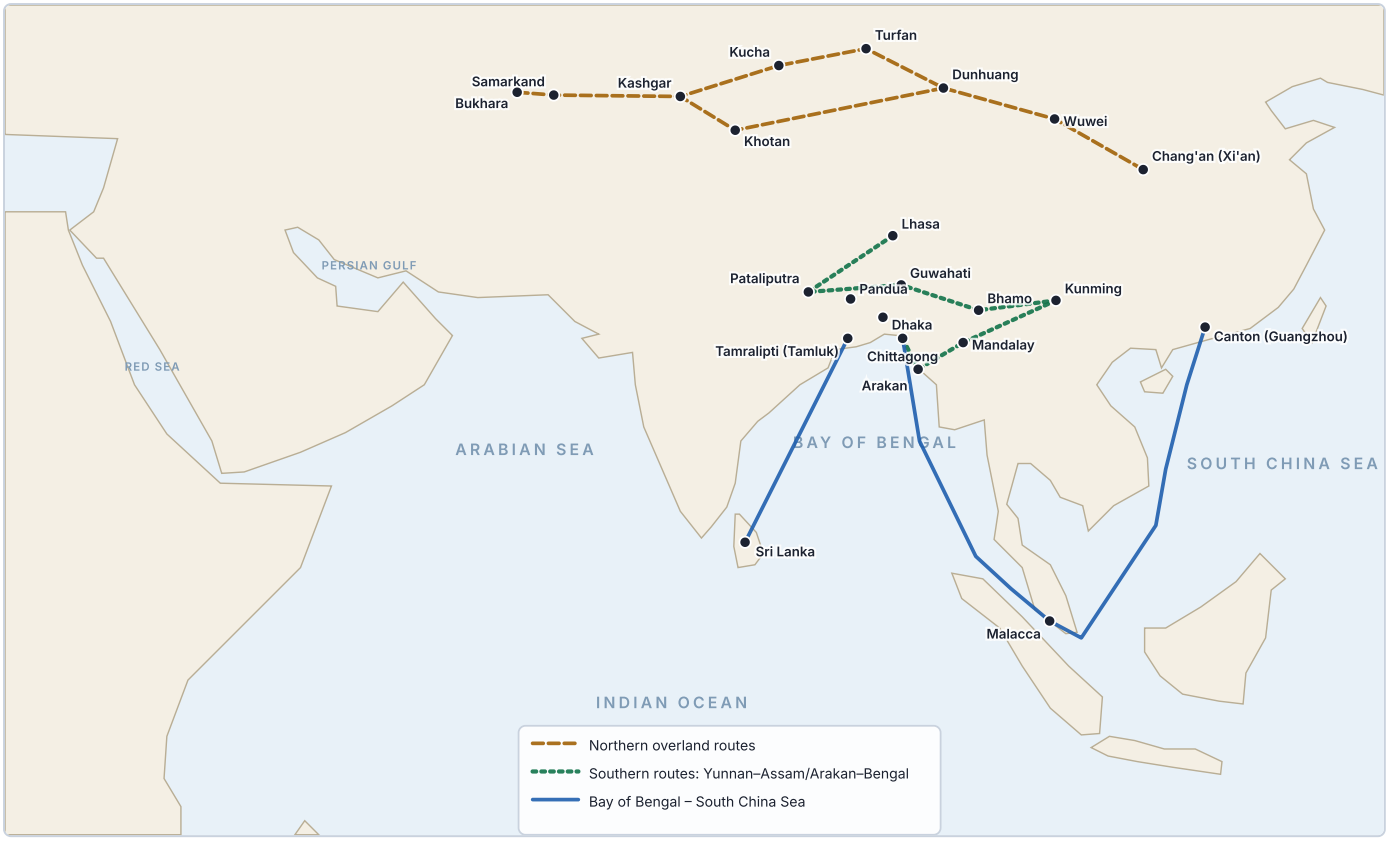
Dynamics of the Silk Road (lecture)

- **Goods moved not only through trade but through gifts and dowries**: Han rulers kept peace by regularly giving silk and lacquerware to the **Xiongnu** beyond the Great Wall.
- **Cosmopolitan centres** (Chang'an, Samarkand, Dunhuang).
- **Transmission of religions**: Christianity, Buddhism, Manichaeism, Zoroastrianism.
- **Cultural expressions**: Dunhuang and Bezeklik caves; a Khotan king's portrait at Mogao; Sogdian frescoes at Samarkand; Buddhist art from Tokharistan.

People on the move MUST KNOW

Group	Role (lecture)
Sogdians	Iranians from **Samarkand** and the Zerafshan valley (modern Uzbekistan and Tajikistan); long-distance caravan trade; merchant diasporas far from home; became part of the **administrative machinery** (e.g. the *sabao* headmen)
Muslim merchants	After the Sogdians declined in the 8th century; resided in Chang'an and south-east Chinese ports
Eastern Christians (Nestorians)	From the Middle East to India and beyond

Jewish community	Repository of Hebrew documents in Cairo (the Geniza); a Hebrew prayer was found in the Dunhuang library cave
Italian merchants	Sent emissaries to the Mongol **Yuan** dynasty
From the 17th c.	Dominated by **Indian and Armenian** merchants (horses, spices)
Religious missionaries	Indian monks **Kasyapa Matanga** and **Dharmaraksa/Dharmaratna** went to China at the invitation of Han Emperor Ming (57–75 CE). **Faxian** (350–414): Chang'an → Khotan → India, back from Tamluk via Sri Lanka and Sumatra, landing in Shandong. **Yijing** (635–713): Chang'an → Yangzhou → Guangzhou → Palembang → Tamluk and back; wrote about **56 monks** (21 overland, 30 by sea). **Xuanzang**: along the Tarim Basin to Uzbekistan and Afghanistan; stopped at Dunhuang on his return.



Two lenses: Chang'an as terminus (Hansen) and Bengal as circulatory centre (Bhattacharya). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

8.2 Why compare these two readings? MUST KNOW

	Valerie Hansen	Jayati Bhattacharya
Unit / scale	**City-centred**: Chang'an / Xi'an	**Region-centred**: Bengal, Bay of Bengal, Yunnan, the Himalayan zone
Method	**Archaeology**, tombs, objects, **urban history**, migration	**Spatial and commodity history**, ecology, geopolitics, the *longue durée*
Best short formulation	From **"luxury trade"** to **urban cosmopolitanism and lived intercultural contact**	From **"frontier and periphery"** to **circulatory centrality**
On trade	**Sceptical of trade volume**: overland trade favoured small, high-value goods; people and ideas mattered more	**Uses commodities** (cotton textiles, cowries, horses, silver) to map regional systems

Change over time	Rise under the **Sui and Tang**, then rebellion, violence and religious persecution; a shift from overland to **maritime** routes	Ancient and medieval circulation → **colonial rerouting** and boundary-making → **postcolonial rupture** → selective 21st-century **revival**

SHARED ARGUMENT ACROSS BOTH READINGS

Both **reject the narrow "silk-for-the-West" story** (no simple linear east–west route); both **reject centres-only history** (imperial capitals are not the only places that matter); both emphasise **movement of people** (migration mattered as much as, or more than, cargo); both emphasise **cultural and political meaning** (religious exchange, cultural translation, political mediation). **"Connectivity is not just movement; it is also how spaces become meaningful through movement."**

8.3 Hansen: Chang'an as cosmopolitan terminus MUST KNOW

HANSEN'S ARGUMENT

Chang'an was **not merely a Chinese capital** but a genuinely **international hub**, home to monks, merchants, craftsmen, officials, refugees, military dependents and religious communities. **Overland trade brought few bulk goods**; long-distance cargo volumes were smaller than popular memory suggests. **What travelled most significantly was not cargo but lives and ideas.** Her evidence is above all **archaeological**: tombs, hoards and paper reused in burials.

The city

- Modern Xi'an (over 10 million people) was capital of ten dynasties, three of them major unifying ones: **Former Han (206 BCE–9 CE), Sui (589–617), Tang (618–907)**. It was the starting point for travellers west (Xuanzang sought advice in the **Western Market** from Sogdians) and also for sea travellers, who went overland to the coast.
- The Sui founder built a new planned city (582). Tang Chang'an: walls about **9.5 × 8.4 km** (about 80 sq km); a main avenue **155 m wide**; **109 walled quarters (*fang*)** with a night curfew; the palace and government to the north; officials in the less-crowded east, ordinary people in the west.
- **Two markets:** the **Eastern Market** (domestic goods: 220 groups of shops, brushes, iron, cloth, meat, wine, printing) and the **Western Market** (foreign goods by camel: leather, jewellery, precious stones), with restaurants, inns, warehouses and bank-like institutions. Officials above the fifth rank were barred because the **Tang Code** viewed commerce as polluting; market officials checked weights and set prices every ten days.
- **Law for foreigners:** if foreigners of the **same** country wronged each other, their home law applied; if of **different** countries, Chinese law applied.
- **Population** about **960,000** (300,000 households), mostly Chinese, with a sizable foreign community around the Western Market. Foreigners came through treaties (after the Eastern Turks surrendered in **631**, about 10,000 households, many Sogdian, were moved to Chang'an), as **hostage princes**, and as refugees (the **Sasanian royal heirs Peroz and Narseh** after the Muslim conquest of Iran in 651).
- **Religions:** 5–6 **Zoroastrian** temples (four around the Western Market); one **Church of the East** church. The **"Nestorian stele" (781)** in the Forest of Steles museum records **Aluohan** arriving in **635** with 70 Syriac names (it was found in 1625 and delighted the Jesuits). Today only the **Big and Small Goose Pagodas** survive from Tang Chang'an (the Big Goose Pagoda housed Xuanzang's texts).

Lens 3: archaeology and material culture (Hansen's evidence) MUST KNOW

Sogdian tombs: burial hybridity

- **An Jia** (d. 579; found 2001; the only undisturbed Sogdian tomb; "top ten discovery"): from a **Bukhara** family settled at Liangzhou (Wuwei); a ***sabao*** (a Chinese-appointed **headman of the foreign community**). The tomb is **Chinese in form** (sloping walkway, underground chamber, Chinese epitaph) with **Sogdian elements**: a **stone funeral bed** instead of a coffin, a **Zoroastrian fire altar**, the "Sogdian swirl" dance. Puzzle: his bones lay **outside** the door. The panels show little commerce and more **diplomacy** (meeting a Turkish leader; camels with gifts).
- **Shi Wirkak** (d. 579; "wolf"; also a *sabao* at Wuwei): a **stone house** (sarcophagus) with a **bilingual Sogdian–Chinese epitaph** (not translations of each other) and the soul crossing the **Chinwad Bridge** to paradise, a more detailed Zoroastrian scene than any from Iran.
- 2005: the first **Indian** ("Brahman") tomb in Xi'an, of **Li Cheng**.
- Normal Sogdian practice was **exposure, then ossuary**; in China they adapted, so the stone bed is like an ossuary "turned inside out". **Immigrants adjusted to and modified Chinese practices.**

Pawn tickets and the Hejiacun hoard

- **Pawnshop tickets** (dated 662–689) from Chang'an, reused to make a figurine buried at **Astana (Turfan)**: 54 transactions, mostly **clothing or cloth** pawned for about 100 coins at **5% a month** (within Tang law). Another set of 608 transactions shows **a quarter made by women**, so women did leave home despite Confucian ideals. This is **everyday economic life**, not grand trade.
- **Hejiacun (Hejia Village) hoard**, found 1970: over 1,000 items in three pots (gold and silver vessels, gems, medicines, 478 coins). Tax-silver "biscuits" dated **722 and 731** suggest a **government storehouse**; perhaps buried in a crisis (the An Lushan rebellion of 755?).
- **What it reveals:** only **a few imported items** (sapphires, rubies, topaz, Indian agates, a glass bowl, a Sasanian coin, Japanese coins, an imitation Byzantine coin) against many **locally made, hybrid Iranian–Chinese vessels** made by **migrant Sogdian metalsmiths** in Chang'an. This fits the overall pattern: **relatively few goods travelled long distances overland, mainly small, light, precious ones; people and skills moved.**

OTHER EVIDENCE CORRECTING TEXTBOOK MYTHS (HANSEN'S PLATES)

Fewer than **50 Roman gold coins** have been found in all of China, many of them imitations used as **talismans**, not money, and the earliest date only to the 500s CE (so no Han–Rome coin trade). By contrast, **over 1,000 Sasanian silver coins** circulated in north-west China. **Silk often functioned as currency** (e.g. paying soldiers at Loulan), not as a luxury good. **"Objects and tombs correct the popular myth of endless caravans loaded with luxury goods."**

Disruption and decline: Hansen's "change over time"

- **An Lushan (An Rokhshan) rebellion, 755–763**, led by a Turco-Sogdian general. The emperor fled; Uighur troops helped suppress it and then sacked Chang'an. Afterwards the Tang blamed Sogdians: the character "An" was removed from street names, and in one account people with "big noses like the Sogdians" were massacred. This was a **new and ugly chapter**, the first time a ruler targeted a **minority group** within China. Many foreigners nevertheless stayed.
- **Tibetans** pillaged Chang'an in 763. In **787** minister **Li Mi** cut subsidies for **4,000 foreign envoys**, mostly Sogdians who had lived there 40+ years, married, and bought land.
- **Stereotype vs reality:** 9th-century "wonder tales" and model legal cases portray Sogdians as fabulously rich jewel merchants, but **merchants were only a minority** of Sogdians in China (also envoys, soldiers, refugees, farmers, metalsmiths). **A stereotype is not proof of a prosperous trade.**
- **843:** Manichaeism banned; **845:** Buddhism, Zoroastrianism and Christianity banned (to melt statues for coin). Buddhism's ban was lifted in 847; the others never recovered.
- **Shift to the sea:** after Chinese troops withdrew from the Taklamakan oases in the 750s, **land routes declined and sea travel gained primacy**. Faxian's voyage (c.412) was perilous; Yijing (671–695) sailed Guangzhou–Palembang three times ("express boats… stopped for no one"). An Arabic account of **851** describes Guangzhou's 30% tax. **Huang Chao**

(877/878) killed foreigners at Guangzhou, then burned Chang'an's Western Market (881). In 904 the palace was dismantled and floated to Luoyang; the Tang ended in 907, and the Silk Road entered "a quieter era".

8.4 Bhattacharya: Bengal and circulatory centrality MUST KNOW

BHATTACHARYA'S ARGUMENT

New policies (India's **Look East / Act East** since the 1990s and China's **Belt and Road Initiative** from 2013) have revived memories of old routes that had been marginalised as "frontier" and "periphery". The article argues for the **centrality of "Bengal"** (Bengal delta, Ganges–Brahmaputra valleys, Tibetan plateau, Himalayas, Arakan hills, Yunnan, and the Indian Ocean networks) in well-connected networks reaching China, Southeast Asia and the globe. Bengal **synergised overland and maritime worlds** through rivers, mountain agriculture and valley states. It was called peripheral only from the viewpoint of rulers far from the sea (Delhi; and for Yunnan, Beijing). The "Silk Route" was **not one road but a web** of pathways across land, river and sea: a **Southern Silk Route**, a **Southwest Silk Route** (China's term), or a **"Cotton Road"**.

Concepts used (useful vocabulary):

- **Periphery as construct:** counter-arguments by **Yang Bin** (Yunnan's global centrality) and **Willem van Schendel** (*The Bengal Borderland*).
- **"Zomia"** (James C. Scott): the vast uplands from Vietnam to north-east India, extended by van Schendel to the Himalayas and Tibet.
- **Tirthankar Roy**: Bengal as a "series of parallel globalizations"; Bhattacharya stresses **linkages within diversity**.
- **Braudel's *longue durée*** vs "episodic" (short-term political) history; the article "makes long leaps" across periods.
- **Lefebvre**: **space** as a means of production, control and domination. **Richard Eaton**: Bengal as a **frontier** (political, Islamic, agrarian, 13th–18th c.). **Nile Green**: sacred geographies of memory. **Massey**: "time-space compression". **Appadurai**: disjunctive global flows.
- **Wallerstein** placed South Asia in the "semi-periphery"; **Washbrook** rejected this (strong states, finance, bourgeoisie), and **Bayly and Ludden** called it Eurocentric. But even these critics used a Cold War "area studies" map that made the sub-Himalayan regions peripheral.

Bengal's history in "episodes"

- Buddhism spread under the **Mauryas** and flourished under the **Palas**; sites include Somapura, Salban Vihara, Mahasthangarh, **Tamralipti** (visited by Xuanzang in 639), Chandraketugarh and Mogalmari.
- The **Senas** reinstated a reformed Brahmanism (Shaivism, Vaishnavism, goddess cults).
- **Ilyas Shahi** sultanate (1342–57) broke from Delhi; capital at **Pandua**; two centuries of autonomy.
- Outsiders' "periphery" images: Marco Polo's "Bangala", with its "peculiar language"; **Abul Fazl**'s *Bulghakkhana* ("house of turbulence"); **Ibn Battuta**, guest of the Sufi **Shah Jalal** in Sylhet (1345), found it magical.
- Autonomy enabled global ties: **two of Zheng He's Ming expeditions** reached **Pandua (1415)** and **Gaur (1432)**; close links with **Arakan**.
- Colonial: **Plassey (1757) and Buxar (1764)**; Calcutta, the "London of the East"; partitions in **1905** and **1947**, and Bangladesh in **1971**.

Pre-colonial phase: commodities, routes and networks

Four major economic corridors: (a) **Tibet–Bhutan–Nepal–Bengal**; (b) **Yunnan–Arakan–Bengal**; (c) **Gangetic valley riverine networks**; (d) **Kamarupa (Assam)–Bengal**.

- The **Periplus** (1st c. CE) mentions trade across the Himalayas via Sikkim and the Chumbi valley, with Chinese raw silk and cloth re-exported down the Ganges. **35 mountain passes** between Kamarupa and Tibet brought **horses** to Lakhnauti. Tibet traded gold, rock salt, musk and wool; Nepal exchanged herbs, hides, musk, yak tails and timber for Indian spices, textiles, sandalwood, indigo and jewellery.

- The Silk Roads took shape from the late 1st century BCE as the **Han** occupied parts of Central Asia; Rome in the east Mediterranean and the **Kushans** (1st–4th c.) linked continents. The Southern Silk routes ran from the Tibetan mountains to the Bay of Bengal, Southeast Asia and **Guangzhou and Hepu**, overland through Burma and Yunnan to Sichuan. They were facilitated by royal patronage and diplomacy, and by monks like Xuanzang, Yijing and Faxian.
- China is "Cina" in the *Mahabharata*; "Cinasi"/"Cinapatta" (Chinese silk) in Kautilya's *Arthashastra*. The Chinese envoy **Zhang Qian** (sent in 136 BC) noted India–China trade **before the 2nd century BC**. Most knowledge comes from **Chinese records**.
- **Popular products and currencies: silver** (imported until about the 16th c.), **horses** (trans-Himalayan), **cotton textiles** (exported to China, Southeast Asia and the world) and **cowries**.

Case study 1: cotton textiles, the "Cotton Road"

Chinese sources (e.g. **Wang Ta-yuan**, c.1349–50, who visited Bengal) praise Bengal's wealth and fine cotton (*tu-lo mien*, i.e. muslin/malmal). Varieties named in Chinese include *pi-pu* (bafta), *sha-na-pa-fu* (shanbaft) and *sha-ta-eul* (chadar). India had its own cotton technology, and **China kept buying Indian cotton even after it grew its own** (Stephen Dale). Chinese names for the routes include the South Silk Road, the Southwest Silk Road, the Ancient Yunnan–Burma–India Road and the **"Road of the Shu Cloth"**. **Why "Silk Road" and not "Cotton Road"?** Richthofen's name stuck in the West (and silk was used as currency), while the Cotton Road was neglected "perhaps due to the imagination of Bengal as a merely **peripheral zone**".

Case study 2: cowries

Small shells used as **low-value money** (Bengal cowries were larger with yellow stripes; white ones came from Pegu, Arakan, Siam and Malacca), also hoarded as wealth. Mentioned by **Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing**; the Chinese word *kaoli* comes from Bengali *kauri* (Yuan–Ming records). **Ibn Battuta** describes the **Maldives–Bengal** cowrie trade; **Tomé Pires** lists links from Malabar to Bengal, Pegu and Arakan; a good chicken cost about **448 cowries** in Bengal. Cowries circulated in Chiang Mai, Borneo, Malacca and Yunnan. An unstable currency (farmable, brittle), but its spread **maps the outward stretch of the "Southern Silk Road"**. They were most prevalent under the **Palas and Senas**.

PROF: MAY SKIP **HIGHLIGHTED DETAIL IN THE ARTICLE**

The detailed route list (Yongchang, Tengchong, Bhamo, Myitkyina; Brahmaputra nodes like Sadiya and Guwahati; roads to Bodh Gaya), P.C. Bagchi's description of the Yunnanfu–Bhamo–Assam/Manipur–Pataliputra routes, the 15th–16th-century Chinese sources on Bengal (**Ma Huan**'s *Ying yai sheng lan*, Fei-sin, etc.: Bengali and Persian spoken, silver **tangka**, ports of **Chittagong** and **Sonargaon**, capital **Pandua**, Ghiyas-ud-din's embassy of 1408, a giraffe in 1438), the post-1947 transition paragraph, and the conclusion's details (Siliguri "chicken-neck", Nathu La, Duars). These are marked "may leave out", but one or two names can still enrich an answer.

Colonial phase: restructuring routes MUST KNOW

- **Colonialism restructured, rather than simply expanded, mobility** (lecture S9): new institutions, technologies and infrastructure reshaped places; it was a rupture in the continuity of trade.
- Europeans in Bengal: the **Portuguese** (Bandel factory; Chittagong; slave trade with Arakan), **Dutch** (Serampore), **French** (Chandernagore), all overshadowed by the English East India Company.
- **Warren Hastings** sent missions to **Bhutan and Tibet** in the 1770s (Bogle 1774, Hamilton, Turner 1783) to tap existing trade; fairs at Rangpur (1780) and other towns. The Deb Raja of Cooch Behar allowed only non-Europeans free passage to Tibet.
- After the British annexed the **Duars** (1841–65), Bhutanese trade suffered (the Sinchula treaty of 1865 was partly violated). Assam's **tea** industry grew after the Company lost its monopoly (1833). The **Permanent Settlement**, commercial crops (jute, indigo, sugar), plantations and mining reshaped land and people. **Bengal textiles succumbed** to the colonial order; profits flowed to the Company, reversing the earlier bullion inflow.
- Railways, telegraphs and steamships served British advantage. India–China trade via Burma rose about 30% (1896–99). **James Rennell** (first Surveyor-General, 1765) noted Yunnan was only **220 miles** from the Brahmaputra; plans emerged to link Chittagong to the Mandalay–Rangoon railway (1899). Strategic fears (Japan after 1905, France near

Yunnan) shaped the **1905 Partition** and its parallel railways. The **Younghusband** mission (1903–04) opened Tibet trade.

- The Yunnan firm **Hengshenggong** (early 20th c.) shipped Yunnan tea via Burma, Rangoon, Calcutta, Siliguri and Kalimpong to Lhasa, and Tibetan wool back to India.
- **Ledo (Stilwell) Road** (1942), Assam to Kunming through Myanmar, built after Japan cut the Burma Road; closed after independence and now being revived. Bengal's centrality turned into a "peripheral identity" after the capital moved to **Delhi in 1912**, and buffer states and borders followed.

Postcolonial rupture and 21st-century revival MUST KNOW

- After **1947** (Partition), the **1962 Sino-Indian war**, Communist China and the Cold War, **political boundaries erected huge walls**; states turned inward and away from the sea; **ASEAN (1967)** and **SAARC (1985)** separated Southeast from South Asia; area studies reinforced the divide. "The 'cowrie' connections were soon chapters of a forgotten history."
- **New millennium:** the Eastern Indian Ocean became an "arc of advantage" within the "Indo-Pacific".
  - **India: Look East Policy** (1990s, PM **Narasimha Rao**, announced in Singapore) → Vajpayee's **car rally (2004)** through the north-east → **Act East Policy** (PM **Modi**, East Asia Summit, Nay Pyi Taw, **2014**). Regional, evolving across governments, focused on the north-east "periphery"; partly **hedging** against China.
  - **China: Belt and Road Initiative** (Silk Road Economic Belt + 21st-century Maritime Silk Road), announced by **Xi Jinping in 2013** in Kazakhstan and Indonesia. A global, "one-man-driven" strategy that addresses industrial overcapacity at home and invests in Myanmar, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka. **Bangladesh is the second-largest recipient of BRI loans; India has not joined BRI.**
- **Multilateral groupings in the Bay: BIMSTEC** (born 1997 as BIST-EC; now Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand), with the **Kaladan** multimodal project (Kolkata–Sittwe–Mizoram) and the **Asian Trilateral Highway** (India–Myanmar–Thailand, Moreh to Mae Sot); **BBIN** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal) for goods and vehicles; **BCIM** (Bangladesh–China–Myanmar–India), born in Yunnan's "Kunming Initiative" (late 1990s), backed by Li Keqiang and Manmohan Singh (2013), with the **K2K (Kolkata–Kunming) car rally** (2013) and a 2,800 km corridor; also ReCAAP (anti-piracy), Milan naval exercises and the Shangri-La Dialogue. BCIM's success was arguably impeded by India staying out of BRI.
- **Contestation:** Myanmar and Bangladesh are courted by both giants; India boosts naval assets; Beijing's "containment" (90% of China's arms sales go to India's neighbours).

> **BHATTACHARYA'S CRITICAL CONCLUSION: THE POLITICAL USE OF SILK ROAD HISTORY**
>
> States have **selectively used history** (facts, legends, mythologies) for soft diplomacy and grand strategy. BRI appropriated the "Silk Route", which "at no point in history was a single route, nor a static one", as **one dominating path** from the Mediterranean to the South China Sea, pushing South and Southeast Asian channels into the periphery. Act East likewise **reasserts the peripherality** of the north-east through a centrally driven national agenda. There is a **disconnect between policy and nuanced historical understanding**, visible in displacements and walls between overlapping communities. She suggests **cosmopolitan heritage sites** with many stakeholders as an alternative. (This is Hobsbawm's **symbolic restoration and invented past** in action.)

8.5 The seven lenses on Silk Road connectivity (lecture synthesis) MUST KNOW

Lens	Hansen	Bhattacharya	What it helps us see
1 Urban	Chang'an as capital, market and religious centre; migrant destination; Western Market; elite and everyday life together	(not central)	Cosmopolitan cities, markets, daily intercultural life

2 Regional-spatial	(the city as one node)	The **macro-region** is the key unit: Bengal delta, Ganges–Brahmaputra basin, Tibetan plateau, Arakan hills, Yunnan, Bay of Bengal; **circulation over corridor**	Connections a city-level view would miss
3 Archaeology / material culture	Sogdian tombs, Hejiacun hoard, pawn tickets, figurines: burial hybridity, limited long-distance trade	Buddhist sites in Bengal	Migrants, burial practices, objects, lived exchange
4 Ecology & geography	Oasis routes; the shift to sea routes	River systems, passes, delta, maritime access; **routes are dynamic because ecologies are**; not just state policy	Bengal as a **hinge between inland and maritime Asia**
5 Migration & diaspora	Sogdians, monks, officials, craftsmen, refugees, military dependents	Merchants, caravan traders, intermediaries, diasporas; colonial business networks; state actors	Silk Road history is about **mobile communities**, not just commodities
6 Religion as connectivity	Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, Christianity in one city; monks as travellers	Buddhism across Bengal–China routes; sacred sites preserve the memory of routes	Religion **created and sustained routes**, not just travelled along them
7 Commodities	**Sceptical** of trade volume; small high-value goods	**Traces commodity circuits** (cotton, cowries, horses, silver)	Flows of goods, value, circulation systems

The question of scale

City, region, empire, ocean, borderland: **each gives a different Silk Road**. The most useful historical question: **at what scale are we studying connectivity?** (Urban archaeology vs *longue durée* regional history.)

Centre and periphery

Centres are not natural; they are historically produced, and so are peripheries. Chang'an's cosmopolitanism depended on so-called outsiders; Bengal and Yunnan were labelled peripheral by later political narratives yet were central to exchange.

Connectivity has a history

It **expands, contracts, reroutes and gets reimagined**. Modern projects (BRI, Act East, BCIM, BIMSTEC) invoke old routes. **Discussion:** are they reviving historical connectivity, or **inventing politically useful pasts**?

SUMMARY OF SESSION 8

"The Silk Road" (Richthofen, 1877) was never one road; it was **multiple, layered, changing** networks of people, religions, goods and states, and **what we see depends on the lens**. **Hansen** (city lens) uses archaeology (Sogdian tombs of An Jia and Shi Wirkak, the Hejiacun hoard, pawn tickets) to show Chang'an's **cosmopolitanism**, burial hybridity, and **limited long-distance trade in goods**: people and ideas mattered more. Its story is one of rise under the Tang, then violence (An Lushan, the bans of 843/845, Huang Chao) and a shift to the sea. **Bhattacharya** (region lens) shows **Bengal's circulatory centrality** across river, mountain and sea, through cotton (the "Cotton Road") and cowries. Colonial rule restructured routes and borders; 1947 and 1962 closed them; LEP/AEP and BRI revive them **selectively**, which is the political use of the past. Centres and peripheries are historically produced.

EXAM CORNER

1. "There is no single Silk Road." Discuss with reference to Hansen and Bhattacharya.
2. Compare the urban lens (Hansen) and the regional lens (Bhattacharya) in studying Silk Road connectivity.
3. How does archaeology change our understanding of the Silk Road? (Sogdian tombs, Hejiacun hoard, pawn tickets, Roman coins.)
4. "Centres are not natural; they are historically produced." Explain with reference to Chang'an and Bengal.
5. Are projects like BRI and Act East reviving historical connectivity or inventing politically useful pasts? (Use Hobsbawm and Bhattacharya.)

MCQ facts: "Silk Road" coined by Richthofen in 1877; *sabao* = Sogdian community headman; An Jia d. 579 (Bukhara origin); Hejiacun hoard found 1970; Nestorian stele 781 (Aluohan arrived 635); An Lushan rebellion 755–763; BRI 2013; AEP 2014; LEP 1990s (Narasimha Rao); BIMSTEC 1997; K2K rally 2013; Ledo/Stilwell Road 1942; "Cotton Road" (Stephen Dale).

SESSION
9

India and the Silk Route Connections II: Trade, Religion and Cultural Interactions (the Maritime Buddhist Networks)

Reading: Tansen Sen, "Buddhism and the Maritime Crossings", in D. C. Wong & G. Heldt (eds.), *China and Beyond in the Mediaeval Period: Cultural Crossings and Inter-Regional Connections* (Cambria/Manohar, 2014), ch. 2 · Lecture 9 PPT (Prof. Jayati Bhattacharya)

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

Session 8 showed that the "Silk Road" was many routes, mostly over land. Session 9 moves to the **sea** and to **religion**. Sen asks how **Buddhism** travelled from India to China **by sea**, and who carried it. The answer joins three course threads: **connected histories** (Session 3), **travellers as sources** (Faxian and Yijing from Session 6) and **trade–religion links** (Sessions 7, 10 and 11). It is also the bridge to Session 10's question of how religion moved across the Indian Ocean.

9.1 Sen's main argument (in one box) MUST KNOW

SIX CLAIMS OF THE ARTICLE (AND OF THE LECTURE'S "MAIN ARGUMENT" SLIDE)

1. **Critique of the "Silk Road" paradigm.** Scholarship has focused on the overland routes; one recent volume on the spread of Buddhism had **not a single chapter** on the sea routes or Southeast Asia. The phrase **"maritime Silk Road" is historically misleading**.
2. **Buddhism and maritime commerce were tied together.** Like the overland spread, the sea spread of Buddhism was **closely connected to mercantile activities**.
3. **"Long-distance", not "contact", transmission** (borrowing **Erik Zürcher**'s model): in the first centuries CE, **maritime Southeast Asia was only a "transit zone"** where monks changed ships, not a place where Buddhism was established and then passed on step by step.
4. **India–China maritime Buddhist networks** were cosmopolitan: Indian, Sogdian and Central Asian merchants and monks, Sri Lankan nuns, Southeast Asian rulers.
5. **Sri Lanka** was not just the home of Theravada; it was also a centre of **relic cults** and of **Tantric** (and Mahayana) Buddhism linked to India, Java and China.
6. **Long-term transformation:** maritime Buddhist networks **lasted longer** than the overland ones (into the 19th–20th centuries).

9.2 Why "maritime Silk Road" is a misleading label MUST KNOW

Recall: **Ferdinand von Richthofen** coined *Die Seidenstrassen* ("Silk Roads") in **1877** for the overland China–Europe routes through Central Asia. Later, **every** route linking China to the outside world got called a "Silk Road". Sen's objections:

1. **Silk was not the main cargo at sea.** Early maritime trade was in **beads, precious stones and pearls**; later, **bulk goods** such as **incense, pepper, spices and porcelain** (the lecture adds ceramics, metals and textiles). Silk was "neither the earliest nor the most commonly traded commodity".
2. **It over-emphasises China.** China was a major market and source, but ports, traders and ships from **Southeast Asia, India and the Middle East** were equally crucial. **The Chinese became active in Indian Ocean shipping only from the 10th century.**
3. **It underestimates Southeast Asia and Indian Ocean societies.** Southeast Asia's rise as an economic, political and religious centre was crucial for the Mediterranean–China sea link.

Sen's alternative: see maritime Asia as a **multi-centred commercial world**, not a China-centred extension of the Silk Roads.

Deep background: the sea was busy long before Buddhism

- **2500–1500 BCE: Austronesian migrations** created maritime networks linking southern China, mainland Southeast Asia and the Indonesian archipelago.
- **1st millennium BCE:** metal technology and **wet-rice cultivation** spread through these networks; by the second half of the millennium they reached India. **Southeast Asian sailors were as important as South Asian ones**; Southeast Asia exported **tin and gold** and imported semi-precious stones and glass; Indian craftsmen in Southeast Asia made Indian-style goods.
- **1st c. CE: Funan** (Mekong delta, southern Vietnam and Cambodia) rose as a "buffer" between India and China; its ports, especially **Oc Eo**, **trans-shipped** cargo between "these two giant markets" (until about the mid-5th century).
- **India:** Mauryas (c.324 BCE), then the Kushans, Guptas, Satavahanas, Cheras and Cholas sustained trade. **Indo-Roman trade** (1st c. CE): Roman coins, beads and glass in Tamil Nadu and Andhra, in exchange for **black pepper and textiles**.
- **China:** under the Qin and Han, rhinoceros horn, ivory, pearls and incense reached the ports of **Jiaozhi** (north Vietnam), **Hepu** (Guangxi) and **Panyu (Guangzhou)**. **Sima Qian** and **Ban Gu** describe Guangzhou as a rich trading outpost; glass, amber and agate appear in Han elite tombs; by the **Jin** (265–420) even commoners wore foreign jewellery. With these traders, **Buddhist preachers, texts and ritual items** came to China.

9.3 Land or sea first? Sen's way out of an old debate SUPPORTING

Position	Who / evidence
Buddhism first reached China **by sea**	**Liang Qichao**, **Paul Pelliot**
Buddhism first came **overland** via Central Asia (traditional view)	**Tang Yongtong**, **Rong Xinjiang**
Sen: the debate is "irrelevant"	There is no archaeological evidence of Buddhist monasteries in either eastern Central Asia or maritime Southeast Asia before the **4th century**, by which time Buddhism was already in China. The evidence points to **both routes**: late-2nd-century Buddhist carvings at **Mount Kongwang** (coastal Jiangsu) suggest the sea; Buddha figures in **Han tombs in Sichuan** suggest the land. So the transmission came by **multiple routes**, not one conduit.

IN SIMPLE WORDS: "LONG-DISTANCE" VS "CONTACT" TRANSMISSION (ZÜRCHER)

Contact transmission works like a relay race: Buddhism spreads to the next region, settles there and builds monasteries, and that region passes it on to the next. **Long-distance transmission** works like a long-haul flight: monks and texts travel **straight from India to China**, and the places in between are just **stop-overs**. Zürcher argued that Central Asian oasis towns (Kucha, Khotan) became real Buddhist centres only from the **mid-3rd century**, once farming, population and trade grew. Sen applies the same model to the sea: **early Southeast Asia was a stop-over ("transit zone")**.

Better question (Sen): instead of "which route came first", study the **complementary, interconnected and sometimes competitive** roles of land and sea. Many monks used **both**; **Mahayana**-dominated networks grew on the Central Asian land routes, while maritime networks later featured **Theravada**. The lecture calls this balanced view (**land and sea complemented each other**; sea did not "replace" land) **one of the article's greatest strengths**.

9.4 Monks and merchants: partners, but not always friends MUST KNOW

Reciprocity (the dominant model)

- **James Heitzman**: within South Asia, Buddhist monasteries stood near commercial towns and trade routes, in **mutual support** with merchants.
- **Xinru Liu** extended this to India–China: an **interdependent, reciprocal relationship** between monks and merchants.
- **Merchants:** carried monks; met the demand for ritual items; financed monasteries and missions; circulated relics and carried manuscripts.
- **Monks and monasteries:** met merchants' spiritual needs; protected merchants and gave lodging; created **trusted commercial environments**; introduced new items into trade.
- ***Saptaratna* ("seven jewels", Ch. *qibao*)**: offerings of precious objects to monasteries **created demand** for **pearls, lapis lazuli and coral** exported from India.

Lecture's point: religion did not merely accompany trade; **it became embedded within commercial exchange itself**. Buddhism expanded **because commercial networks already existed**.

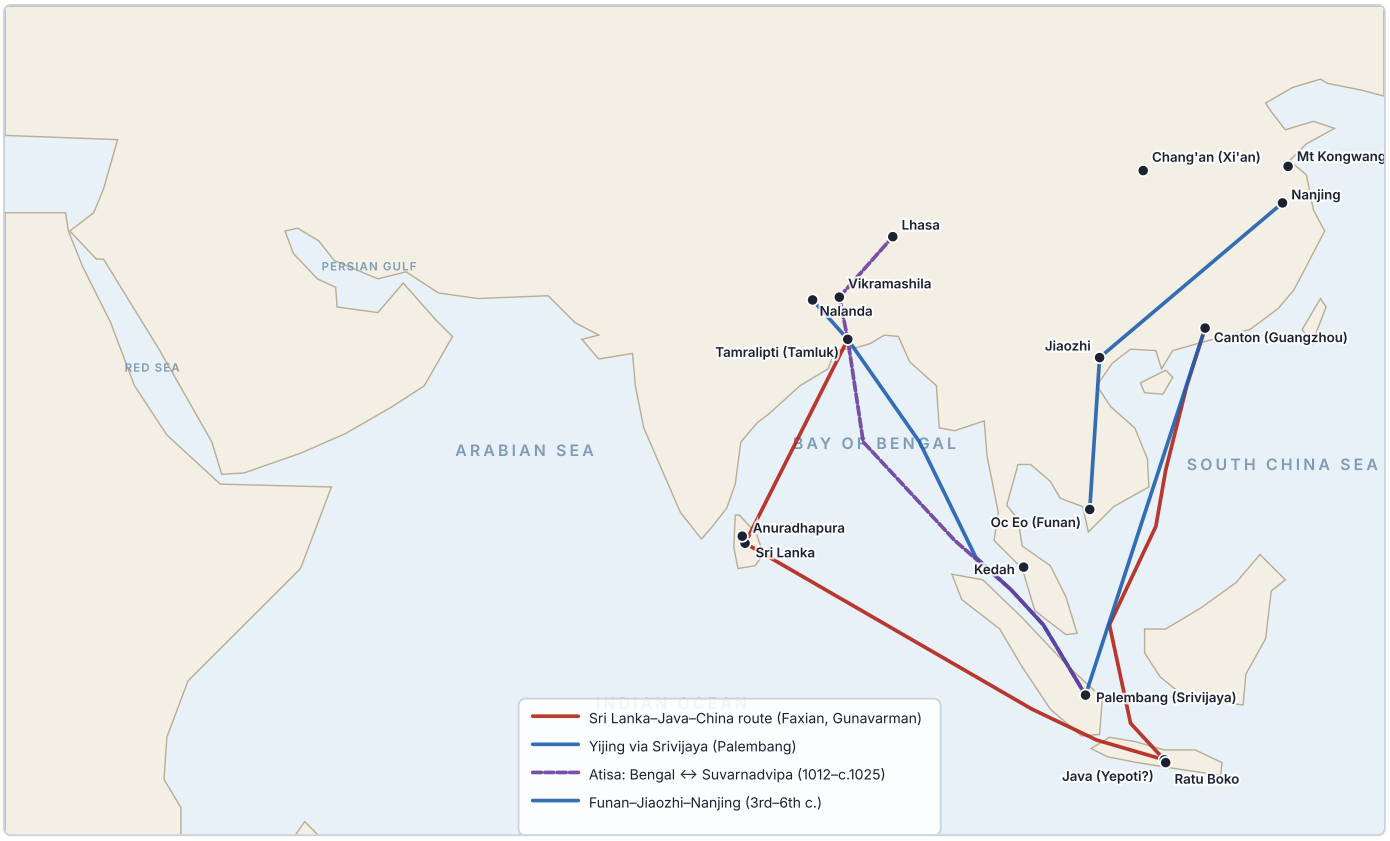
Antagonism (Sen's addition)

Traders specialised in particular goods and route segments, owed loyalty to particular patrons, and believed in particular deities. Some were **Brahmanical** or later **Muslim**, and even Buddhist merchants may have **competed** over the lucrative trade in texts and ritual items. So the relationship was "more complex than is usually recognized".

Example: Faxian, 411/412. About a month out from **Yepoti** (Yavadvipa, Java/Sumatra?), a storm struck. The terrified merchants, whom Faxian calls **"Brahmins"**, blamed the Chinese monk for bad luck and wanted to **abandon him on an island**. His patron (*tanyue*, Skt. *danapati*) threatened to report them to the Chinese ruler, who respected monks, and the merchants "faltered".

Sen calls for more study of Buddhist monks' relations with the **Brahmanical and Muslim** trader networks that dominated intra-Asian routes after the first millennium.

9.5 The India–China maritime network (3rd–6th centuries) MUST KNOW



Maritime Buddhist networks (Tansen Sen). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Mount Kongwang (northern Jiangsu, late 2nd c.): Buddhist carvings mixed with **Daoist** motifs, and donors in **Central Asian** dress (Indo-Scythians or Parthians, key players in India–China sea trade via Southeast Asia). **Why were Central Asians at sea?** The **Kushan empire** (1st c. CE), spanning Central Asia and north and east India, created **interlocking overland and maritime** trade networks; Sogdians were active in trade, diplomacy and religion. **Trade, diplomacy and religion were intertwined.**

Person	What to remember
Kang Senghui (d. 280)	**Sogdian** monk; ancestors lived in India as merchants; his seafaring father migrated to **Jiaozhi**, where he grew up and became a monk; went to **Jiankang (Nanjing)**, close to ruler **Sun Quan** (222–52); spread Buddhism in south China. This shows **Sogdian seafaring merchants** in Southeast Asia (but no evidence of monasteries there in the 3rd c.).
Kang Tai (3rd c.)	Envoy (perhaps Sogdian) sent by Sun Quan to **Jiaozhi and Funan**, perhaps to promote trade
Kashmiri & South Asian monks (4th–6th c.)	Buddhajiva; **Gunavarman** (367–431); **Gunabhadra** (394–468); **Paramartha** (499–569); **Bodhidharma** (6th c.). The last three first landed at **Guangzhou**, a Buddhist centre from the 3rd century.
Early Guangzhou monks	**Jivaka** and **Kumara** (3rd c.) founded early monasteries; **Dharmayasas** from Kapisa (Kashmir/Afghanistan), arrived 401, linked to the **Guangxiao Monastery**
Zhu Pole (Bhallaka?)	A 4th-c. **Indian expatriate in Guangzhou**; his son Jinqie became a monk under Dharmayasas (from the 6th-c. text *Chu sanzang ji ji*)
Nandin (Zhu Nanti)	5th-c. South Asian **"ship owner"** (*bozhu*); carried **Gunavarman** and **two groups of Sri Lankan nuns** to Guangzhou; himself helped translate texts. **The clearest merchant–Buddhism link.**
Gunavarman's route	Sri Lanka → **Java** (lived there several years, helped establish Buddhism in the "Holing" region) → Nanjing (431)
Funan monks (6th c.)	**Samghapala** (460–524) and **Mandrasena** went to Nanjing to translate texts

Faxian's return voyage (411–412): the first detailed sea account

- **Tamralipti** → **Sri Lanka** → a "large ship" of **200+ people** with a rescue boat; a typhoon on day 3 and a leak; cargo thrown or unloaded; about **90 days** to **Yepoti**.
- After **5 months**, another 200-person ship with 50 days' provisions, bound for Guangzhou; blown off course; after about 3 months it reached **north-east China (Shandong)**.
- *"On the seas there are many pirates... The great ocean spreads out, a boundless expanse. There is no knowing east or west; only by observing the sun, moon, and stars..."*
- He found **no Buddhism at Yepoti**, which supports the transit-zone argument.

A shift in shipping lanes (5th c.)

Earlier the **Funan–Jiaozhi** region (port of **Oc Eo**) was the key link; Sun Quan sent envoys there. From the 5th century, **Java, Sumatra and Kedah** (Malay peninsula) became the main centres, so Faxian's ship stopped at an Indonesian island, not at Oc Eo. Later monks also passed through the Indonesian islands.

9.6 Southeast Asia: from transit zone to Buddhist centre MUST KNOW

1st–4th c.
Transit zone: ships stopped, changed crews, replenished supplies; no monasteries

→

5th c.
First Buddhist inscription: **Buddhagupta**, a "sea captain", at **Kedah**; Gunavarman in Java

→

7th–13th c.
Srivijaya (Palembang): Mahayana and Tantric hub

→

12th c. on
Theravada / Pali networks with Sri Lanka

Evidence for the "transit zone" phase (lecture): early Buddhist monasteries are **absent before the 4th–5th centuries**; Buddhist **inscriptions appear late**; Buddhist institutions **grow alongside expanding maritime commerce**. In fact maritime India–China traffic **helped establish** Buddhism in parts of Southeast Asia. The **Buddhagupta inscription** (5th c., from **Raktamrttika**, now in the Indian Museum, Kolkata) records a sea captain's prayers to the Buddha and confirms the **Buddhism–seafaring trader** link and Kedah's rise.

Srivijaya (7th–13th centuries) MUST KNOW

- Ruled from **Palembang (Sumatra)**; controlled Sumatra, Java and the Malay peninsula, and so the routes between the Bay of Bengal and the South China Sea.
- Used **Buddhism in diplomacy**: inscriptions at **Nalanda**, **Nagapattinam** (east coast of India) and **Nakhon Si Thammarat** (south Thailand) record Srivijayan donations to monasteries. (These come back in Session 10.)
- **Yijing** (635–713) studied there (Ch. *Foshi*) on his way to **Nalanda**: *"In the fortified city of Fo-che, there are more than one thousand Buddhist monks… Rules and ceremonies are identical [to India]. If a Chinese monk wants to travel to India… he must stay in Fo-che for one or two years."* He returned to Sumatra to write his works. His *Biographies of eminent monks who travelled to the Western Regions* covers **60 Chinese monks**, of whom **36 from China and 2 from Korea** went to India **by sea**.
- **Lecture's point:** intellectual authority was **no longer monopolised by India**; knowledge became **distributed across maritime Asia**.

Tantric Buddhism in Srivijaya (not mentioned by Yijing)

- An **Old Malay inscription of 684** (Palembang) suggests knowledge of the ***Gandavyuha sutra*** (Hiram Woodward); the **Kota Kapur** and **Telaga Batu** inscriptions also suggest Tantra.
- **Punyodaya (Nati)**, 7th c.: travelled between China and Cambodia.
- **Vajrabodhi** (670–741): to China via Java in the early 8th century. **Amoghavajra** (d. 774): through the region in the mid-8th century.
- **Bianhong**, a Javanese monk, went to China in **780** and studied under Amoghavajra's student **Huiguo**.
- **Atisa** (982–1054), a prince from eastern India, went to Srivijaya in **1012** to study under **Dharmakirti** for about **13 years**; then **Vikramashila**; invited to **Tibet in 1040**; carried Dharmakirti's *Durbodha aloka*, the oldest surviving Southeast Asian Buddhist commentary. **An Indian going to Southeast Asia to learn: the flow reversed.**

End of the 12th century: Chinese Buddhism took "its own ideological path", away from Indian Tantra, while Bay of Bengal trade (Myanmar, south India, Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia) grew stronger, so **Theravada** from Sri Lanka shaped Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia and Laos (the "Theravada/Pali" networks).

9.7 Sri Lanka reinterpreted: relics, Tantra and the Bay of Bengal MUST KNOW

LECTURE: "PERHAPS THE MOST SIGNIFICANT CONTRIBUTION OF THIS ARTICLE"

Most histories describe Sri Lanka **simply as the centre of Theravada**. Sen shows it was also a **transit point** from the **4th century**, a **repository of relics**, a **staging ground for pilgrims**, a centre of **Mahayana and Tantric** traditions, and a **diplomatic actor** across the Bay of Bengal. Faxian, Vajrabodhi, Amoghavajra (and, in the lecture, Atisa) all passed through; its monasteries were **intellectual crossroads**, not isolated Theravada centres.

The relic cult and political power

- **Faxian** saw the **Bodhi-tree sapling** (planted in **Ashoka**'s time, r. c.270–232 BCE) and the annual **tooth relic** ritual at **Abhayagiri** led by the king. Also famous: the Buddha's **alms bowl** and **footprint**.
- **Candrabhanu**, a Southeast Asian king (probably from **Tambralinga**, Malay peninsula), **attacked Sri Lanka in 1247 and 1262** to get relics (*Culavamsa*).
- **Kublai Khan** sent an envoy in **1284**, perhaps for the alms bowl (after missions to south India in 1272 and 1275).
- **Zheng He** captured a Sri Lankan "ruler" in **1410**, probably wanting the **tooth relic**.
- Rulers believed relics had **magical powers** to project **political power**.

Tantric masters and Abhayagiri

- **Vajrabodhi**, told in a vision by Amitabha Buddha, went to Sri Lanka, venerated the tooth relic for **6 months** at **Abhayagiri**, saw the footprint at Lankaparvata, then sailed on a **"Persian" ship** to Srivijaya (where he may have met Amoghavajra) and reached China **719–20**.
- **Amoghavajra** (some biographies say Sri Lankan by birth) went in **741** after Vajrabodhi's death, on a **Kunlun (Southeast Asian) ship**, perhaps because of Xuanzong's 740 expulsion of foreign monks, or (Sundberg) to get the Tantric text *Sarvatathagata-tattvasamgraha*. The king bathed him; he learned from the Sri Lankan monk **Samantabhadra**; he returned in **746** with a diplomatic mission and the *Prajnaparamita sutra*.
- **Abhayagiri** had Mahayana leanings from the 3rd century; it had ties with **Pala** Bihar–Bengal (750–1120), Tamralipti, Mahabodhi and Nalanda. Around **800**, the abbot of **Vikramashila** was the Sri Lankan **Jayabhadra**. Gunawardana: Tantra was influential at Abhayagiri by the 9th century.

RATU BOKO, JAVA (792): SRI LANKA'S INFLUENCE IN SOUTHEAST ASIAN ARCHITECTURE

A Sanskrit inscription from **Ratu Boko** (central Java), dated **792**, reads: *"This Abhayagiri Vihara here of the Ceylonese [Sinhalese] ascetics... was established."* **J. G. de Casparis**: this is a **second Abhayagiri Vihara**, either a replica or a building sharing its form or spirit. **Véronique Degroot**: it was dedicated to **Avalokitesvara**, and the Sinhalese influence came only in **later stages** (e.g. the northern platform has four access points instead of one). **John Miksic**: similar **double platforms joined by a "bridge"**, a wall, rocky sites on the edge of a capital, pools and simple carving, but **differences** (an **east–west** axis in Sri Lanka vs **north–south** in Java) showing **Javanese adaptation**. **Lesson: local adaptation, not copying.**

11th–15th centuries: close links between Sri Lanka, **Myanmar, Cambodia and Thailand**. When the **Cholas invaded** Sri Lanka (11th c.), monks took refuge in Myanmar; after **Vijayabahu I** (r. 1055–1110) liberated the island, Sri Lankan and Burmese monks **together restored Buddhism** there. In the 12th–13th centuries Sri Lankan rulers sent monks, relics and texts to Myanmar; Sri Lankan monks visited **Sukhothai, Chiang Mai and Ava** and performed purification ceremonies. **Modern echo: Anagarika Dharmapala** (1864–1933) travelled by sea to India, Japan, China and the USA to make Buddhism a world religion.

9.8 Long-term transformation and conclusion MUST KNOW

Ashoka (3rd c. BCE)	Buddhism enters Sri Lanka; maritime spread may begin
Early period (1st–5th c.)	**India** → **China**; Southeast Asia is a transit zone; Sogdian and Indian merchants; Guangzhou and Nanjing
Middle period (7th–11th c.)	Srivijaya and Sri Lanka as centres; Mahayana and **Tantric** networks; Vajrabodhi, Amoghavajra, Atisa
Later period (11th c. on)	**Sri Lanka** → **Southeast Asia**: **Theravada/Pali** networks linking Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand and Cambodia
13th c.	Overland routes dominated by **Islamic** exchanges, but **maritime Buddhist exchange continues**
19th–20th c.	Chinese diaspora; Chinese in **Calcutta**; monk **Taixu** (1890–1947); Malaya, Singapore, Thailand and Myanmar as intermediaries, reviving the 1st-millennium networks

SEN'S CONCLUSION IN BRIEF

Buddhism moved through **trade routes**, carried by **monks, traders and other travellers**, over both short and long distances. Maritime routes **complemented** land routes and created **unique networks**. Southeast Asia, like eastern Central Asia on land, was first a **transit zone**. Maritime Buddhist links **endured longer** than overland ones. Southeast Asia's later contribution to Chinese Buddhism needs more study.

9.9 Evaluating Sen (lecture's critical evaluation) MUST KNOW

Strengths and contributions

1. **Connected histories:** not separate histories of India, China and Southeast Asia, but **interconnected networks**.
2. **Maritime history:** the sea is **not empty space but an active historical arena**.
3. **Network theory:** ideas spread through **networks, not political boundaries**.
4. **Economic history:** trade and religion are **mutually reinforcing**.
5. **Buddhist studies:** the long-term evolution of networks.

- **Interdisciplinary evidence:** archaeology, inscriptions, travel accounts, Chinese chronicles, Buddhist biographies, material culture.
- **Strong comparative framework:** land and sea **complemented** each other.
- **Excellent use of mobility:** people, objects, texts, rituals and ideas **all travelled together**.

Limitations

1. **Heavy dependence on Chinese textual sources** (Faxian, Yijing, Chinese Buddhist biographies). Recall Session 2 on **source criticism**: whose voice survives?
2. **Limited local agency:** early Southeast Asians appear as **intermediaries**, not active producers of Buddhist thought. Recent scholarship stresses **local adaptation, not passive reception** (cf. Ratu Boko).
3. **Merchants generalised** into one category; their different motivations need more attention: **Tamil merchant guilds, Arab merchants, Malay traders, Gujarati merchants**.
4. **Gender almost absent**: apart from the Sri Lankan nuns, women get little attention.

9.10 "Silk Roads": connecting the old with the new SUPPORTING

- **The lens has changed in the new millennium. OBOR → BRI** is Xi's most important foreign-policy initiative. It focuses on **Central Asia** (Chinese capital flowing into Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan and Tajikistan), integrates markets, and **feeds the needs of Chinese steel and coal production**, aimed at industrialising Central Asia. The lecture asks: **why did India refrain from joining?** (e.g. objections to the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor through disputed Kashmir, and debt concerns; see the Forbes 2017 article the lecture cites.)
- **Re-emergence of the Southern Silk Route:** its rhetoric is now part of political, policy and academic dialogue, rethinking Yunnan–Myanmar–India links "that had **never ceased to exist**".
- **Three take-aways** (repeated from Bhattacharya): (1) the Southern Silk Road was a **network** (overland, riverine and maritime), not one line; (2) **colonialism restructured rather than simply expanded mobility**, disrupting older circulations and imposing borders; (3) **modern states selectively use the past** (BRI, Act East, BCIM): "the past is being **mobilized**, not neutrally remembered."
- **Multilateral groupings in the Bay of Bengal: BIMSTEC** (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation); the **Asian Trilateral Highway** (India–Myanmar–Thailand); **BCIM** (Bangladesh–China–Myanmar–India); **BBIN** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal).

New approaches to the study of the "Silk Roads" (historiography table) MUST KNOW

Earlier scholarship	Contemporary scholarship

One Silk Road	**Multiple Silk Roads**
Overland focus	Overland **and maritime** networks
Trade in luxury goods	Exchange of goods, **ideas, religions, technologies and people**
State- and empire-centred	**Networks, mobility and connectivity**
National or civilisational histories	**Connected and global** histories
Static routes	**Dynamic, evolving** networks
Text-based evidence	**Interdisciplinary**: archaeology, material culture, GIS, environmental data and texts
China–Europe axis	**Multi-centred** Eurasian and Indian Ocean worlds

Fields feeding the new approach: connected histories, network theory, maritime Silk Roads, mobility studies, global history, Indian Ocean studies, religious networks, material culture, environmental history, digital humanities and GIS mapping, comparative empire studies, interdisciplinary Silk Road studies.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 9

Sen rejects "maritime Silk Road" as a label (silk was not the main cargo; it is China-centric; Chinese shipping in the Indian Ocean dates only from the 10th c.) and sees maritime Asia as **multi-centred**, with roots in Austronesian voyaging, Funan/Oc Eo, Indo-Roman trade and Han Guangzhou. The land-vs-sea debate (Liang Qichao/Pelliot vs Tang Yongtong/Rong Xinjiang) is **irrelevant**: Mount Kongwang and the Sichuan tombs show both routes. Buddhism spread by **long-distance transmission** (Zürcher), with Southeast Asia as a **transit zone** until the 5th c. (Buddhagupta, Kedah). **Monks and merchants** were reciprocal partners (Heitzman, Liu, *saptaratna*; Nandin the ship owner) but sometimes antagonists (Faxian and the "Brahmin" merchants). The networks included Kang Senghui, Gunavarman, Paramartha and Bodhidharma via Guangzhou and Nanjing. **Srivijaya** became a learning centre (Yijing: 1,000 monks; Atisa studied under Dharmakirti). **Sri Lanka** was a hub of **relics** (Candrabhanu, Kublai, Zheng He) and **Tantra** (Vajrabodhi, Amoghavajra, Abhayagiri, Jayabhadra, Ratu Boko 792). Later Theravada networks reached Myanmar, Thailand and Cambodia, and maritime links **outlasted** overland ones (Dharmapala, Taixu).

EXAM CORNER

1. Why does Tansen Sen consider the term "maritime Silk Road" misleading?
2. "Religion did not merely accompany trade; it became embedded within commercial exchange." Discuss with reference to Buddhism's maritime spread.
3. Explain the idea of Southeast Asia as a "transit zone" in the early spread of Buddhism. What evidence supports it?
4. How does Sen reinterpret the role of Sri Lanka in Buddhist networks?
5. Critically evaluate Sen's article: its strengths and limitations (Chinese sources, local agency, merchants, gender).
6. Essay link: "Connectivity has a history." Use Sessions 7–9 (Bernstein, Hansen, Bhattacharya, Sen) to show how routes expanded, shifted and were reimagined.

MCQ facts: Richthofen 1877; Austronesian migrations 2500–1500 BCE; Funan port Oc Eo; Chinese active in Indian Ocean from 10th c.; Kang Senghui d. 280 (Sogdian, Jiaozhi → Nanjing); Gunavarman reached Nanjing 431; Faxian's return voyage 411; Buddhagupta inscription (Kedah, 5th c.); Srivijaya at Palembang (7th–13th c.); Atisa to Srivijaya 1012, to Tibet 1040; Vajrabodhi in China 719–20; Amoghavajra to Sri Lanka 741, back 746; Ratu Boko inscription 792; Candrabhanu attacks 1247 and 1262; Zheng He in Sri Lanka 1410; Vijayabahu I r. 1055–1110; Dharmapala 1864–1933; Taixu 1890–1947.

SESSION
10

Religions in India: Encounters, Adaptations and Transregional Influences

Readings: T. N. Madan (ed.), *India's Religions: Perspectives from Sociology and History* (OUP), "Introduction" · John Guy, "Tamil Merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist Diaspora in Early Southeast Asia" (ch. 11, in *Early Interactions between South and Southeast Asia*, ISEAS) · Himanshu Prabha Ray, "A 'Chinese' Pagoda at Nagapattinam on the Tamil Coast: Revisiting India's Early Maritime Networks" (IIC Occasional Publication 66, 2014/15) · Lecture 10 PPT

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

This session has **two halves**. **Half 1 (Madan)** asks what "religion" means in India: it is **plural**, **internally diverse**, **lived** and **socially embedded**. **Half 2 (Guy, Ray)** asks what happens to religion **when people move** across the Indian Ocean: it is **carried, translated, appropriated and reinterpreted**. The bridge, in the lecture's words: *"If religion is plural, lived, adaptive and socially embedded… how does it change when people move?"* The professor's model short answer (front matter) on **doctrine vs lived religion** comes from this session, so it is **very likely in the exam**.

10.1 The lecture's conceptual toolkit MUST KNOW

India is not simply a land of "many religions"

- **Religions originating in India (Indic):** Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism.
- **Religions that arrived from outside:** Christianity, Judaism, Islam, Zoroastrianism, Bahá'í.
- Study their **interaction** and their relationship with **society and politics**.
- The study of religion has shifted **from studying religions only "objectively"** (as doctrines) **to religion as a social and historical phenomenon**.

Plurality ≠ Pluralism

- **Plurality** is a **fact**: many religious traditions **exist**.
- **Pluralism** is a **value or practice**: communities **negotiate their coexistence** through accommodation, interaction, borrowing, negotiation, competition and conflict.
- **Key question:** *How do people live with religious difference?*

Idea	What the lecture says
Religion is not one homogeneous entity	Religions are **internally diverse**. Hinduism includes Shaiva, Vaishnava, Shakta, bhakti and regional and sectarian traditions; Islam, Buddhism, Christianity, Jainism and Sikhism are also diverse in schools, sects, philosophies, rituals, regional variations and competing authorities. Boundaries **exist but are neither perfectly fixed nor internally uniform**.
Religion as lived experience	Religion is more than belief: **belief → practice → experience → social life**. Food, worship, pilgrimage, death rituals, festivals, sacred spaces, family practices and community institutions. **Distinguish religion as doctrine from religion as lived practice**; stay mindful of the gap between **textual references and lived experience**.
Religion and society are intertwined	Religion is embedded in caste, community, family, gender, economy, political authority, hierarchy and institutions. **A temple can also be an economic institution, a centre of redistribution, a site of political authority, a source of employment and a marker of community identity.** To understand religion historically, study the **society** in which it is practised.
Tradition is not static	**Tradition → adaptation → innovation.** Traditions reinterpret, generate new movements, respond to social change and encounter others; tradition itself contains mechanisms of reinterpretation. Examples: **bhakti**, the **Kabir Panth**, the **Ramakrishna Mission**, **Ambedkar's engagement with Buddhism**.

WHY "RELIGION" WAS MISUNDERSTOOD IN INDIA: THE JUDEO-CHRISTIAN AND COLONIAL LENS (LECTURE'S CLOSING SLIDES)

- Non-Western religions were first studied by **Christian missionaries** through a **comparison model** that was "Western" and "Christian". The **Judeo-Christian model** (one God, one book, one church, clear membership) **did not suit South Asia**, which had **competing models of divinity, diverse practice, regional distinctiveness and inclusive religious identities**. Only in the **20th century** did the **pluralist** viewpoint dominate the academic study of religion.
- **From 1871** the British **census** classified the population by caste and community. Despite the varying status of castes and the **fluidity of religious identity** from region to region, it used **uniform categories**. Despite a policy of "non-interference", colonial administration **enlivened perceptions of caste and community**. The census's philosophical assumptions were problematic for South Asia and led to the **hardening of religious identities** (Muslim *or* Hindu *or* Sikh).
- **Connect:** this is the same **colonial knowledge** problem as in **Session 4** (Orientalism, Said, Mill) and the "census" step in **Session 1's** invention of tradition.

10.2 Madan: India's religions (the Introduction) MUST KNOW

MADAN'S MAIN ARGUMENTS IN BRIEF

1. India is a land of **religious plurality at two levels**: **between** religions (the global level) and **within** each religion (the intra-religious level of sects and movements).
2. The distinction between "pluralist" Indic religions and "homogeneous" (fundamentalist) religions of foreign origin is **"wholly misleading"**. Any religion with many regional groups and millions of followers develops **internal plurality**; Islam and Christianity in India are as diverse as Hinduism.
3. In India religion **encompasses** the secular; **dharma** is not the same as the Latin *religio*.
4. **Plurality is a fact; whether it produced pluralism as an ideology** is a separate question. Traditional pluralism was often **hierarchical** ("tolerate and rank"). Popular **folk pluralism** (lived) differs from **intellectual or secular pluralism** (ideological).

(a) Religion, dharma and the numbers

- **Dharma vs *religio*:** *dharma* is a moral and cosmic order, duty and the right way of life (including law, caste duties and life stages). The Western idea of "religion" as a separate private sphere of belief does not fit; in India religion has traditionally **encompassed** the secular (politics, economy, family).
- **Hinduism as a "federation of faiths":** no single founder, book, creed or church; a loose union of many sects, gods, philosophies and practices.
- **Dalits** (formerly "untouchables") occupy an ambiguous place: some reject Hindu identity (e.g. Kancha Ilaiah's *Why I am not a Hindu*), and many converted (to Buddhism under Ambedkar, or to Christianity).

Census of India 1991 (Madan)

Religion	Share
Hindus	about 82%
Muslims	about 12%
Christians	2.32%
Sikhs	1.99%
Buddhists	0.77%
Jains	0.41%

Minorities are **concentrated regionally**: Muslims are a majority in Jammu & Kashmir; Sikhs in Punjab; Christians in the north-eastern hill states (Nagaland, Mizoram, Meghalaya) and strongly present in Kerala and Goa; Buddhists mainly in Maharashtra (neo-Buddhists); Jains in Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Gujarat. Apart from Indonesia (and, Madan notes, Bangladesh), India has more Muslims than any other country.

(b) Hinduism: from the Vedas to bhakti MUST KNOW

c.2500–1800 BCE — **Harappan** civilisation: possible precursors (a "proto-Shiva" seal, mother goddess figurines, ritual bathing)

c.1500 BCE — **Aryans** (Indo-European speakers) arrive; the **Veda** (Rig, Sama, Yajur, Atharva), with Brahmanas, Aranyakas and Upanishads. **Shruti** ("that which is heard", revealed) vs **smriti** ("that which is remembered", tradition: Dharma Shastras, epics, Puranas)

c.200 BCE–300 CE — **Dharma Shastras**, especially ***Manusmriti*** (the Laws of Manu): ***varna-ashrama-dharma*** (duties by caste and life-stage: student, householder, forest-dweller, renouncer); the four goals (*dharma, artha, kama, moksha*)

Classical — **Six darshanas** (philosophical "viewpoints"): Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Mimamsa, Vedanta

Epics & Puranas — *Ramayana*, *Mahabharata* (with the **Bhagavad Gita**); Puranas bring **theism**: Vishnu's **avatars** (Rama, Krishna and others), Shiva and the Goddess. The **smarta** worship of **five deities** (Vishnu, Shiva, Devi, Surya, Ganesha)

6th–9th c. onward — **Bhakti** (loving devotion) arises in the **Tamil south** (Alvars for Vishnu, Nayanars for Shiva), then spreads north; the sant tradition (Kabir and others)

Three ritual orientations

Shrautas: follow Vedic (shrauta) sacrifice. **Smartas**: follow smriti, domestic rites and the five-deity worship. **Pauranikas**: Puranic, temple- and image-based theistic worship. Plus **Tantra** (esoteric ritual, also influencing temple worship; e.g. at Puri).

Sects (sampradayas)

Vaishnava: Pancharatra and Vaikhanasa temple traditions. **Shaiva**: Pashupata, Kapalika, Kalamukha (ascetic orders), Shaiva Siddhanta, Kashmir Shaivism, Virashaiva. **Shakta**: worship of the Goddess (Devi/Shakti), strong in Bengal, Assam and Kashmir.

Vedanta teachers

Shankara (8th c.): **Advaita** (non-dualism; Brahman alone is real). **Ramanuja** (11th–12th c.): **Vishishtadvaita** (qualified non-dualism; devotion to Vishnu). **Madhva** (13th c.): **Dvaita** (dualism).

(c) Buddhism and Jainism SUPPORTING

Buddhism

- The Buddha (Siddhartha Gautama, 6th–5th c. BCE). The **four noble truths**: suffering is universal; its cause is craving and attachment; it can end (*nirvana/nibbana*); the way is the **eightfold path**. The **three refuges**: Buddha, Dhamma, **Sangha** (monastic order).
- The second council at **Vaishali** led to a split into **Sthaviras** (elders) and **Mahasanghikas**. The Sthavira line became **Theravada**, which the Mahayanists called "Hinayana" and which survived in Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.
- **Mahayana** (the bodhisattva ideal; **Nagarjuna**'s philosophy of emptiness); **Vajrayana** (Tantric), strong in eastern India and Tibet.
- **Decline in India** (by about the 12th–13th c.): absorbed by Hinduism (the Buddha as an avatar of Vishnu), loss of patronage, and destruction of monasteries. **Revival: B. R. Ambedkar's** mass conversion of Dalits in **1956** (neo-Buddhism).
- Pluralism in Buddhism (Madan): "even the Buddhas are many" (Mahayana), but doctrinal pluralism did **not** mean sectarian tolerance; Mahayanists "virtually drove" Theravada out to Sri Lanka.

Jainism

- **Mahavira** (6th c. BCE), the 24th **tirthankara** ("ford-maker"); extreme **ahimsa** (non-violence) and asceticism.
- Because farming harms living beings, Jains turned to **trade and banking**: a **merchant** community (Gujarat, Rajasthan).
- Split into **Shvetambara** ("white-clad") and **Digambara** ("sky-clad", whose monks go naked).
- **Anekantavada** ("many-sidedness"): reality has infinite aspects, so no single view is complete. Hence **syadvada** (conditional assertion, "in some respect it is..."), qualified by four specifications: substance (*sva-dravya*), location (*sva-kshetra*), time (*sva-kala*) and state of being (*sva-bhava*).

(d) Sikhism SUPPORTING

- **Guru Nanak (1469–1539)**, a representative of the north Indian **sant** tradition; ***nam simran*** (remembrance of the divine Name); rejected external formalism (rituals, customs, caste distinctions) and offered a "transcendent third path" beyond Hinduism and Islam.
- **Guru Gobind Singh**, the tenth and last personal guru, created the **Khalsa** ("the pure") in **1699** with initiation by ***pahul*** (baptism); Khalsa Sikhs keep their hair **unshorn** and are distinct from both Hindus and Muslims. Authority passed to the **Guru Granth Sahib** (*gurbani*).
- Types: **Amritdhari** (initiated), **Keshdhari** (keep hair, uninitiated), **Sahajdhari** ("slow adopters" who cut their hair). Codes of conduct (*rahitnamas*) tightened identity. A lax Sikh is a *patit* (lapsed).
- History: the kingdom of **Ranjit Singh** (early 19th c.); reform sects (**Nirankari**, **Namdhari**); the **Singh Sabhas** (late 19th c.) defined Sikhs as separate from Hindus; the **Bhindranwale** phenomenon (1980s) showed a **fundamentalist** turn. Madan: **the Khalsa version is exclusivist, not pluralist**, and the Sikh vision, like the Hindu and Muslim ones, is **hierarchical**.

(e) Christianity in India SUPPORTING

- **1st c. (tradition)** — **St Thomas** the Apostle on the Malabar coast: the **Syrian Christians** (St Thomas Christians) of Kerala
- **4th & 8th–9th c.** — Migrations of Syrian Christians from West Asia strengthen the community (links with the Church of the East)
- **16th c.** — Portuguese: **Franciscans** in **Goa**; **St Francis Xavier** arrives **1542**; the **Inquisition** in Goa; **Jesuits** at **Akbar's** court; **Roberto de Nobili** (from 1606) adopts a Brahman sannyasi lifestyle at Madurai (accommodation)
- **18th c.** — Protestants: **Ziegenbalg** (Lutheran, Danish mission at Tranquebar; Tamil Bible work, 1712)

1814 → Anglican diocese of Calcutta (1814); reform among Syrian Christians (the **Mar Thoma** church); church unions: the **Church of South India (1947)** and the **Church of North India (1970)**. **Article 30** of the Constitution protects minorities' right to run educational institutions.

(f) Islam in India MUST KNOW

- Begins with the Prophet's **hijra (622)**; the **five pillars** (shahada, prayer, fasting, zakat, hajj). Madan notes that **jihad is not an obligatory "pillar"** for Indian Muslims.
- **Arrival by trade before conquest:** Arab traders on the **Malabar** coast, giving rise to the **Mapillas** (Moplahs), Muslims of mixed Arab–local descent who adopted local customs. **Sind** was conquered in **712** (Muhammad bin Qasim); later the Turkish sultanates and the Mughals.
- **Local incorporation:** converts kept caste-like groups, local customs and saint veneration.
- **Ulama vs Sufis:** the **ulama** (jurists, e.g. the chronicler **Barani**, who urged rulers to enforce the sharia) vs the **Sufis**, mystics whose shrines attracted Hindus and Muslims alike. Islam spread largely **peacefully** (Sufis and trade), not mainly by the sword; at Partition, **less than a quarter** of the subcontinent's population was Muslim.

Internal diversity of Indian Islam

- **Sunni** majority (mostly the **Hanafi** school of law) and **Shia** minority.
- **Sufi orders**: Chishti, Suhrawardi, Qadiri, Naqshbandi. In Kashmir, the **Rishi** order (**Nuruddin**, 1379–1442), which drew on local ascetic traditions, alongside Iranian influence (**Hamadani**).
- 19th-century movements: **Deoband** (1867, orthodox seminary); **Aligarh** (Sir Syed, Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College, 1875: modern education); **Ahl-i-Hadis** (scripturalist); **Barelwis** (defend saint veneration and shrine practice).
- **Ahmadiyah** (Mirza Ghulam Ahmad of **Qadian**, Punjab; claimed to be the *mahdi*). Recognised as Muslim in India, unlike in Pakistan; Madan reads this as a "general attitude of tolerance".

(g) Religious pluralism as ideology: has plurality produced pluralism? MUST KNOW

Tradition / person	Pluralist idea (and its limit, per Madan)
Rig Veda (I.164.46)	"The Absolute is one, although the sages have given it different names." But this pluralism is **internal** to the Vedic tradition and silent on **inter-religious** pluralism.
Manusmriti (ii.14)	Contradictory revelations are all valid and must be respected.
Hindu "fusion"	Brahmanical carriers spread east and south through **give-and-take** (Chakrabarti). **McKim Marriott**: **parochialization** (the downward spread of Great Sanskritic Tradition elements) and **universalization** (the upward rise of Little/folk tradition elements). Diversity remained resilient.
Brahmanical tolerance	Each group's right to its own way of life (***svadharma; adhikara bheda***), but **not** equal merit. Hinduism tolerates difference by **incorporating and hierarchizing** it (Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism seen as inferior varieties of Hinduism). Conflict was not absent (persecution of Buddhists and Jains; Shaiva–Vaishnava conflict).
Ramakrishna (1836–86)	Practised Islam for a time and disregarded sectarian differences.
Vivekananda (1863–1902)	Tolerance, not equal acceptance: **Vedanta** above all creeds, "the mother of all religions"; critical of Buddhism and Christianity. "Neo-Hinduism" was a **reversal** of traditional internal pluralism, with political implications (nationalism; Hinduism as a universal religion).
Arya Samaj (Dayananda, 1824–83)	Founded in Bombay (1870s; Madan gives 1874). Rejected post-Vedic Hinduism (idol worship, caste and gender discrimination) and denied that Christianity and Islam were divinely inspired. An **exclusivist** strand that anticipates **Hindutva**.

Mahatma Gandhi (1869–1948)	The most explicit pluralism: on **30 May 1913**, "the world as a whole will never have, *and need not have* a single religion". All religions are equally true and equally imperfect; he refused to rank them. In *Young India* (1920) he credited the Jain **anekantavada**: "It is this doctrine that taught me to judge a Mussalman from his own standpoint and a Christian from his."
Islam	Since the Quran is held to be the most perfect revelation, pluralism must honour that, but it has a basis: "To you your religion and to me mine" (109.3). **Dara Shikoh** (17th c.) translated Upanishads into Persian and called Vedanta and Islam "twin brothers", and was executed by Aurangzeb. **Abul Kalam Azad** (1888–1958): Allah is God of all creation, so all humanity is one; the ulama objected and the work stayed unfinished.
Sikhism	Nanak's **sant** path transcends Hindu and Muslim identities, but the **Khalsa** (Gobind Singh) tightened identity: **exclusivist, not pluralist**.
Christianity	Ecumenism; Raimundo **Panikkar** (exclusivist → inclusivist); a theo-centric rather than Christo-centric idea of salvation.

State pluralism: *sarva dharma samabhava*

"Equal respect for all religions", presented as **Indian secularism** (vs Western separation). Madan: it "does not go very far"; real pluralism must be built by **people of faith**, not as passive tolerance. Gandhi: the secular state should **leave religion to the people**.

Two pluralisms

Folk (people's) pluralism is **spontaneous**, lived social reality: ordinary Indians acknowledge difference as experienced fact, and "social harmony is built on the basis of difference". **Intellectual or secular pluralism** is **ideological, self-conscious and sceptical** of religion. 19th-century elites dismissed folk pluralism as ignorance. **There is a "hiatus" between the two.**

Connect to the model answer (doctrine vs lived religion): Madan's folk pluralism, Marriott's little traditions, Sufi shrines shared by Hindus and Muslims, Mapilla customs, and the gap between Brahmanical texts and village practice are all **lived religion**. The census of 1871 and the scripture-based Judeo-Christian model are **doctrine-centred** lenses that hardened identities.

10.3 From Madan to the Indian Ocean: religion on the move MUST KNOW

From "diffusion" to "circulation"

- **Traditional model:** India → Southeast Asia (one-way "Indianization").
- **Dynamic model: India ↔ Sri Lanka ↔ Southeast Asia ↔ China**.
- **Agents:** merchants, monks and teachers, pilgrims, rulers. **Media:** ships, texts, images, temples and monasteries, merchant guilds.
- **"Religion travelled because people travelled; what travelled was transformed in the process."**
- The movement also ran **back toward India**; Islam spread to Southeast Asia along the same routes.

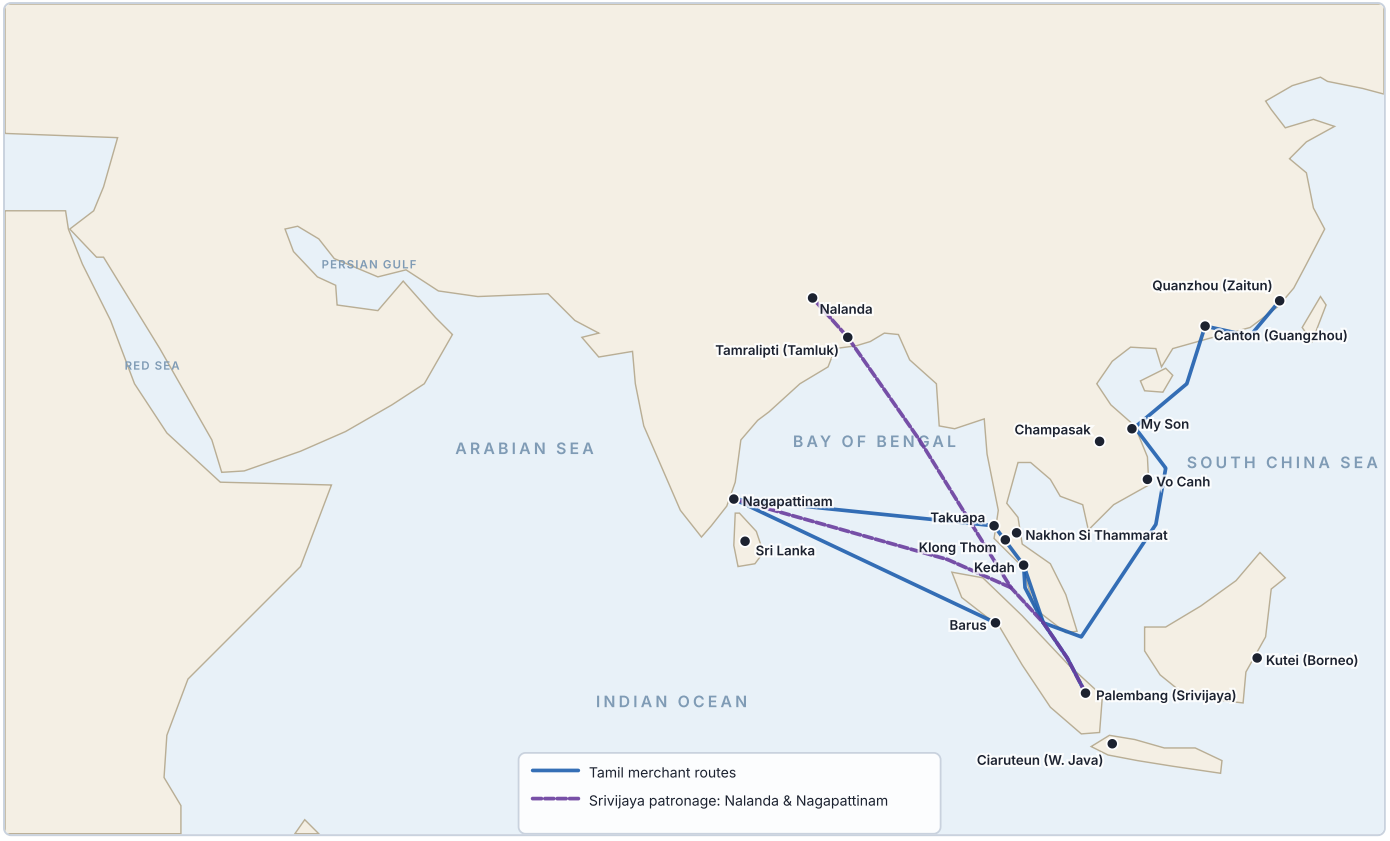
Who carried religion? Not one agent but several

- **Merchants** created mobility.
- **Brahmans** brought ritual and kingship.
- **Buddhist monks and teachers** brought monasteries, teachings and pilgrimage.
- **Rulers** gave patronage and appropriated religion politically.
- **Artisans** made images and material culture.

"Commercial mobility created conditions within which religious mobility became possible." The sequence: **merchant → settlement → community → religious presence**; resident communities allowed practices to become **institutionalised**.

RELIGIOUS ENCOUNTERS: POROUS BOUNDARIES

Hindu ↔ Buddhist ↔ Jain ↔ Islamic ↔ Christian interaction can produce **borrowing, adaptation, shared vocabulary, shared sacred spaces, new institutions and new identities**. Lecture images: a temple in **Bali**; the ***Ramakien*** (the Thai Ramayana); Thai religious practice; **Mendut temple** in Java; Buddhist Tantra from Odisha to Tibet. **Encounter does not necessarily mean conversion**: traditions may coexist, compete, borrow, adapt and influence art and politics. The Indian Ocean was a **cultural space**: the sea **connected** South India, Sri Lanka, the Bay of Bengal, Southeast Asia and South China, carrying goods, people, ideas, institutions and rituals. Ports were where merchants settled and religious specialists met.



Inscriptions and sacred sites of the Hindu–Buddhist maritime world (Guy; H.P. Ray). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

10.4 John Guy: Tamil merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist diaspora MUST KNOW

GUY'S ARGUMENT

It is generally accepted that Hindu-Buddhist beliefs spread in first-millennium Southeast Asia largely through **local rulers' initiatives** to recruit **Brahman priests and Buddhist monks** to secure their political and personal welfare. Yet the **medium** of transmission was the **merchant vessels** of the Indian Ocean diaspora. So **early traces of Indian (mostly Tamil) merchant activity** (inscriptions and religious imagery) reveal the early entry of Indic religion into Southeast Asian states. **Tamils were dominant** among the earliest Indian traders in insular Southeast Asia, supported by successive south Indian kingdoms. The distribution of inscriptions **mirrors the trade routes and commercial nodes**: coastal sites on rivers, giving access to hinterland riches.

Earliest Indic inscriptions and kingship (4th–7th centuries)

Site / evidence	What it shows

Kutei (east Borneo), late 4th c.	**Seven *yupa* steles** of King **Mulavarman**, in Sanskrit, box-head **Grantha** script: the **earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia**. They record **Vedic animal sacrifice and gift-giving by Brahmans** for the king, so Indian Brahmans were present in a "court context" from the very start. (*Yupa* = sacrificial post, normally wooden; only about four stone ones are known in north India, two from Kushan Mathura.) Kutei grew from a fiefdom into an "Indic" kingdom through Indian merchants seeking Borneo's riches; it may also have been a **production centre** for bronze images for Java (McKinnon's scrap finds; the **Intan** and **Cirebon** shipwreck cargoes).
Purnavarman, West Java, c.450	Rock inscription at **Ciaruteun** (near Bogor): king of **Tarumanagara**, **devotee of Vishnu**, Sanskrit in cursive **Tamil Grantha**; the name ending "-varman" is a **Pallava** convention. It shows a **Vishnupada** (sacred footprint), the **earliest *pada* in Southeast Asia**. The footprints are **both the king's and Vishnu's**: the first Southeast Asian ruler **personally identifying with an Indic god**, "the language of the Puranas, invoked by a new convert to the concept of Indian kingship". The threatening tone ("capable of destroying his enemies") is like the **"curse inscriptions"**, e.g. the **Telaga Batu** naga-stele (Palembang, late 7th c.: subjects "drink the curse"), with **Tantric** overtones.
Vo Canh stele (near Nha Trang, Vietnam)	The earliest mainland Sanskrit inscription (cruder Sanskrit), in Cham territory, signalling trading states on the India–China route
My Son (Champa), c.400	Three inscriptions of **Bhadravarman I** ("Dharmamaharaja"): sacrifices to **Shiva as Bhadresvara**
Champasak (Laos), mid-5th c.	**Devanika** inscription: the earliest **Chenla/Khmer** Sanskrit record, on a tripartite pillar, i.e. the **earliest inscribed linga** in Southeast Asia

THE KEY INTERPRETIVE POINT (LECTURE)

India was not simply "copied". Indic symbols were **appropriated and reworked locally**: **Indic vocabulary + local political context = a new cultural formation**. Purnavarman used Vishnu to boost **his own** kingship. Brahmanical ritual came to be associated with **kingship and statecraft**, while **Buddhism was more linked to commerce** (Guy).

"Lands of gold": Tamil merchants, gold and religion

- Indian merchants were drawn by spices, resins, forest products and especially **gold**, and because Southeast Asia was the **gateway to China**. The *Silappadikaram* mentions Chinese silk at **Pompuhar**. Buddhist **Jatakas** call the region ***Suvarnadvipa*** ("Island of Gold") and ***Suvarnabhumi*** ("Land of Gold").
- **Wat Klong Thom** (Krabi, peninsular Thailand): a **goldsmith's touchstone** with the **earliest Tamil inscription in Southeast Asia** (**Tamil Brahmi**, 3rd–4th c.), belonging to a Tamil calling himself **"Perumpatan"** ("the great goldsmith"). Excavations at **Khao Sam Kheo** show settlements that **processed** gold and glass, going beyond mere trading.
- **Takuapa** (west coast of the Thai peninsula), early 9th c.: three large **Pallava-style Hindu sculptures** (the main figure over 2 m tall, made under Brahmanical direction) and a **Tamil inscription** on a new **tank** ("Sri Avani-naranam"), linked by Nilakanta Sastri to the Pallava king **Nandivarman III** (r. 826–50). A tank implies an existing temple. The work was done by **three merchant guilds**, including the ***manigramattar*** (most active 9th–14th c.) and the ***sena mugattar*** (perhaps guild **militia**, known from Javanese inscriptions). Traces of processed **gold** are found in the soil.
- **"Takola"**: a place of riches in Suvarnadvipa named in the Buddhist *Mahaniddesa* (3rd c. CE), perhaps Takuapa, confirming continuous Tamil activity. Interestingly, the **earliest reference is Buddhist** but the later archaeology is mostly **Hindu**, as also in the **Bujang valley** (Kedah).
- **Lobu Tua, Barus** (west Sumatra, rich in camphor, benzoin and gold), dated **1088**: a Tamil inscription of the ***ainnurruvar*** ("the Five Hundred") guild, whose members set up a charitable fund, enforced by withdrawing **trading rights** ("to step on the spread cloth") from those who failed to pay the fee in gold. Other Tamil inscriptions come from Aceh and an inland Minangkabau site, showing Tamils settled even in the **hinterland**.
- **Nakhon Si Thammarat:** a 7th-c. Sanskrit Buddhist inscription (Wat Mahaeyong); the **Chong Koi** rock inscription on a community of **Shaivite Brahmans**, urged to perform rituals correctly and **live harmoniously with their host community**.

- **Bujang valley (Kedah):** two Buddhist steles (stupa engravings with the Buddhist creed, Grantha script, c.450–500). One names **"the great sea-captain Buddhagupta, a resident of Raktamrittika"** ("Red Earth", Malay *Tanah Merah*), praying that he and his fellow travellers be successful in their voyage. It was found by Col. James Low in the 1840s. Hindu shrines, late Tang Chinese ceramics and Islamic glass were also found there.
- **Belitung shipwreck** (early 9th c., Java Sea): an **Arab dhow** built of African hardwoods, active in the China–Persian Gulf trade; the **first Arab dhow found in Southeast Asian waters**. (Links to Session 7.)
- Early **stupas** at Sri Ksetra, Nakhon Pathom and Beikthano (Pyu sites).

The Tamil presence in China and the Chola era MUST KNOW

510	An "Indian" trade mission to the Chinese court (Tang annals)
750	The monk **Kanshin** at **Guangzhou**: ships of the **Bolomen** (Indians), **Posi** (Persians) and **Kunlun** (Malays), and **"three monasteries of the Bolomen where Brahmans reside"**, alongside Buddhist shrines and mosques
984–88	An Indian monk buys land in **Quanzhou** for a Buddhist shrine (Zhao Rugua's *Zhufanzhi*). Song China gave foreign quarters (*fanfang*) with a **shahbandar** (harbourmaster) as legal intermediary
1015	**Rajendra Chola** (1012–44) sends the first Chola mission to China (missions continued irregularly to the late 13th c.)
1026, 1068	**Chola raids on Srivijaya**, probably because Chola and Srivijayan missions **competed** for the China trade
1079	**Canton inscription**: "Sanfoqi" (Srivijaya) funds the renovation of Buddhist temples in Guangzhou (perhaps under Chola influence)
1258/1265	Wat Boroma That (Nakhon Si Thammarat): a Tamil inscription (translated by **Noboru Karashima**) on a donation by Danma Senapati to a Hindu temple; late-Chola temple fragments are found nearby. A Chola-period lion balustrade comes from **Lembah Bujang**.
1267	The **"Chinese pagoda" at Nagapattinam**, built (according to **Wang Dayuan**) to encourage Chinese merchants' visits; a Chinese place of worship had existed since the Pallava **Narasimhavarman II**
1281	**Quanzhou**: a **bilingual Tamil–Chinese inscription** (five Tamil lines, one Chinese) dedicating a **Shiva** temple; the donor is **Sambandha Perumal**, perhaps from Kumbakonam

Quanzhou's lost Hindu temples

- Remains were found in **1940** when the Ming city wall was demolished (temple stones had been used as filler).
- Two **late-Chola-style pillars** and basement reliefs (lotus and lion mouldings) were reused in the Ming renovation of the **Kaiyuan** (Buddhist) temple: **"a remarkable instance of cultural syncretism"**.
- The reliefs show **Vishnu** (with Sri Devi and Bhu Devi; as **Narasimha**; young Krishna subduing the naga **Kaliya**) and Shiva as a mendicant; one scene shows an elephant worshipping a linga. These are **localised Tamil myths** from the **Kaveri** region.
- The carving was done by **Chinese-trained stonemasons** directed by a **Tamil *sthapati*** (architect) recruited by the merchant community.
- Quanzhou is **"a final and spectacular manifestation of a long process"** of Tamil presence from Coromandel and Malabar to Southeast Asia and China.

Purnavarman, Balaputradeva, Atisa (lecture case studies)

- **Trade routes become religious routes:** Tamil coast → Thai peninsula → Malay peninsula → Sumatra and Java → China (evidence: Klong Thom, the Vishnupada, Indic royal titles).
- **Balaputradeva**, lord of **Suvarnadvipa (Sumatra)**, founded a monastery at **Nalanda**; the **Pala king Devapala** (c.810–847) granted **five villages** to support it (the Nalanda copper plate, found 1921). **Southeast Asian rulers patronised institutions in India**; India provided learning.
- **Atisa Dipankara** (982–1054): Bengal (born in Vikrampur near Dhaka) → **Suvarnadvipa** (studied with Dharmakirti, 1012–24, travelling **on a merchant ship** with students) → Vikramashila → **Tibet** (1040/1042), "the father of Tibetan Buddhism". **The same ship carried commodities and religious knowledge.**

10.5 H. P. Ray: Nagapattinam, a multi-religious maritime landscape MUST KNOW

RAY'S ARGUMENT

Indian maritime history has usually been treated as **trade driven by foreign (Western) demand** for "oriental" luxuries, while historians **marginalised maritime communities**, studying ancient India through **agrarian expansion** and **caste** (assumed to forbid sea travel). Ray focuses instead on **maritime cultural landscapes**: the coast, its communities and their religious environment. She places the Buddhist complex at Nagapattinam on the east coast (**127 contemporary Buddhist sites** on the Tamil coast, plus the Bengal, Orissa and Andhra coasts), **challenging Alexander Cunningham's theory** (Cunningham was the first Director-General of the ASI) that **Buddhism declined in India around the 7th–8th century**. She also rejects explaining the 8th–13th centuries only through **"Indian feudalism"** (R. S. Sharma) or trade and politics. The sacred landscape was **multi-religious**, not a **sequence** of "Buddhism, then Hinduism".

Nagapattinam: the port and the vihara

- Settled since the Neolithic. It has a **16th-c. dargah** (Nagore, the saint **Shahul Hamid**) and, 10 km away, the **17th-c. basilica of Our Lady of Good Health at Velankanni**. The 7th-c. Tamil saints **Appar and Sambandar** (31 couplets) describe a fortified, prosperous city where large ships called ***vangam*** anchored for Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.
- Chinese records of the **1060s–70s** mention missions from the **Cholas** and from **Srivijaya**; Jambi sent missions to China in 852 and 871.
- **Cudamanivihara** (Chulamanivarma-vihara): founded at the initiative of the **kings of Srivijaya** (around 1005); construction began under **Rajaraja I** (985–1016) and was completed under **Rajendra I** (1012–44). The **Larger Leyden Plates** (Sanskrit, 111 lines, plus Tamil, 332 lines): in his 21st regnal year Rajaraja gave the village of **Annaimangalam** to the shrine that **Mara Vijayottungavarman** of the **Sailendra** family, ruler of Srivijaya and **Kataha** (Kedah), had built in his father's name, "towering above Mount Meru". The **Smaller Leyden Plates** (Tamil) list **nine units of land**.
- The **1467 Kalyani inscription** of the Burmese king **Dhammaceti**: shipwrecked Burmese monks worshipped at Nagapattinam.

The "Chinese Pagoda" and its destruction

- **Wouter Schouten** (Dutch, 1660s) called a brick tower the **"Chinese Pagoda"** (repeated by Valentyn, 1724).
- **Sir Walter Elliot** (1846, on the steamer *Hugh Lindsay*): "a four-sided tower of three stories constructed of bricks closely fitted together without cement".
- Despite local objections, the Governor-in-Council approved its **demolition (28 Aug 1867)** by **French Jesuits** expelled from Pondicherry, who wanted to build a college there.
- Finds: five bronze Buddhas in a concealed chamber; **350 Buddhist bronzes** (1856–1930s); the **Sellur hoard** (2004, 42–45 bronzes, 11th–13th c., including a votive stupa with scenes of the Buddha's life and a tiny Buddha inside).

Hybrid Buddhism: what the bronzes and inscriptions show

- The bronzes include **Buddha images and votive stupas**, and also **Avalokitesvara, Maitreya, Lokesvara, Jambhala, Vasudhara and Tara**. Tamil pedestal inscriptions (11th–13th c.) record Buddha epithets and gifts by **monks, nuns and lay donors**.
- **Rockefeller Buddha** (69.2 cm): "for **festival procession**(s)" at the image-house of **Rajendracolapperumpalli**; installed by a monk; donor "the prefect of artisan manufactories for the merchants of the **eighteen countries**". So the

Buddha image was **treated like a Hindu deity** (processions, epithets of divinity like those of **Shiva and Vishnu**), showing **inter-religious communication**.

- Two monasteries: the Cudamanivihara and the Rajendracolapperumpalli. **Pauline Scheurleer:** some 9th-c. **Javanese** bronzes used **Nagapattinam** models.
- **Peter Schalk's three Buddhisms at Nagapattinam:** (1) bronze-pedestal Buddhism so **close to Shaivism** that the two are hard to tell apart; (2) **devotional** Buddhism mediated by the sage **Agastya** (in the 12th-c. ***Viracoliyam*** and its commentary); (3) the Buddhism of **acaryas** (teachers), which barely survives.
- **Woodward vs Davidson: Hiram Woodward** argues that a shared world of **Mantrayana and Yogini Tantras** made **Indonesia and India "an integral unit well into the ninth century"** (e.g. parallel Lalitavistara and *Gandavyuha* programmes at **Borobudur** and **Tabo**). This counters **Ronald Davidson**, who, following R. S. Sharma's **feudalism**, sees esoteric Buddhism as a **response to the feudalization** of Indian society (the yogin as overlord of a mandala of vassals).
- **Travel as Buddhist self-identity** (**Robert Buswell**): the ***Gandavyuha*** (part of the *Avatamsaka sutra*) tells of Prince **Sudhana**, sent by Manjusri to visit **53 "spiritual friends"** of all walks of life, so **enlightenment comes through pilgrimage**. It was popular in Indonesia, China and Japan, in an environment of trading guilds and merchant travel.

A multi-religious sacred geography

Hindu

The **Kayarohanaswami** (Shiva) temple (6th-c. origins, 11th-c. structure). The king of **Srivijaya** gave ornaments to its silver image **Nakaiyalakar**; his agent donated lamps; **Chinese gold coins** were given for worship of an **Ardhanarisvara** image installed by the king of **Kidar (Kedah)**.

Buddhist

The Cudamanivihara and Rajendracolapperumpalli; bronzes; monks and nuns; links to Srivijaya, Burma, China and Java.

Islamic, Christian, Jain

The **Nagore dargah** (Shahul Hamid), patronised by **maraikkayar** ship-owners, Nayak rulers and even the Dutch East India Company; the **Velankanni** basilica; inland at **Tiruchirappalli**, Jain ascetics' inscriptions (3rd–11th c.), rock-cut shrines and the 8th-c. **mosque of Abdullah ibn Muhammad**.

Textual complexity (Anne Monius on the *Viracoliyam*): Chola-era Tamil Shaiva and Vaishnava literature shows saints **defeating ignorant Buddhist monks** in debate (Cekkilar imagines Buddhism's end), yet **Pali** sources of the same period show south India as a **bastion of Buddhist orthopraxy**, with monks called "Coliya" or "Damila". **Recognise cultural complexity.**

Merchant guilds across the Bay of Bengal (9th–14th c.) MUST KNOW

- Guilds: the **Ainurruvar**, **Manigramam**, **Nanadesi** and **Anjuvannam** (the last associated with West Asian merchants), with associated craftsmen (weavers, potters and others). Inscriptions cluster in **Karnataka** (Dharwad–Bijapur, Mysore) and **Tamil Nadu** (Thanjavur, Tiruchirappalli, Madurai).
- They kept **private armies**, **donated to temples** (some named after them) and built tanks.
- Two kinds of assembly record: ***pattana-dharmam*** (Kannada) / *pagudi* (Tamil), "shared contribution" to temples (12th–14th c.), and ***erivira-pattinam***, towns where **merchants and soldiers** lived (11th–12th c. in Tamil Nadu), showing the **rising importance of armed guards**.

Tamil inscriptions abroad (Jan Wisseman Christie)

Eight mid-9th to late-13th-century Tamil inscriptions in Southeast and East Asia: **1** near Pagan (Burma); **2** south of the Isthmus of Kra; **4** in north and west Sumatra; **1** on the China coast (Quanzhou, bilingual). Earliest: **Takuapa** (9th c.: a tank and a military camp). Then a gap of about 2 centuries to **Lobo Tuwa/Barus, 1088** (a tax on ships' captains and crews); a 12th-c. north Sumatra inscription on trading rules. In the 10th c., local guilds called ***banigrama*** appear in **Java and Bali** (seven Javanese inscriptions, 902–1053), largely **indigenous** tax-farming organisations.

QUESTIONING THE CHOLA "NAVAL EXPEDITION"

The volume *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa* (Kulke, Kesavapany, Sakhuja, 2009) argues that Rajendra I's famous expedition against Srivijaya (1025) rests on a **single source**, the **eulogy** in Rajendra's own inscription, **uncorroborated by Chinese sources**. Contemporary sources instead show an **extensive Indian Ocean trading system** from the Tamil coast to China, the real context. (Session 2's source criticism: a royal eulogy is a biased source.) **Ray's conclusion:** stories of travel and pilgrimage lost centrality with "scientific" archaeology and **national histories**; socio-economic history stressed trade, towns and Brahmans legitimising kings. Maritime history should now study **multi-religious cultural landscapes across the oceans**, not the "sequential development" of Buddhism and Hinduism.

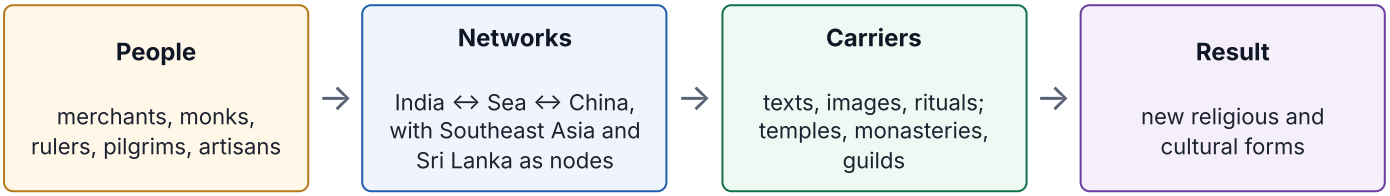
10.6 Synthesis: what does this tell us about religion? MUST KNOW

Nagapattinam: a religious crossroads (lecture)

- Buddhist images used **Shaiva + Vaishnava + Buddhist** visual and ritual vocabularies: **religion was adapted, not simply transplanted**.
- **One port, multiple religious worlds:** a Shiva temple, Vaishnava traditions, the Cudamanivihara, bronzes, monks and nuns; links to Srivijaya, China and Southeast Asia.
- **Hybridity does not mean traditions simply merged**; they borrowed, adapted and reinterpreted shared forms. A multi-religious geography **preceded and followed** the vihara.

The direction also reversed

- Srivijaya → Nagapattinam; Sumatra → Nalanda; Chinese gifts to Tamil temples; Southeast Asian rulers → Indian monasteries.
- **India was not simply the source**: its religious centres became **nodes in transregional networks**.
- Quanzhou's Tamil–Chinese inscription and Shiva temple. The readings do **not** show a simple China → India transmission. **Better formulation:** Chinese and Indian communities **participated in a shared maritime religious environment**.



OVERARCHING ARGUMENT (MEMORISE)

Premodern religion was **mobile, networked, adaptive, plural, reciprocal and open-ended**. Religion travelled with people; people travelled through commercial networks; networks created institutions; institutions created new cultural forms. **Indian religions became historically significant beyond the subcontinent not because they remained unchanged as they travelled, but because they could be carried, translated, appropriated and reinterpreted in different cultural environments**, producing new combinations of local and transregional elements.

Madan → religion as a **social and plural** phenomenon · **Guy** → transmission through **merchant and maritime networks** · **Ray** → religious exchange and **multi-religious cultural landscapes**.

SUMMARY OF SESSION 10

Madan: India's religions are plural **between** and **within** traditions; dharma ≠ religio; the 1991 census (82% Hindu, 12% Muslim…); Hinduism as a "federation of faiths" (Veda/shruti–smriti, Manu, darshanas, epics and Puranas, bhakti from the south, Shankara, Ramanuja and Madhva); Buddhism, Jainism (anekantavada, syadvada), Sikhism (Nanak; the Khalsa 1699 as exclusivist), Christianity (St Thomas → Xavier, de Nobili → CSI/CNI) and Islam (trade before conquest, Mapillas, Sufis vs ulama, Deoband and Aligarh, Ahmadiyah). **Plurality is not pluralism**: traditional pluralism was **hierarchical**; Vivekananda and the Arya Samaj were exclusivist turns; Gandhi was most pluralist; *sarva dharma samabhava* is weak; **folk vs intellectual pluralism**. The colonial **census from 1871** and the Judeo-Christian model **hardened identities**. **Guy:** Tamil merchants were the medium; inscriptions map the routes (Kutei yupas, Purnavarman's Vishnupada, Klong Thom "Perumpatan", Takuapa and the guilds, Barus 1088, Buddhagupta); Tamil temples in Guangzhou (750) and Quanzhou (1281, Kaiyuan pillars); Chola–Srivijaya rivalry. **Ray:** Nagapattinam's Cudamanivihara (Srivijaya and Chola patronage; Leyden plates), destroyed in 1867; hybrid bronzes ("eighteen countries"); Schalk's three Buddhisms; a multi-religious landscape; merchant guilds; Tamil inscriptions abroad; a challenge to Cunningham's decline thesis and to the sequential model.

EXAM CORNER

1. Distinguish religion as **doctrine** from religion as **lived practice**, with examples from India. (Professor's model answer: see the front matter.)
2. "Plurality is not pluralism." Discuss with reference to Madan.
3. How did colonial categories (the census, the Judeo-Christian model) reshape religious identity in India?
4. "Religion travelled because people travelled." Discuss with reference to Guy and Ray.
5. Using Nagapattinam, show how religion was "adapted, not simply transplanted".
6. From "diffusion" to "circulation": how have historians rethought the "spread" of Indian religions to Southeast Asia?

MCQ facts: Kutei yupas (Mulavarman, late 4th c.) = earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia; Purnavarman c.450 (Tarumanagara, Vishnupada); Klong Thom touchstone = earliest Tamil inscription (3rd–4th c.); Takuapa / Nandivarman III / manigramam; Barus 1088 (ainnurruvar); Kanshin 750 (three Brahman monasteries in Guangzhou); Chola mission to China 1015; Quanzhou Tamil–Chinese inscription 1281; Cudamanivihara: Rajaraja I and Rajendra I, built by Mara Vijayottungavarman (Leyden plates); demolished 1867; 127 Buddhist sites on the Tamil coast; Kalyani inscription 1467; Devapala's Nalanda grant to Balaputradeva; census from 1871; Khalsa 1699; Gandhi's pluralism statement 30 May 1913.

SESSION 11

History of the Indian Ocean as a Connected Space: Trade, Mobility, Empire, Ecology, Religion and Institutions

Readings: K. N. Chaudhuri, "The Unity and Disunity of Indian Ocean History from the Rise of Islam to 1750: The Outline of a Theory and Historical Discourse", *Journal of World History* 4:1 (1993), pp. 1–21 (OT7) · Tirthankar Roy, *India in the World Economy: From Antiquity to the Present* (CUP, 2012), ch. 4, "The Indian Ocean Trade, 1500–1800", pp. 78–112 (RB6) · Lecture 11 PPT

WHERE THIS FITS / WHY IT MATTERS

This is the **capstone** of the course. It pulls together the sea routes (Session 7), the Silk Roads and Buddhist networks (Sessions 8–9) and religion on the move (Session 10), and asks whether the Indian Ocean was **one connected historical space**. **Chaudhuri** answers at the level of **theory and the *longue durée*** (622–1750); **Roy** answers at the level of **trade, merchants, companies and ports** (1500–1800), ending with the **shift from trade to empire**. It also links to Session 3 (**global vs regional**, Wallerstein, Frank) and Session 2 (Braudel, **comparison**).

11.1 Part I: what does "connected space" mean? MUST KNOW

THE LECTURE'S DEFINITION

The Indian Ocean was **a connected space, not a collection of isolated regions**, linking **East Africa, the Middle East, South Asia, Southeast Asia and China**. **"Connection does not mean sameness; it means structured interaction across distance."**

Five forms of connection

1. **Routes**: maritime pathways structured by **wind, geography and custom**.
2. **Shared commercial practices**: common norms of trade, credit and exchange.
3. **Migration**: people settled, carrying skills, language and ties.
4. **Religious networks**: belief and pilgrimage linked distant regions.
5. **Political and military encounters**: conflict and diplomacy were **also forms of connection**, not its opposite.

Why the Indian Ocean matters in world history

- One of the **oldest and most important arenas** of interregional exchange.
- Long-distance trade **long before European empire**; it had its own deep history.
- Movement of goods, people, technologies, languages and religious ideas.
- Crucial to the histories of **Islam, India, Southeast Asia, China and East Africa**.
- **Helps decentre Europe**: European expansion is only one chapter.

Significant point: Indian Ocean history is **not a "prelude" to European expansion**; it has its own long historical logic.

Discussion question (lecture)

Was the Indian Ocean connected **mainly by trade**, or did trade itself depend on deeper connections like **climate (the monsoon), religion and migration**?

Answer sketch: both. The monsoon made trade possible and seasonal (Session 7); religious and diaspora networks gave trust and credit (Sessions 9–10); but trade paid for and spread those networks. Chaudhuri stresses deep structures; Roy stresses commerce.



Indian Ocean c.1500–1800: Asian hubs, Portuguese bases, English presidencies (T. Roy). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

11.2 Chaudhuri: unity and disunity of Indian Ocean history (1993) MUST KNOW

THE PROBLEM, IN SIMPLE WORDS

Fernand **Braudel**'s *The Mediterranean* (1949) wrote the history of a whole **sea** and its surrounding societies in three dimensions: **space, time and structures**. Chaudhuri (author of *Trade and Civilisation in the Indian Ocean*, 1985, and *Asia Before Europe*, 1990) asks: **can we do the same for the Indian Ocean?** Does it have **unity**? And why are there so few studies **comparing Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asia and China** before European colonialism? The sceptics' answer: the Indian Ocean has **no tangible unity**, there is no clear chronological coherence from the rise of Islam to the 18th century, and Asia is **"too complex and diverse"**, so they avoid the question ("the problem is resolved by denying its existence").

(a) Unity "in the large" vs similarity "in the small"

- Borrowing from mathematics and **Wittgenstein**: the question is about similarity **"in the large"** (the overall form) vs **"in the small"** (local details). **Example: a Möbius strip, a cylinder and a twisted cylinder** look identical if you cut out a small square of any of them (alike "in the small"), but their overall shapes differ (the Möbius strip has only one side and one edge). So **matching small details do not prove a shared overall form, and differing details do not disprove it**.
- If you compare the **Rig Veda, the Confucian texts and the Qur'an word for word**, you find dissimilarities "in the small". But **Arab sailors could sail from Suez and Basra to Guangzhou and Japan**: at the level of **transcontinental trade** there was an intrinsic unity, a similarity "in the large" with Braudel's Mediterranean.
- **Lecture formula: "Unity in the large, disunity in the small."** The Indian Ocean can be a meaningful historical unit **without being uniform**: unity at the level of space, time and structures (shared routes, long-distance trade, recurring political patterns), always alongside **internal differentiation** (food, clothing, housing, authority and religion varied enormously).

Why so few intra-Asian comparisons? A historical reason

In the past, Asian writers were curious about their neighbours' civilisations. In the **19th century**, with Europe's military and scientific power, Asian historians began to measure their own histories **against Europe**. Intellectual orientation changed from a **latitudinal** (east–west, Asia-to-Asia) direction to a **longitudinal** axis (Asia-to-Europe). Today most Asian historians relate their regions to **European categories like feudalism and capitalism**.

Compare **Session 4** (Marxist and colonial frameworks applied to India) and **Session 3** (Eurocentrism).

(b) The problem of chronology: Arasaratnam's critique

S. Arasaratnam argued that Chaudhuri showed a **geographic** unity but failed to show a **chronological** unity "for the period **A.D. 750 to 1750**". Chaudhuri notes the "unconscious slip": his period begins with the **rise of Islam, i.e. 622, not 750**. The deeper point is a **contradiction**: a South Asian historian sees **spatial** unity but South Asian periodisation does not fit an Indian Ocean chronology, while historians of Islam see a clear **temporal** unity (622 to the 18th c.) but deny that Asia is a unit of space (the *Balad al-Islam* was a concept, not contiguous territory). **Unity of space and unity of time may not coincide.** Such contradictions are built into real structures (e.g. a bumper harvest lowers prices, which can ruin peasants who must sell for cash).

(c) Chaudhuri's theory: six domains, four strands, four conclusions

Six domains + logical space

Historical action is an interaction between: **(1) real space, (2) perceived space, (3) real time, (4) perceived time, (5) physical structures, (6) perceived structures**. A **seventh** domain, the perception of the other six, is the **"logical space" of history**.

Braudel himself said (1985): "For me, a structural phenomenon is a phenomenon that **persists**", nothing to do with Lévi-Strauss's structuralism. Chaudhuri goes further: he wants to **identify** structures and the principles that **classify, group and divide** them. Critics (e.g. Gordon Johnson called him a "latter-day Dr Faustus" drawing randomly on all learning) found it incoherent; Chaudhuri replies that the theory is rigorous, and that a cabinetmaker still needs a saw and chisel.

Four strands of theory

1. **Braudel**'s social, economic and civilisational history and intuitive interpretation (the *longue durée*).
2. **Structuralism** (mainly French social philosophers: Lévi-Strauss, Foucault, Barthes, Bourdieu…).
3. **Semiotics** (analysis of signs).
4. **Mathematical set theory** (Cantor) to establish continuities and discontinuities.

Conclusion	Meaning, in simple words
1. Structural **invariance**	A basic underlying structure, the **"ground floor of material life"** (food, clothing, housing, religious principles, technology, production), stayed **invariant** while varying within limits. (Roman **Jakobson**: the search for "invariance amid variations".) A distinction is made between **structural change** and **changes inside a structure**. **Analogy:** stomach-lining cells are replaced every few days, but the stomach's function stays the same.
2. Unity as the sum of **four civilisations**	The Indian Ocean's structural unity is the sum of four civilisational identities: **Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asian societies and Confucian China**. Set theory (integration and differentiation, **cardinality**, the property that identifies a set) marks their boundaries and filters the invariant core. "Islam" is a set whose members may also belong to African, Indian, Javanese or Chinese sets.
3. **Totality** and binary action	Political authority, social forms, economic activity and art form a **totality** with an indivisible logical space. But **action** is a **binary** decision (to act or not), a simple "thermostatic" function. Economic or political action can be separated from the totality only through a **theoretical filter**.
4. Dynamics and **"perpetual memory"**	The interaction of the **long term and the random**, of events and tendencies (e.g. Islam changing from an Arab identity into a complex structure with Iranian and Turkish elements). Societies replicate their structures through a **"perpetual memory"** (like genetic coding), studied with topological transformation. **Dali's** painting *The Persistence of Memory*: even if a watch seems to melt, as long as the dial and hands are intact, **time can still be read**.

(d) The "ground floor" of material life: food, clothing, housing MUST KNOW

Food

- Every society distinguishes **"food" vs "non-food"** (a universal syntax), but the elements differ; there are separations in **space** (Islam vs China) and **time** (breakfast food; **famine food**; ascetic, sacred, festive and everyday food mark sacred and profane, rich and poor).
- Two zones: **bread (wheat) vs rice**. To be invited to a meal = to eat bread or rice. Not symmetrical: in the Middle East people ate both (rice as a luxury), while rice-eaters rejected bread. **Dairy** disappears in Southeast Asia and China.
- **Invariance:** dishes in the Qur'anic tradition, cookbooks and Javanese inscriptions are still cooked today. Porridge of boiled grain fed farmers from **Egypt to China**.
- **Change:** new plants with early Islam; New World crops (**maize, tobacco, potatoes, tomatoes, chilli**); **hot food may date only from the 16th-c. chilli** (before that, black pepper gave pungency).
- Food maps onto social life, but **not isomorphically** (taste is habit).

Clothing

- Clothing maps onto social identity **almost one-to-one** (isomorphic): tiny variations signal gender exactly.
- Generic distinctions: **unsewn, semi-sewn and fully sewn** garments.
- The white unsewn ***ihram*** of Muslim pilgrims on the hajj is **structurally isomorphic** to the ritual dress of **Brahmans** at worship: different forms, same ritual meaning. (Ordinary Islamic dress is fully sewn.)

Housing

- In all societies **a house is a three-dimensional projection of the human body**, replicating **power relations** within the family and between civic authority and families (e.g. planning laws).
- **Arid zone** (west and north): brick or stone houses, grain farming, semi-fortified villages, a tendency to **political fragmentation**.
- **Wet zone** (east and south): **bamboo and wooden** houses, sloping roofs, banana and coconut, **rice fields and fish ponds**; intensive, vulnerable irrigation gave a "terrible power of **coercion**" to military rulers.

Desert and sown: nomads and settled farmers

Agriculture needed draft animals (**camels** in the Middle East, **oxen and buffalo** in India, Southeast Asia and China), often supplied by **nomads** raising stock on marginal land (paradoxically, the drier the climate, the better the cattle). Desert and sown were held in **symbiosis**: nomads needed grain, dates, sugar, coffee, tea and cloth, but could also **exact them as tribute** by force; their monopoly of transport animals let them **protect caravans** and promote urbanisation. Settled societies faced a chronic **threat of nomadic conquest**.

Four expansionary movements (618–1757)

From the founding of the **Tang dynasty (618)** to the **Battle of Plassey (1757)**:

1. the outward projection of **Islam**;
2. the projection of **imperial China**;
3. the migrations of **Turko-Mongol nomads** into the Middle East, China and India;
4. the **maritime expansion of Christian Europe**.

618 / 622 — Tang China founded; Islamic community (umma) founded: the **two thresholds** and the start of a "double phase" of expansion and decline to the 11th c.

Abbasid & Song — Abbasid mastery of space from the Mediterranean to the eastern Indian Ocean (new cities as instruments of control); Song unification and urban growth

12th–14th c. — **Turko-Mongol** expansion, plus "random" disasters (famines, failed rains, the **Black Death c.1345–49**): instability, seen as a "failure at the very foundation of society"

15th–17th c. New **military-bureaucratic empires**, the **Ming, Ottomans, Safavids and Mughals**, recreate an *ancien régime* by assimilating nomadic elements. The Manchu conquest of the Ming (mid-17th c.) was "the last nomadic gesture on a grand scale"; Nadir Shah (18th c.) was a late tribal response

1500–1800 European maritime expansion adds an "extraneous dimension"; **Plassey (1757)** marks the final dynamics: the **symbolic demise** of the life cycle and the foundation of European domination

(e) Time, theory and "unity as a mental construct" SUPPORTING

- **Temporal frequency: the lower the frequency of events, the higher their explanatory power**, and vice versa. The founding of the Islamic umma is a rare event with huge influence; the number of meals a person eats is huge but explains almost nothing (to study meals structurally, we assume food habits stay stationary).
- **Foucault:** three domains of action, one real (**primary relations**) and two **mental constructs** (reflexive and discursive). He was concerned with **discontinuities**; historians compulsively seek continuity.
- **Gödel** (the "Undecidable Theorem", 1931): human language and logic contain **inherent contradictions**, so there is no single self-consistent truth. Therefore **the spatial unity of the Indian Ocean and the chronological unity of 622–1750 are not objective truths but mental constructs**. For some analyses treat the ocean as one unit; for others break it up. The same applies to chronology. **"Historians create the unity of their subject."**
- **"Asia is the contradiction of Europe":** the sign "Asia" has no positive content without reference to "Europe" (*Asia Before Europe* = not-Europe, before colonialism). Likewise, **the sea is the antithesis of the desert and the land mass**, so by dialectical exclusion both belong to one set, "the Indian Ocean".
- **Why 622–1750 works:** it is a whole **life cycle**, from the start of two great expansions to their symbolic end at Plassey. Ask people in the Middle East, India, Java or China what Islam, Chinese civilisation and colonialism meant to them. Even Sanskritic Indians learned to call themselves "**Hindus**" through contact with Muslims; "if Charlemagne is inconceivable without Muhammad", post-1947 South Asia is inconceivable without the umma.
- **Mathematicians: Cantor** (set theory, the arithmetic continuum), **Wittgenstein** (logical space, language games; "what cannot be said must be passed over in silence"), **Dedekind** (1872: continuity is defined by a **"cut"**, i.e. a limit; so the "present" is an irrational concept, since everything perceived is past or future), Russell and Gödel. Their key ideas: **mapping** (projecting one set's structure onto another) and **isomorphism** (exact one-to-one correspondence). **Continuity and discontinuity, unity and disunity, depend on how we define limits.**

BACKGROUND **HOW MUCH THEORY DO YOU NEED?**

For the exam, know the **argument** (unity in the large and disunity in the small; four civilisations; the ground floor of material life; the *longue durée* 622–1750; unity as a constructed analytical frame) and **2–3 named examples** (Möbius strip; bread vs rice; *ihram* ≅ Brahman dress; house = body; Dali's watches; Arasaratnam's 750 vs 622). The mathematical detail (Dedekind cuts, transfinite numbers) is background; name-drop it at most.

CHAUDHURI IN ONE PARAGRAPH (FOR ANSWERS)

Inspired by **Braudel**, Chaudhuri argues that the Indian Ocean from the **rise of Islam (622)** to **Plassey (1757)** can be studied as one historical space, showing **unity "in the large"** (transcontinental trade, shared routes, a common "ground floor" of material life, four expansionary movements) alongside **disunity "in the small"** (four civilisations: Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asia, Confucian China; bread vs rice zones; arid vs wet ecologies). Using **structuralism, semiotics and set theory**, he shows that structures like food, dress and housing stayed **invariant** over the *longue durée*. He accepts (via **Gödel and Foucault**) that such unity is ultimately a **mental construct** chosen by the historian, which is why scale and periodisation must fit the question.

11.3 Roy: the Indian Ocean trade, 1500–1800 MUST KNOW

ROY'S ARGUMENT

Indo-European trade laid the foundation of a **new economic order** in Asia and Europe: it created new **consumer markets** in Europe, shaped the world's **money markets** (silver), motivated **colonisation** in the 18th century, and transmitted **technology in both directions**. There was so much two-way traffic that it cannot be described as simple "European influence" or Indian "incorporation" into a European world economy (contrast **Wallerstein**, Session 3). The **hybrid technological, institutional and political order** that followed had momentous consequences for India.

(a) The Indian Ocean world at 1500: India at the centre of the "great arc"

- India sat in the middle of the **"great arc" of Asian trade** (Om Prakash's phrase): a **hinge** between the western and eastern circuits. No single merchant group usually connected the extremities; direct West Asia–China trade, always rare, **declined after 1400**, so **Indian ports grew** as places to change ships and restock, linking Aden, Hormuz and Kilwa with Malacca.
- Indian ports were **transit points, markets and production centres**. **Exports:** textiles (silk, muslin), rice, sugar, oil, cotton, indigo. **Imports:** gold and silver, consumer goods, **horses**, and spices for re-export (Indonesia → Cambay → West Asia → Europe).
- **Route to Europe:** Cambay or Calicut → **Aden** (Red Sea) or **Hormuz** (Gulf) → Arabs to **Suez/Tor**, then caravans to **Cairo/Alexandria**; or Persians to **Basra**, then caravans to **Aleppo/Tripoli** → **Venetians** (plus Turks, Ragusans, Armenians and Greeks). Southern Europeans even considered digging a **Suez Canal c.1500**.

Merchant communities and ports

- **Cambay: Gujarati Muslims** (who expanded in the 15th c. after Arab–China trade stopped, settling in Malacca and Aden).
- **Malabar: Mapilla Muslims**.
- **Coromandel: Chulia** merchants and **Telugu Chettis** (Balija and Komati); the main port was **Pulicat** (linked to Vijayanagar).
- **East:** Oriyas and Bengalis; **Saptagram** and **Chittagong** traded with Burma, Indonesia and China.
- Each combined trade with **shipbuilding**, credit and mobility.
- **No port was firmly tied to an inland empire**: the **Samudri (Zamorin)** of Calicut, Cambay's king, Konkan chiefs. Merchants **adapted** to pan-regional forces rather than controlling them.
- **Two new hubs: Masulipatnam** (Qutb Shahi Golkonda; Persian merchants; Krishna delta) and **Surat** (sacked by the Portuguese in 1530; vital after the **Mughal annexation of Gujarat in 1576**).

LECTURE: "EUROPEANS ENTERED A CROWDED AND FUNCTIONING COMMERCIAL WORLD, NOT AN EMPTY STAGE."

Key ports were **Calicut, Cambay, Surat, Malacca, Aden and Hormuz**. Ports were **interfaces** connecting sea, land and political authority, and cargo passed through many merchant groups.

(b) The Portuguese: entry, violence and limits MUST KNOW

14 Aug 1415 — **Ceuta** (north-west Africa) falls to a Portuguese force of 45,000, "more religious than economic" in intent but a commercial key. Portugal was one of Europe's **poorest nations**, with strong navigation skills, royal patronage, a poor nobility and high mortality. Short hops with settlements at each stage: Tangier, Madeira, Cape Verde, Guinea, Senegal, Ghana (1415–80)

1480s — An overland journey to **Sofala** (Mozambique); **Bartholomew Diaz** rounds the Cape of Good Hope

May 1498 — **Vasco da Gama** (chosen more for political skill; the mission was partly **diplomatic**, not a crusade; ships of only 200–250 tons) reaches **Calicut**, guided by a **Gujarati pilot** picked up at Mombasa (Malindi in other accounts). Trade fails ("resistance of Muslim merchants"), but he returns with spices and, more valuable, **navigational knowledge**

1502–03 Da Gama's **second voyage** sets the pattern: treaties, but also the **bombardment of Calicut** and the **massacre of passengers on a ship bound for Mecca**

1503 → **Afonso de Albuquerque**: aims at **dominions**, not diplomacy. Within about a decade: **Goa** and Ceylon settled; Cochin and Cannanore friendly; **Malacca and Hormuz** made treaty ports; a Mamluk fleet (backed by Venetians) routed at **Diu** (1509); Aden held out

1500s The **Casa da India** (Crown trading firm) holds the Cape-route monopoly; the **Estado da India** (Goa) issues **passes** (the *cartaz*) for a fee and forces customs at Portuguese ports; protection money is extorted. A ring of forts: Malacca, Nagasaki, Macau, Goa, Diu, Cochin (with Spain in Manila)

1560s → Pepper slips through to the Venetians; the Levant route revives; the Crown farms out authority to private traders (New Christians, *casados*); Lisbon departures fall from 4,000–5,000 tons a year (1500–1600) to **<2,000 tons by 1650**

After 1640 **Decline**: the Portuguese empire shrinks to an impoverished Goa

Why so violent? And why did it fail?

- To oust **Muslim merchants** from the Malabar and Sumatra spice trade, **violence** was "a necessary weapon"; a **crusading impulse** made it worse. It worked at first: European **pepper prices stabilised**, profits ran at perhaps several hundred per cent, and Lisbon became an entrepôt (wholesale trade went on to **Antwerp**). Dutch resentment of dependence on Portugal motivated the **VOC (1602)**.
- **Debate on failure:** (1) **Niels Steensgaard**: the enterprise was **"redistributive" and "pre-capitalist"**, living off others' profits (protection money) instead of making its own trade profitable; (2) others (**Pearson, Subrahmanyam**): **external** factors, the resistance of **strong territorial states** (Mughals, Ottomans, Japanese, Persians).

Bengal: Sebastião Gonzales

Portuguese private traders, mercenaries, artillerymen and shipwrights were in Bengal (Hooghly, Sandwip); the Mughals suspected them of **river piracy** (expelled from Hooghly). **Sebastião Gonzales**, a salt trader leading refugees from Arakan, with help from the king of **Bakla** and a Spanish fleet, seized **Sandwip** from the Mughals in **1607**, cheated Bakla, and set up a customs house; he then betrayed the Arakan king. A Goa fleet failed (a Dutch fleet, an ebb tide), and Arakan took Sandwip in **1616**. These Bay of Bengal misadventures sped the Portuguese decline. **Lecture caution:** the Portuguese changed the ocean but **never fully controlled it**; their monopoly was **partial and unstable**, with bases (Goa, Cochin, Hormuz, Malacca) that were footholds, not territorial control.

(c) The East India Companies: new commercial forms MUST KNOW

Company	Origins (Roy)
English EIC (1599/1600)	Meeting at Founders' Hall, London (**22 Sept 1599**); royal charter (**1600**) giving a **monopoly east of the Cape** (taxes to the Crown, regulated bullion export). Background: the Levant and Venice companies' failure; the destruction of **Antwerp** (1576); the expulsion of the **Hanseatic League** (1597); Ralph Fitch's overland journey; Drake and Cavendish exposing Iberian weakness. Investors included Levant Company men and Drake's and Frobisher's fleets.
Dutch VOC (1602)	The United Company: many small companies consolidated with a monopoly charter; strong cities and guilds, secure property, corporate capitalism (a "deviant medieval heritage"). In nature a **shipping cartel**, with large armed ships (500–1,000 tons). By **1630** it had thrown Portuguese trade into disarray, and its dominance of **Indonesia** pushed the English to focus on **India** and the Mughal court.
French (1604 → 1664)	Early failures (1604, 1615; Madagascar; the Compagnie des Indes 1642). **Colbert** (treasury from 1661) formed a new company in **1664**; a secure foothold in India only by **1700** (Pondicherry), then consistently profitable.

What was new (lecture: "European power was institutional as well as military")

- **Joint-stock finance**: capital pooled at an unmatched scale.
- **Monopoly charters**: state-backed exclusive rights.
- **Risk sharing** across many investors (reducing bankruptcy risk).
- **Forts, factories, harbours and armed shipping**: continuous power projection.
- A single firm could send **credible diplomatic embassies** to Indian courts (helped by English victories over the Portuguese off the Konkan, 1610–40).

Roy's strongest point (lecture): organisational difference mattered as much as military force.

Three problems of the English Company (1600–1813)

1. **Monopoly hard to enforce**: rival City merchants and **interlopers** (e.g. **Thomas Pitt**); oligarchic, opaque management; charges of corruption; bribes to local kings to stop competitors.
2. **Private trade by employees**: allowed as an incentive but impossible to restrain; officers spied on each other and used company agents for themselves. "The more powerful and capable the officer, the greater the conflict of interest."
3. **Embassies of limited use**: the Mughal writ did not cover the south; local governors (Surat, Hooghly) could obstruct; disputes over **customs** (bribes to be renewed with each new official) and over the **right to a mint** (coining silver needed Indian bankers).

(d) The scale and content of trade, 1600–1800

1600–1650

Spices (pepper, cloves, nutmeg)

→

1650–1750

Indian cotton textiles
, saltpetre (gunpowder), Chinese silk and porcelain

→

1750–1800

Chinese tea
; Indian
opium
pays for tea

- **Cotton cloth** was the EIC's main import around 1700; coloured Indian cottons set European **fashion** and design standards. Within Asia, Indian cottons paid for **spices** in Indonesia (Dutch) and for **slaves in Africa**; Persian horses balanced trade briefly.
- **Bengal** was the most important region in the 18th century (cotton, opium, saltpetre, sugar, silk), but Europeans exported at most 150 tons of Bengal silk a year in the 1730s, while **Asian merchants exported five times as much overland** in the 1750s.
- **American silver** was the key: Spanish conquest made silver cheaper in Europe than in India and China, and Indians had an "almost inexhaustible" demand for silver as a private asset. Money was dearer in Asia (high interest), so trade ran on **bullion**. New World tobacco and sugar fed the consumer boom; sugar profits built London's docks, banks and insurance.
- The EIC had about **50% of the textile market** by mid-century (French and Dutch shared the rest). A structural break at mid-century (politics); the French and Dutch companies ended, and the English one survived **only by reinventing itself as a colonial power**.

(e) Partners, employees, agents: Indian agency MUST KNOW

DEPENDENCE ON INDIAN INSTITUTIONS

Om Prakash: "the Europeans had **no option but to operate within the given organizational structure**": bankers, money-changers, merchant partners, artisans and shipwrights. **Asian traders controlled almost everything except the final sale and shipment by sea**: overland, inter-regional, river and caravan trade. Pedro Machado: Gujarati traders supplied textiles to Portuguese Mozambique and built an ivory trade. **No question of European dominance over trading institutions; the goal was stable partnerships.**

Bankers

Converted **silver bullion into coin**, lent money (high, seasonal, monthly-quoted interest), changed currencies (risky as the Mughal currency fragmented), and issued **promissory notes** (hundis) for remittance. After 1765 the **Jagatseths** lost importance, while **Gopaldas of Benares** and **Arjunji Nathji of Surat** prospered; bankers' networks even supplied **military intelligence**.

Coastal communities

Owned boats; loaded cargo at Bombay; pepper at Calicut; timber from Canara to the **Trincomalee** naval yard. **Dhows** (50–250 tons, lateen sails) carried coconut and copra; **dhoni** boats on the Madras–Ceylon route through the shallow Palk Strait. Some were **pirates** (Tavernier on the Mapillas, 1660s).

Brokers (chief contractors)

Took company **advances** and distributed contracts to an "army of under-contractors"; held an **information advantage** (language, supply sources); in the 17th c. often military or political men, in the 18th c. merchants. Relations combined **dependence and distrust**: fraud, threats and imprisonment.

Broker	Episode
Kasi Viranna (Madras, 1670s)	Indispensable to the EIC, yet Streynsham Master was told not to give "Verona" exclusive contracting powers
Khem Chand Shah (Balasore, 1670)	Squeezed between the Mughal governor and the company; his loyalty was questioned
Kola Venkadri (Masulipatnam, 1678–79)	Secretly negotiated with the king of Golkonda and was **imprisoned** by the English
Parsi vs Hindu merchants (Surat, 1730s)	Disputes over brokerage damaged relations
Amirchand (Bengal, 1756)	Conspired to dethrone **Siraj ud-Daula**; Clive suspected him of double-crossing and **penalised** him
Ananda Ranga Pillai (Pondicherry, 1740s)	Chief broker for the French; his **diary** explains how hard and unprofitable the broker's job was

"Contract": the words "contract" and "breach of contract" had **no Indian counterpart** for sales; Hindu and Islamic law dealt with **debt**, not sales, and were tied to religious identity rather than being the law of the land. Large advance-order purchasing was probably **new** with the companies. Written contracts specified quantity, price, dimensions, quality, advances and wages. Why bother without courts? They made **bookkeeping** easier and carried **moral** force (breaking one was "sinful").

(f) From merchants to landlords: the port towns MUST KNOW

- Three English territories: **Madras (c.1640)**, **Bombay (c.1660)** and **Calcutta (c.1690)**, each acquired amid threatened or actual war (Madras: the Mughal invasion of the Deccan; Bombay: **Shivaji's** threats; Calcutta: the Mughal attack in Bengal in the 1680s).
- In Surat, Hooghly and Masulipatnam the English were **tenants** sharing rights; in the three new towns they were **landlords**, with their own laws. Each had a fort (with the European population) plus Indian villages as suburbs; the two worlds transacted at arm's length until the 18th century.
- A **schism** between London directors and local officers: the founders, **Francis Day** (Madras), **George Oxenden and Gerald Aungier** (Bombay) and **Job Charnock** (Calcutta), paid from private means and were disgraced or chastised. Mutinies posing as **royalists**: **Edward Winter** (Madras, **1665**) and **Richard Keigwin** (Bombay, **1679**). Result: governors got wide powers, **including law-making**.
- Calcutta's fort was on the east bank (navigability; defence against the Dutch, French, Danes and Portuguese on the west bank). Bengali textile dealers migrated in (after **Saptagram** silted up); in the 1740s, **Maratha raids** made it a safe haven and its population doubled.

Why the port cities mattered (lecture)

New kinds of **political-commercial spaces**:

- **More autonomous** from inland powers;
- **More ocean-facing** from the outset;
- A greater role for **commercial law and contract enforcement** (predictable rules attracted capital and merchants, often **refugees from decaying states**);
- They became **bases for expanding Company power**.

Roy treats these cities as **a major turning point in both Indian Ocean and Indian history**. ("Port city sovereignty" is in the glossary.)

(g) State formation, 1707–1765, and the Company as a state

1707	**Aurangzeb dies**; the Mughal empire fragments: Awadh, Hyderabad and Bengal become independent; Marathas, Rajputs and Nayakas rise. Until about 1740 the three towns were still just trading settlements
1740s	Two lines merge, the **empowerment of merchants** and the **weakening of states**: Maratha raids weaken the Bengal nawab; a Carnatic succession dispute draws in the English and French
1740–1760	**Three Carnatic wars** (tied to the War of the Austrian Succession 1740–48 and the Seven Years' War 1756–63); the English prevail by 1760
1757–1764	Bengal: a dispute over the nawab's power to tax Europeans and their private trade; the English win (**Plassey 1757**, **Buxar 1764**), helped by moving troops between Madras and Calcutta and by Indian merchants under their protection
1764/65	The Company is recognised as **de facto ruler of Bengal** (the diwani, 1765); state revenue is used to buy cloth ("taxing the peasant to pay the artisan"); brokers are subordinated to paid officers who abuse weavers
1771	The English **zamindari court** of Calcutta (until 1765 the Company was "no more than a Mughal zamindar") extends its jurisdiction over all Bengal
1772	War debts force a large **loan from Parliament**, in exchange for closer regulation
1813	**End of the Company's trade monopoly**, pushed by private traders
1818	The Marathas subdued; the Company's empire takes its final shape

Transactions in knowledge (two-way)

European calico printers copied Indian techniques (Riello); British spinning drew on Indian cotton (Parthasarathi). Into India: navigation (the **telescope and compass** were unknown; heavy Indian ships used little iron), stimulating **Narsapur Peta** (a "syncretic" shipbuilding centre on the Coromandel), **European-style anchors** made from Indian iron, Dutch ironworks near Palakole, and princes casting **cannons** with European help.

From trade to empire (lecture's bridge point)

Trade did not mechanically produce empire, but it created the conditions that made empire possible: fortified settlements accumulated power; Company organisation **blurred trade and sovereignty** (merchant and quasi-state); **Mughal decline** opened space; commercial cities became **staging grounds for conquest**. Violence mattered, but Europeans **depended on Indian brokers, financiers and shipwrights**; **empire grew through entanglement, not simple replacement**. And Asian trade was **not purely peaceful before 1500** either.

DISCUSSION: IF EUROPEANS DEPENDED SO HEAVILY ON INDIAN MERCHANTS AND PRODUCERS, WHAT EXACTLY WAS NEW ABOUT EUROPEAN POWER?

Suggested answer: not superior commerce, since Asians controlled procurement, credit and most trade. What was new was **organisational** (joint-stock capital, monopoly charters, continuous corporate presence, credible diplomacy), **armed** (fortified ports, armed shipping, the *cartaz* system) and above all **institutional-territorial**: **port cities with their own law and sovereignty** that attracted Indian capital, and that the **Mughal collapse** let turn into bases for conquest. Roy's own framing is "a hybrid technological, institutional and political order".

11.4 Part III: synthesis and critique MUST KNOW

Chaudhuri	Roy
Macro-historical and **theoretical**	**Empirical** and political-economic
Focus on **unity and disunity**	Focus on **trade and institutional change**
Civilisational structures	**Merchant networks, companies, ports**
Longue durée (622–1750)	The **1500–1800 transformation**
Connected space as **theory**	Connected space as **commercial practice**

The lecture's verdict: they are **complementary, not opposed**: two ways of thinking about the same connected world.

Strengths of the "connected space" framework

- Breaks **national history** boundaries
- **Decentres Europe**
- Shows **mobility and interdependence**

Limits

- May **flatten local differences**
- May **privilege merchants** over labourers and peasants
- May **understate coercion, slavery and inequality**
- May make connection seem **smoother** than it was

"Connected for whom? On whose terms?"

CONCLUSION: THE INDIAN OCEAN AS A CONNECTED BUT UNEVEN WORLD

- **Unity did not mean sameness**: macro coherence coexisted with deep regional difference.
- **Trade was central but not the whole story**: ecology, religion, migration and empire also mattered.
- **European expansion transformed, but did not create, Indian Ocean connectivity**: long before 1500, the system already worked.
- It was a **connected, contested and constantly re-made** historical world.

"The Indian Ocean became historically significant not because it erased difference, but because it connected different worlds in durable, unequal, and transformative ways."

Glossaries from the lecture MUST KNOW (MCQS)

Chaudhuri's key terms	
Longue durée	Long-term historical structures and slow change
Invariance	Deep continuity despite surface variation
Structuralism	Search for underlying organising principles
Unity/disunity	Simultaneous connectedness and difference
Logical space	Conceptual field within which meaning and classification operate
Mapping	Projecting one structure onto another for comparison
Isomorphism	Structural equivalence between different forms
Temporal structure	The explanatory significance of different scales of time
Civilisational identity	Large cultural-historical formations like Islam or Confucian China

Roy's key terms	
Littoral	Coastal commercial zone
Joint-stock company	Capital pooled by shareholders with shared risk
Monopoly charter	Exclusive trading rights granted by the Crown
Broker	Intermediary linking the company and local producers or merchants
Factory	A **trading station**, not an industrial factory in the modern sense
Commercial law	Legal framework supporting contracts, property and trade
Port city sovereignty	Urban control that let merchants and companies shape governance
Indo-European trade	Trade linking Indian and European commercial systems within the wider Indian Ocean

SUMMARY OF SESSION 11

The Indian Ocean was a **connected space** (routes, commercial practice, migration, religion, conflict), **not uniform**, and not a prelude to Europe. **Chaudhuri** (Braudel + structuralism + semiotics + set theory) finds **unity in the large, disunity in the small** (the Möbius strip): four civilisations; the invariant ground floor of material life (bread vs rice, *ihram* ≅ Brahman dress, house = body); arid vs wet zones; nomad–sedentary symbiosis; four expansions from 618/622 to Plassey 1757; low-frequency events explain more; unity as a **mental construct** (Gödel, Foucault; "Asia is the contradiction of Europe"); and Arasaratnam's 750-vs-622 slip. **Roy:** India at the centre of the **great arc**; Gujarati, Mapilla, Chulia and Chetti merchants; ports not tied to empires; the **Portuguese** (Ceuta 1415, da Gama 1498 and 1502–3, Albuquerque, the cartaz, violence, decline after 1640; Steensgaard vs strong states; Gonzales and Sandwip); the **EIC 1600, VOC 1602, French 1664** (organisation: joint stock, charters; problems: monopoly, private trade, embassies); spices → textiles → tea, paid in American silver; **dependence on Indian bankers and brokers** (Kasi Viranna, Amirchand, Ananda Ranga Pillai); "contract"; the port towns **Madras, Bombay and Calcutta** as autonomous, law-making spaces; 1707–1765 state formation; the Company as a state (1771, 1772, 1813). **Trade created the conditions for empire through entanglement.** "Connected for whom?"

EXAM CORNER

1. "Unity in the large, disunity in the small." Explain Chaudhuri's argument about the unity of Indian Ocean history.
2. Compare Chaudhuri's and Roy's approaches to the Indian Ocean as a connected space.
3. "Europeans entered a crowded and functioning commercial world." Discuss with reference to Roy.
4. Why did the Portuguese fail to control Indian Ocean trade? (Violence, limits, Steensgaard vs strong states.)
5. How did trade create the conditions for empire? (Companies, port cities, Indian intermediaries, Mughal decline.)
6. "Connected for whom? On whose terms?" Critically assess the "connected space" framework.
7. **Essay link:** "European expansion transformed but did not create Indian Ocean connectivity." Use Bernstein (S7), Sen (S9), Guy and Ray (S10), Chaudhuri and Roy (S11).

MCQ facts: Chaudhuri, *JWH* 1993 (*Trade and Civilisation* 1985; *Asia Before Europe* 1990); period 622–1750/1757; Braudel's *Mediterranean* 1949; four civilisations; Arasaratnam wrote 750; Dali's *Persistence of Memory*; Gödel 1931; Dedekind 1872; Ceuta 1415; da Gama in Calicut May 1498 (Gujarati pilot); second voyage 1502–3; VOC 1602; EIC charter 1600 (meeting 22 Sept 1599); French company 1664 (Colbert); Madras c.1640, Bombay c.1660, Calcutta c.1690; Winter 1665; Keigwin 1679; Aurangzeb d. 1707; Parliament loan 1772; monopoly ended 1813; Narsapur Peta (shipbuilding).

PART ★

Synthesis and Exam Toolkit: Themes, Who's Who, Glossary, MCQ Practice, Answer Plans and the Last-Night Sheet

Use this part after reading the sessions, and again on the morning of the exam. Exam format (Lecture 16): **A** 10 MCQs × 0.5 = 5 · **B** 3 of 5 short answers × 10 = 30 · **C** 1 of 2–3 essays × 15 = 15. Total 50 marks, 2 hours, closed book.

S.1 Six threads that run through the whole course MUST KNOW

Examiners reward answers that **connect sessions**. Each thread below lists the sessions and the evidence to cite.

Thread	Core idea	Evidence across sessions
1. Uses of the past	The past is constructed, mobilised and invented for present needs	Hobsbawm: pattern, model, process; symbolic restoration; invented tradition (S1) · Orientalist, colonial and nationalist histories (S4) · BRI and Act East's selective "Silk Road" (S8–9) · the 1871 census hardening identities (S10)
2. Sources and their biases	Every source is socially located; corroborate	Source criticism and Droysen's four steps (S2) · travellers as evidence and interpretation; al-Shahrastani vs al-Biruni (S6) · *Akhbar*, *Marvels*, Ibn Battuta, Pires (S7) · Sen's dependence on Chinese texts (S9) · Rajendra's lone eulogy for the naval raid (S10)
3. Scale	City, region, nation, ocean, globe: each scale shows a different history	Global vs regional; Hall's multiple globalizations; Vasco da Gama at three scales (S3) · Hansen's city vs Bhattacharya's region (S8) · Chaudhuri's unity in the large vs small (S11)
4. Connectivity before Europe	Asia was connected long before 1500; Europe transformed but did not create it	Bernstein's monsoon trade, Baghdad to Canton (S7) · Silk Roads and Sogdians (S8) · maritime Buddhism (S9) · Tamil guilds and Quanzhou (S10) · Roy's "crowded world" (S11) · Frank vs Wallerstein (S3)
5. Trade and religion entangled	Merchants carried monks and gods; religion created trust, demand and institutions	Monk–merchant symbiosis in the pilgrims' accounts (S6) · Islam spread by traders (S7, S10) · *saptaratna*, Nandin the ship-owner, Faxian's voyage (S9) · Takuapa, Barus, Nagapattinam (S10) · Roy's Gujarati, Mapilla and Chulia communities (S11)
6. Centre vs periphery, and agency	Centres and peripheries are made; whose agency counts?	Colonial "India without history" — nationalist, Marxist and Subaltern responses (S4) · Bengal "peripheralised" (S8) · local agency at Ratu Boko and Purnavarman (S9–10) · Indian brokers and bankers vs companies (S11) · "Connected for whom?" (S11)

How do we know the past? S1 Why history · S2 Methods and sources · S3 Scales

↓

How has India's past been written? S4 Orientalist → Colonial → Nationalist → Marxist → Cambridge → Subaltern

↓

How did outsiders see India? S6 Chinese pilgrims and Arab writers

↓

How was India connected? S7 Sea (Baghdad–Canton) · S8 Land (Silk Roads) · S9 Buddhism at sea · S10 Religions on the move

↓

The big picture: S11 the Indian Ocean as a connected but uneven space

S.2 Who's who: the scholars to name in answers MUST KNOW

Name	S	Remember them for
Eric Hobsbawm	1	"The Social Function of the Past" (*Past & Present*, 1972): pattern, model, process; restoration; invention of tradition
Ranke · Droysen	2	"Wie es eigentlich gewesen" and source criticism · Droysen's *Historik* (heuristic, criticism, interpretation, presentation)
Matthew Lange	2	Comparative-historical analysis: within-case + comparative methods, macro units; Skocpol vs Bendix
Nadine Backerra (OT2)	2	Source criticism for cultural history; diplomatic correspondence
Immanuel Wallerstein	3, 8	Modern world-system: core, semi-periphery, periphery; South Asia as semi-periphery (criticised by Washbrook, Bayly, Ludden)
Thomas Hall · A. G. Frank · Chase-Dunn	3	Multiple globalizations and world-systems · Frank: one 5,000-year world system (*ReOrient*) · Chase-Dunn & Hall: many systems compared
William Jones · Prinsep · Cunningham	4	Asiatic Society 1784 · Brahmi deciphered 1834 · ASI, Buddhist decline thesis (challenged by H. P. Ray, S10)
James Mill · Elphinstone	4	*History of British India* (1818): Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation · "Tacitus of India"
Edward Said	4	*Orientalism* (1978): knowledge as power
D. D. Kosambi · R. S. Sharma · Romila Thapar · Irfan Habib	4	Marxist "new history": modes and relations of production; Indian feudalism (Sharma, also used by Davidson in S10)
Ranajit Guha	4	Subaltern Studies (1982), "history from below"; Gramsci's "subaltern"
Faxian · Xuanzang · Yijing	6, 8, 9	Chinese pilgrims (399–413; 629–645; 671–695); Yijing at Srivijaya
al-Shahrastani · al-Biruni · M. S. Khan	6	*Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal* (12th c.), secondary sources · al-Biruni's critical *Kitab al-Hind* · Khan's 1983 evaluation
William Bernstein	7	*A Splendid Exchange*, ch. 4: monsoon trade, Baghdad to Canton, India as hub
Valerie Hansen	8	*The Silk Road*: Chang'an, Sogdian tombs, the Hejiacun hoard, limited goods trade
Jayati Bhattacharya	8	"Old Routes, New Dreams" (JESHO 2021): Bengal's circulatory centrality; cotton and cowries; BRI and Act East
Tansen Sen	9	"Buddhism and the Maritime Crossings": against "maritime Silk Road"; transit zone; Sri Lanka and Tantra

Erik Zürcher · Xinru Liu · Heitzman	9	Long-distance vs contact transmission · monk–merchant reciprocity, *saptaratna* · monasteries near trade towns
T. N. Madan	10	*India's Religions*: plurality vs pluralism; folk vs intellectual pluralism; dharma ≠ religio
John Guy	10	Tamil merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist diaspora: Kutei, Purnavarman, Takuapa, Quanzhou
Himanshu Prabha Ray	10	Nagapattinam's Cudamanivihara; maritime cultural landscapes; multi-religious sacred geography
McKim Marriott	10	Parochialization and universalization (Great and Little traditions)
Fernand Braudel	2, 8, 11	*The Mediterranean* (1949); *longue durée*; model for Chaudhuri
K. N. Chaudhuri	11	Unity and disunity (JWH 1993): four civilisations; invariance; 622–1750
Tirthankar Roy	8, 11	*India in the World Economy*, ch. 4 (1500–1800); also Bengal's "parallel globalizations" (S8)
Om Prakash · Steensgaard	11	"Great arc"; Europeans worked within the Asian structure · the Portuguese as a "redistributive" enterprise

S.3 Glossary of key terms SUPPORTING

Anekantavada
Jain doctrine of the many-sidedness of reality; with syadvada (conditional assertion). Gandhi credited it for his pluralism.

Ainnurruvar / Manigramam / Nanadesi / Anjuvannam
Medieval south Indian merchant guilds active overseas (Takuapa, Barus 1088).

Cartaz
Portuguese pass that Asian ships had to buy from the Estado da India.

Circulation (vs diffusion)
Multi-directional movement and transformation of religion and culture, not one-way spread from a centre.

Connected histories
Histories that follow links across regions instead of treating nations or civilisations separately.

Cudamanivihara
Buddhist monastery at Nagapattinam built by Srivijaya's king with Chola grants (Leyden plates).

Dharma vs religio
Dharma is cosmic and moral order and duty; it encompasses law and society, unlike the Western "religion".

Effective vs symbolic restoration
Hobsbawm: real return to the past (rarely possible) vs restoring symbols of it (Warsaw's rebuilt old town).

Factory
Company trading station (warehouse and residence), not an industrial plant.

Heuristic
The first step of historical method: finding and collecting sources.

Invention of tradition
New practices presented as ancient to legitimise the present (Hobsbawm).

Isomorphism / mapping
Chaudhuri: exact structural correspondence between two sets / projecting one structure onto another (*ihram* ≅ Brahman ritual dress).

Joint-stock company
Capital pooled from many shareholders with shared risk (EIC 1600, VOC 1602).

Long-distance vs contact transmission
Zürcher and Sen: Buddhism jumped directly from India to China with Southeast Asia only a stopover, vs step-by-step spread.

Longue durée
Braudel: slow-changing long-term structures (geography, climate, material life).

Monsoon

Seasonal reversing winds (from the south-west in summer, the north-east in winter) that made Indian Ocean sailing predictable.

Orientalism
(1) Scholarly study of the East (Jones, Asiatic Society); (2) Said: Western discourse that constructs the East as inferior "Other" to dominate it.

Plurality vs pluralism
The fact of many religions vs the value or practice of negotiating coexistence (Madan, Lecture 10).

Sabao
Chinese-appointed headman of a Sogdian or foreign community (An Jia, Shi Wirkak).

Saptaratna
"Seven jewels" offered to Buddhist monasteries, which created demand for pearls, coral and lapis (Xinru Liu).

Subaltern
Subordinate groups (peasants, workers, tribals, women); from Gramsci; Guha's Subaltern Studies.

Suvarnadvipa / Suvarnabhumi
"Island/Land of Gold": Indian names for Southeast Asia (Sumatra), in Jatakas.

Transit zone
Sen: early maritime Southeast Asia, where monks changed ships, before Buddhist institutions took root (5th c.).

Vishnupada
Sacred footprint of Vishnu; Purnavarman's inscription (c.450) makes the king's footprints Vishnu's.

World-system
Wallerstein: a unit with a single division of labour and multiple cultures; "a world-system, not a system of the world".

Yupa
Vedic sacrificial post; Kutei's seven stone yupas (late 4th c.) are the earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia.

Zomia
James Scott's term for the stateless uplands of mainland Southeast Asia, extended by van Schendel.

S.4 MCQ practice (30 questions) MUST KNOW

Answers are at the end of the list. Each MCQ is worth only 0.5 marks, so don't spend long on them in the exam; but these facts also make your written answers precise.

1. Hobsbawm's "The Social Function of the Past" appeared in: (a) *Annales* 1949 (b) *Past & Present* 1972 (c) JWH 1993 (d) JESHO 2021
2. Rebuilding Warsaw's old town after WWII is Hobsbawm's example of: (a) effective restoration (b) symbolic restoration (c) innovation (d) genealogy
3. The four steps of Droysen's method are heuristic, source analysis (criticism), interpretation and: (a) synthesis (b) presentation (c) comparison (d) archiving
4. Who classified South Asia as part of the "semi-periphery"? (a) Frank (b) Wallerstein (c) Bayly (d) Hall
5. The Asiatic Society of Bengal was founded in 1784 by: (a) Prinsep (b) Jones (c) Mill (d) Müller
6. The Brahmi script was deciphered in 1834 by: (a) Cunningham (b) Colebrooke (c) Prinsep (d) Wilkins
7. James Mill's periodisation of Indian history was: (a) ancient–medieval–modern (b) Hindu–Muslim–British (c) Vedic–Buddhist–Islamic (d) feudal–capitalist
8. Subaltern Studies was launched (1982) by: (a) R. S. Sharma (b) Romila Thapar (c) Ranajit Guha (d) Bipan Chandra
9. Al-Shahrastani's book is: (a) *Kitab al-Hind* (b) *Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal* (c) *Fihrist* (d) *Rihla*
10. Which pilgrim studied at Srivijaya and wrote about 56 monks? (a) Faxian (b) Xuanzang (c) Yijing (d) Kang Senghui
11. The *Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind* (c.851) is associated with: (a) Sulayman the merchant (b) Ibn Battuta (c) Buzurg ibn Shahriyar (d) Tomé Pires
12. The Canton massacre of foreign merchants in 878 occurred during the rebellion of: (a) An Lushan (b) Huang Chao (c) the Red Turbans (d) the Taiping
13. "Silk Road" (*Seidenstrasse*) was coined in 1877 by: (a) Sven Hedin (b) Aurel Stein (c) Ferdinand von Richthofen (d) Paul Pelliot
14. The Hejiacun hoard is evidence that: (a) Roman gold flooded China (b) relatively few imported goods reached Chang'an (c) Sogdians were only merchants (d) Buddhism was banned

15. A *sabao* was: (a) a Buddhist relic (b) a headman of a foreign community (c) a Tang market tax (d) a Tibetan envoy
16. Stephen Dale's term highlighted by Bhattacharya is: (a) Spice Road (b) Cotton Road (c) Tea-Horse Road (d) Jade Road
17. India's Act East Policy was announced in: (a) 1991 (b) 2004 (c) 2013 (d) 2014
18. Sen says the Chinese became actively involved in Indian Ocean shipping only from the: (a) 2nd c. BCE (b) 5th c. (c) 10th c. (d) 15th c.
19. The earliest Buddhist inscription in Southeast Asia (5th c., Kedah) was commissioned by: (a) Purnavarman (b) Buddhagupta, a sea captain (c) Mulavarman (d) Balaputradeva
20. Atisa went to Srivijaya in 1012 to study under: (a) Vajrabodhi (b) Amoghavajra (c) Dharmakirti (d) Jayabhadra
21. The 792 Ratu Boko inscription names a Javanese: (a) Shiva temple (b) Abhayagiri Vihara "of the Sinhalese" (c) mosque (d) Chola fort
22. The earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia are the yupas of: (a) Purnavarman at Bogor (b) Mulavarman at Kutei (c) Bhadravarman at My Son (d) Devanika at Champasak
23. The Klong Thom touchstone carries the earliest Tamil inscription in Southeast Asia and belonged to: (a) a Brahman priest (b) a goldsmith ("Perumpatan") (c) a Chola general (d) a Buddhist nun
24. The bilingual Tamil–Chinese inscription of 1281 dedicates a Shiva temple at: (a) Guangzhou (b) Quanzhou (c) Nanjing (d) Hangzhou
25. The Cudamanivihara at Nagapattinam was built by a king of: (a) Champa (b) Srivijaya (c) Pagan (d) Sri Lanka
26. Madan: "Plurality" refers to: (a) the value of coexistence (b) the fact that many religions exist (c) secular law (d) conversion
27. Chaudhuri's four civilisations are Islam, Sanskritic India, Southeast Asia and: (a) Christian Europe (b) Confucian China (c) Swahili Africa (d) Mongol Asia
28. Arasaratnam wrongly dated the start of Chaudhuri's period to 750; Chaudhuri's actual starting point is: (a) 618 (b) 622 (c) 711 (d) 1000
29. Vasco da Gama reached Calicut in May 1498 guided by: (a) an Arab pilot from Aden (b) a Gujarati pilot (c) a Chinese pilot (d) a Portuguese chart only
30. Steensgaard explained the Portuguese failure as: (a) strong Asian states (b) a "redistributive", pre-capitalist enterprise (c) disease (d) Dutch sabotage only

ANSWERS

1 b · 2 b · 3 b · 4 b · 5 b · 6 c · 7 b · 8 c · 9 b · 10 c · 11 a · 12 b · 13 c · 14 b · 15 b · 16 b · 17 d · 18 c · 19 b · 20 c · 21 b · 22 b · 23 b · 24 b · 25 b · 26 b · 27 b · 28 b · 29 b · 30 b

More quick facts: Asiatic Society patron = Warren Hastings · "sheet anchor" = Chandragupta = Sandrocottas (325 BC) · Kosambi = means and relations of production · Xuanzang met Harsha at Kanauj · Zheng He: 7 voyages, 1405–33 · Pires: 84 languages at Malacca · An Lushan rebellion 755–763 · Nestorian stele 781 · BRI 2013 · Kanshin 750: three Brahman monasteries at Guangzhou · Leyden plates (Rajaraja I and Rajendra I) · Cudamanivihara demolished 1867 · census categories from 1871 · Khalsa 1699 · EIC 1600 · VOC 1602 · French company 1664 · Madras c.1640, Bombay c.1660, Calcutta c.1690 · EIC monopoly ended 1813.

S.5 Short-answer plans (10 marks each, about 250–350 words) MUST KNOW

Formula for every short answer: (1) one-line definition or thesis naming the scholar; (2) two or three explained points, each with a **named example, date or place**; (3) a brief critical note or limitation; (4) a one-line conclusion linking to the course theme. Write **paragraphs, not bullets**.

Q. Doctrine vs lived religion in India

Thesis: religion is more than belief (belief → practice → experience → social life). ¶ **Doctrine:** texts and orthodoxies: Veda and Manusmriti, the Quran and sharia (the ulama, Barani), the Khalsa *rahit*. ¶ **Lived:** food, pilgrimage, festivals; Sufi shrines shared by Hindus and Muslims; Mapilla customs; Marriott's little traditions; Madan's **folk pluralism**; temples as economic institutions. ¶ **Why the gap matters:** the colonial census (1871) and the Judeo-Christian model read religion through doctrine and hardened identities; lived religion shows porous boundaries (the Nagapattinam bronzes). ¶ Conclusion: study religion through society, not texts alone.

Q. Why "maritime Silk Road" is misleading (Sen)

Richthofen's 1877 term was extended to every route. ¶ Silk was not the main sea cargo (beads, pearls, then incense, pepper, porcelain). ¶ It over-emphasises China (Chinese shipping only from the 10th c.) and erases Southeast Asia, India and the Middle East (Austronesians, Funan/Oc Eo, Indo-Roman trade). ¶ It is also politically loaded today (BRI's 21st-century Maritime Silk Road; Bhattacharya: selective use of the past). ¶ Alternative: a multi-centred maritime Asia.

Q. Hansen's urban lens vs Bhattacharya's regional lens

Both reject one road and centres-only history. ¶ **Hansen:** Chang'an; archaeology (An Jia, Shi Wirkak, the Hejiacun hoard, pawn tickets); cosmopolitanism; few goods, many people; decline after An Lushan and the bans of 843/845. ¶ **Bhattacharya:** Bengal as a hinge of land, river and sea; cotton and cowries; colonial restructuring; BRI and Act East. ¶ Different scales reveal different Silk Roads; centres and peripheries are made.

Q. How useful are foreign travellers' accounts?

Travel writing = observation + memory + interpretation. ¶ Advantages: eyewitness, details Indians did not record, comparisons (Faxian's Gupta India; Xuanzang's Harsha and Nalanda). ¶ Limits: language, religious lens (Buddhist pilgrims), hearsay (al-Shahrastani never visited India and wrote from Arabic secondary sources), exaggeration (*Marvels*). ¶ Method: corroborate with inscriptions, coins and archaeology; al-Biruni as the critical counterpoint. ¶ Conclusion: indispensable but must be read critically.

Q. Chaudhuri's "unity in the large, disunity in the small"

Braudel's model applied to the Indian Ocean (622–1750). ¶ Möbius strip analogy. ¶ Unity: transcontinental trade, the monsoon, an invariant material ground floor, four expansions to Plassey. ¶ Disunity: four civilisations; bread vs rice; arid vs wet. ¶ Unity is a mental construct (Gödel; Arasaratnam's critique). ¶ Lecture: "connected, not uniform".

Q. Indian agency in Indo-European trade (Roy)

A crowded world before 1500 (Gujarati, Mapilla, Chulia and Chetti merchants). ¶ Europeans "had no option but to operate within the given structure" (Om Prakash): bankers (minting, hundis; the Jagatseths), brokers (Kasi Viranna, Amirchand, Ananda Ranga Pillai), coastal shippers, shipwrights (Narsapur Peta). ¶ Relations of dependence and distrust; "contract" was a new institution. ¶ Empire grew through entanglement. ¶ But also coercion of weavers after 1765.

S.6 Essay plans (15 marks, about 600–900 words) MUST KNOW

ESSAY 1: "INDIAN OCEAN CONNECTIVITY WAS TRANSFORMED, NOT CREATED, BY EUROPEANS." DISCUSS.

Intro: define connectivity (structured interaction across distance); thesis: Europeans entered a working system and reorganised it institutionally and violently. ¶ **1. Pre-1500 system:** monsoon and segmented trade, Baghdad to Canton, India as hub (Bernstein); Arab/Persian, Gujarati and Tamil merchants; Chaudhuri's unity in the large. ¶ **2. Religion and diaspora:** Buddhism at sea (Sen), Tamil guilds and temples from Takuapa to Quanzhou (Guy), multi-religious Nagapattinam (Ray). ¶ **3. The Portuguese:** violence, the cartaz, forts, but partial control and decline after 1640 (Steensgaard vs strong states). ¶ **4. Companies:** joint stock, charters, forts; dependence on Indian bankers and brokers; textiles and silver. ¶ **5. Transformation:** port cities with their own law → state formation 1707–65 → empire (Plassey, Buxar, 1765). ¶ **Critique:** "connected for whom?"; coercion of weavers; slavery. ¶ **Conclusion:** continuity of networks and rupture of sovereignty.

ESSAY 2: TRACE THE DEVELOPMENT OF INDIAN HISTORIOGRAPHY FROM ORIENTALISM TO SUBALTERN STUDIES (THE PROFESSOR'S MODEL ESSAY; SEE THE FRONT MATTER)

Intro: each school answered the colonial claim that "India has no history". ¶ **Orientalists:** Jones (1784), Prinsep (1834), the "sheet anchor": achievements, but a golden-age and Brahmanical bias (Said). ¶ **Colonial:** Mill (1818): Hindu–Muslim–British, despotism, the justification of rule; Elliot & Dowson. ¶ **Nationalist:** golden ages, Hindu Polity (Jayaswal), Rajput heroism: pride but communal tendencies. ¶ **Marxist:** Kosambi, Sharma (feudalism), Thapar, Habib: economic structures and class. ¶ **Cambridge School:** elite interest politics. ¶ **Subaltern:** Guha (1982), history from below; critique of elitism. ¶ **Conclusion:** historiography reflects the politics of its present (Hobsbawm).

ESSAY 3: "RELIGION TRAVELLED BECAUSE PEOPLE TRAVELLED." DISCUSS WITH REFERENCE TO INDIAN RELIGIONS IN ASIA

Intro: from diffusion to circulation; Madan's plural and lived religion. ¶ **Agents:** merchants, Brahmans, monks, rulers, artisans. ¶ **Buddhism:** monk–merchant reciprocity (Liu, *saptaratna*), Faxian's voyage, the transit zone (Sen), Srivijaya and Sri Lanka, Atisa. ¶ **Hinduism and kingship:** Kutei yupas, Purnavarman's Vishnupada (local appropriation), Takuapa guilds, Quanzhou temples (Guy). ¶ **Hybridity and reverse flows:** Nagapattinam (Srivijayan and Chinese gifts; Schalk's three Buddhisms; Ray); Balaputradeva at Nalanda. ¶ **Limits:** antagonism (Faxian's "Brahmin" merchants), source bias. ¶ **Conclusion:** religion was carried, translated and reinterpreted, not copied.

ESSAY 4: "THERE IS NO SINGLE SILK ROAD." DISCUSS

Richthofen's 1877 coinage vs many routes. ¶ Overland: Hansen's Chang'an, Sogdians, archaeology, change over time. ¶ Southern: Bhattacharya's Bengal (cotton, cowries), colonial rerouting. ¶ Maritime: Sen's critique; Bernstein's sea route. ¶ Modern uses: BRI, Act East, BCIM (Hobsbawm's invented past). ¶ Scale and centre/periphery. ¶ Conclusion: multiple, layered, dynamic networks; the lens decides what we see.

S.7 Last-night revision sheet (one page) MUST KNOW

S1 Hobsbawm: past = pattern / model / process; restoration (effective vs symbolic: Warsaw, Zapata); invention; genealogy; chronology; history can analyse change but not predict.

S2 Methods: heuristics → criticism (external and internal) → interpretation → presentation (Droysen); primary/secondary/tertiary sources; Rankean, Annales, Marxist, Subaltern, Cliometric schools; Lange's CHA (within-case + comparative; macro); Backerra on cultural history.

S3 Scales: global (connections) vs regional (constitution); Wallerstein's core/semi-periphery/periphery; Hall's multiple globalizations; Frank (one system) vs Chase-Dunn & Hall (many); nation, region, globe; da Gama at three scales.

S4 Historiography: Orientalists (Jones 1784, Prinsep 1834, 325 BC sheet anchor) → Said → colonial (Mill 1818, Hindu–Muslim–British; Elphinstone; Elliot & Dowson) → nationalist (golden age, Jayaswal) → Marxist (Kosambi, Sharma, Thapar, Habib) → Cambridge (interests) → Subaltern (Guha 1982, from below).

S6 Travellers: Faxian (399–413, Vinaya, back by sea), Xuanzang (Harsha, Nalanda, 657 texts), Yijing (by sea, Srivijaya, 56 monks); al-Shahrastani (12th c., secondary, systematic, errors) vs al-Biruni (critical, Sanskrit). Corroborate.

S7 Bernstein: monsoon; segmented trade; Abbasid–Tang golden age; *Akhbar* c.851; Huang Chao 878; the Mongol window (Ibn Battuta); Zheng He 1405–33; Malacca (Pires); India the hub.

S8 Silk Roads: Richthofen 1877; no single road; Hansen (Chang'an, Sogdian *sabao* tombs, Hejiacun, few goods; An Lushan 755; bans 843/845) vs Bhattacharya (Bengal hinge; Cotton Road; cowries; colonial restructuring; LEP/AEP 2014, BRI 2013); seven lenses; centres are made.

S9 Sen: "maritime Silk Road" misleading; trade and Buddhism embedded; long-distance transmission; Southeast Asia a transit zone until the 5th c. (Buddhagupta); Srivijaya (Yijing, Atisa); Sri Lanka (relics, Tantra, Abhayagiri, Ratu Boko 792); maritime links outlast land; limits (Chinese sources, local agency, merchants, gender).

S10 Religions: plurality ≠ pluralism; internal diversity; lived religion; 1871 census; Madan (dharma, 1991 figures, Hindu "federation", folk vs intellectual pluralism, Gandhi 1913); Guy (Kutei, Purnavarman, Klong Thom, Takuapa, Barus 1088, Quanzhou 1281); Ray (Cudamanivihara, Leyden plates, hybrid bronzes, guilds, against Cunningham).

S11 Indian Ocean: connected ≠ uniform; Chaudhuri (Braudel; unity in the large; four civilisations; bread vs rice; 622–1757; construct); Roy (great arc; Portuguese 1498 → decline 1640; EIC 1600, VOC 1602; Indian brokers and bankers; Madras, Bombay, Calcutta; 1707–65 → empire); "connected for whom?"

FIVE SENTENCES TO DROP INTO ALMOST ANY ANSWER

1. "The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness" (Hobsbawm), and every present rewrites it.
2. Every source is evidence and interpretation at once; corroboration is the historian's discipline.
3. The scale we choose (city, region, ocean, globe) decides which history becomes visible.
4. Asia was connected long before 1500; Europe transformed but did not create that connectivity.
5. Religion travelled because people travelled, and it was translated, not simply transplanted.